



GOVERNMENT OF INDIA



BRICS countries have been the main engines of global economic growth over the years...have contributed to the development of the whole humanity... have emerged as a major factor in a peaceful, prosperous and multi polar world.

- Shri Narendra Modi, Prime Minister



Advancing Practical Cooperation For People-Centric Development



BUILDING FOR RESILIENCE, INNOVATION,
COOPERATION AND SUSTAINABILITY

BRICS SUMMIT



12 - 13 September 2026



New Delhi, India

As BRICS completes twenty years of its establishment, India's Chairship is pursuing a people-centric and humanity-first approach under the overall theme of "Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability".

HIGHLIGHTS

400+ Meetings

30+ Cities in India

20+ Ministerials

10,000+ Participants



www.brics2026.gov.in



BRICS2026India



brics2026



BricsIndia2026



BRICS India

CBC 14129/13/0024/2627



₹151 crore forensic science lab approved at Sheikh Sarai

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Expenditure Finance Committee (EFC), headed by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, has approved the construction of a state-of-the-art Regional Forensic Science Laboratory (RFSL) at Sheikh Sarai. A budget of ₹151.81 crore has also been approved for the project. The Chief Minister has set a target for the Public Works Department (PWD) to complete construction within two years.

The new RFSL at Sheikh Sarai will be built on a plot measuring approximately 6,300 square metres, with a total built-up area of 18,300 square metres. The building, to be constructed by the PWD, will be developed as an integrated forensic facility, keeping in mind the specialised requirements of scientific investigations.

In a statement, the chief minister's office said the new Regional Forensic Science Laboratory would help the Home Department and Delhi Police meet the requirements arising from the new criminal laws. The Bharatiya Nyaya



Sanhita, Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita and Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam have led to a significant increase in the demand for forensic investigations in criminal cases. The new regional FSL will help meet this growing demand and strengthen the capacity required for scientific investigations in criminal cases. The new RFSL will strengthen the scientific support provided by the existing FSL in Rohini.

Forensic science is essential not only for scientific investigation in criminal cases but also for criminal trials and the process of delivering justice. The new laboratory will also strengthen the scientific support required to maintain law and order in the capital. The districts of South, Southeast and Central Delhi will benefit particularly from the facility. Delhi Home Minister Ashish Sood said the new regional FSL would make the examina-

tion of evidence related to cases and the submission of forensic reports faster and more efficient once it becomes operational. The facility will strengthen evidence-based investigations and help ensure the timely disposal of criminal cases in courts. The construction of the new Regional Forensic Science Laboratory will further strengthen Delhi's forensic infrastructure for scientific investigations.

LG clears health scheme for construction workers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu has approved the Delhi Building Workers Health Scheme for registered building and other construction workers and their eligible dependent family members, according to a statement issued on Saturday. The scheme was earlier approved by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and the Delhi Cabinet.

"Under the scheme, every registered construction worker and their eligible spouse will receive an annual health check-up, along with cashless outpatient consultation, diagnostics, medicines and inpatient treatment through a network of empanelled hospitals functioning at CGHS rates," the statement said. The scheme will cover emergency treatment, occupational diseases, chronic illnesses, specialised care, maternal healthcare and rehabilitation, with treatment available up to ₹2 lakh per beneficiary annually, subject to an overall family limit of ₹10 lakh a year, it said.

"In the event of a worksite accident or medical emer-



gency, beneficiaries may also avail treatment at the nearest non-empanelled hospital, which will be deemed provisionally empanelled for the limited duration of such treatment," the statement said. The Delhi Building and Other Construction Workers Welfare (DBOCWW) Board, an autonomous statutory body set up in 2002, registers construction workers and administers welfare schemes for them from the cess collected from construction employers. More than 2.7 lakh build-

ing and construction workers are currently registered as live members with the board. Given the technical and specialised nature of the scheme, it will be implemented through a Project Implementing Agency to be engaged initially for three years, extendable by another year subject to a performance review, officials said. Mobile Medical Units will also be provided to transport workers from worksites to empanelled hospitals, coordinate health

screenings and spread awareness, the statement said. A dedicated software system will digitally manage beneficiary records, treatment history and claims processing, it said. To ensure transparency and financial discipline, every claim submitted by the Project Implementing Agency will undergo third-party verification and other checks deemed necessary by the board before payment is released. Periodic reports will also be submitted to the board to track the scheme's progress.

Namo Bharat piers on Ghaziabad-Meerut stretch to become advertising platforms

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

With Nam Bharat trains carrying around 1.1 lakh commuters daily, the piers and portal structures along the Ghaziabad-Meerut stretch are set to become a new outdoor advertising platform, offering brands visibility across busy roads, markets and residential areas. The National Capital Region Transport Corporation (NCRTC) has invited bids for licensing advertising rights on piers and portal structures along the more than 50-km Sahibabad-Modipuram section of the Delhi-Meerut Nam Bharat corridor.

Located largely along road medians, the piers are positioned alongside highways and arterial roads with heavy vehicular movement and pass through densely populated residential areas, commercial establishments and busy markets in Ghaziabad and



Meerut, NCRTC said. The corporation said the advertising spaces could offer branding opportunities to businesses, educational institutions, hospitals, real estate companies and food and beverage chains located along the route.

The corridor currently caters to around 1.1 lakh commuters every day and has crossed 4.5 crore passenger journeys, reflecting the growing use of Nam Bharat services in the region, it said. The initiative is aimed at creating an outdoor advertising ecosystem along the corridor

while generating non-fare revenue for NCRTC, according to the transport corporation.

The selected licensee will be responsible for the design, fabrication, installation, operation and maintenance of the advertising infrastructure in accordance with the prescribed requirements, it mentioned. The Sahibabad-Modipuram stretch is surrounded by industrial areas, educational hubs and residential neighbourhoods, adding to the potential reach of the advertising spaces, NCRTC said.

Govt plans AI upgrade for bus management system

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government, which has been seeking to expand its public bus fleet, is planning to upgrade its existing Bus Management System (BMS) by integrating artificial intelligence (AI) and machine learning to provide better public transport services, officials said on Saturday.

Currently, the Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) has around 6,269 buses, of which more than 4500 are electric. These buses are operated from 52 bus depots across the city.

The proposal comes a month after Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the Government is looking to increase its bus fleet to 14,000 by 2028-29, and that the number of bus depots could go up to 90.

"With the number of electric buses increasing in DTC, the Government plans to hire a company to study the current operational structure of the system and then scale



up to create an AI-enabled Bus Management Software for management and monitoring of operation of electric and CNG or other fuelled buses," an official said.

The DTC has issued a tender requesting proposals from different types of experts in this field, he added.

According to the project plan, the Bus Management System (BMS) will provide functionality for issuance, allocation and management of Electronic Ticketing Machines (ETMs).

The system will also enable depot-wise and duty-wise mapping of ETMs to buses, drivers, and conductors, along with tracking of issuance,

return, status, and usage.

"The BMS will have to be fully integrated with fare collection systems to ensure seamless data synchronisation, validation of ticketing data, reconciliation of revenue and operational monitoring and reporting without manual interventions. The software will also be required to schedule DTC bus routes if any changes are made in real time by the traffic police," the plan read.

The proposed Bus Management System (BMS) for Delhi's public bus fleet will incorporate AI and Machine Learning (ML) capabilities to improve efficiency, punctuality and maintenance.

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given to the general public that I, Shreya Pandey, daughter of Shri Panjaj Pandey, resident of House No. 79, Block-H, Jai Vihar, Phase-1, Najafgarh, South-West Delhi, New Delhi-110043, hereby declare that my name has inadvertently been incorrectly recorded in my Aadhaar Card as "Shriya Pandey". My correct and actual name is "Shreya Pandey". I, Shreya Pandey, hereby declare for all concerned persons, institutions and records that in place of "Shriya Pandey", my correct name "Shreya Pandey" shall be used and treated as such. I have complied with the necessary legal formalities in connection with the correction of the aforesaid spelling of my name. Shreya Pandey, Daughter of Shri Panjaj Pandey, House No. 79, Block-H, Jai Vihar, Phase-1, Najafgarh, South-West Delhi, New Delhi-110043
Date: 12.09.2026, Place: New Delhi

Public Notice
This is to inform the general public that Mrs. Imrana W/o Chand Mohammad is the owner of the Residential House, two-storied, area measuring 133.33 sq. yds. (equivalent to 111.54 sq. mtrs.), comprised in Plot No. 181, situated in Dhamra Road (village Naya Gaon), Pargana Baran, Tehsil & District Bulandshahr, Uttar Pradesh through Gift Deed (husband to wife) dated 07.08.2026 as per no. 12266 executed by Mr. Chand Mohammad S/o Mr. Jakir Hussain in favour of his wife Mrs. Imrana in respect of said property. Mrs. Imrana W/o Chand Mohammad is in the process of mortgaging the said Property with SMFG India Credit Co. Ltd. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 7 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 7-days period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of my client.

PUBLIC NOTICE
My husband late Sh. Anil Kumar Singh S/o Sh. Bodhan Singh R/o B-346, First Floor, Dayanand, Colony, Lajpat Nagar -4, Delhi-110024, had booked a Flat No-O-2301, Superch ORB, project, situated at Plot No-03, Sector-74, Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh-201301, after his death I request the Developers to transfer the above property on my name along with My son Mr. Navin Kumar Singh S/o late Sh. Anil Kumar Singh R/o 230, Saket Enclave, Phase-1, Kapra Amberpet, Hayderabad, Telangana-500013, if anyone have objection, may contact to M/s SUPRETECH ORB PROJECT PRIVATE LIMITED located, at Plot No- GH-01A, Sector 74, Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301, Within Fifteen Day, Published By Mrs. Meena Singh, W/o late Sh. Anil Kumar Singh.

PUBLIC NOTICE
General public is hereby informed that my client Leel Kumar Gupta (UID 9936 0357 5261), S/o Shri Kashmiri Lal, R/o 285, Sector-9, Shastri Nagar, Meerut, U.P. 250004, is the exclusive & absolute owner of property No. 415 alongwith its whole of the structure with roof/terrace rights, situated at Mohalla Maharam, Pandav Road, 301, Road, Shahdara, Delhi-110032, who acquired the said property after the death of his mother-in-law, Smt. Maya Devi, D/o Shri Devi Dutt, wife of Late Shri Bihari Lal Mahajan, by operation of law as sole legal heir of the said deceased. Smt. Maya Devi had purchased the same vide proper Sale Deed duly regd. No. 484, Book No. 1, Volume No. 3319, on pages 148 to 150, dated 11.12.1963, in the office of S.R.I. Gate, Delhi. Now my client wants to dispose of the above said property. Any person or persons having any right, title or interest by way of inheritance or claim against the said property should send their claim in writing to the undersigned alongwith the documentary evidence in support of the said claim thereof within 07 days from the date of publication of the said notice, failing which such claims shall be deemed to have been waived.

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given to the General Public on behalf of my client (HDFC Bank Ltd.) that Smt. Geeta Devi Jindal is claiming to be the owner of One Alimrah area measuring 23.33 sq.ft., built up eastern portion of First Floor and Entire Second Floor with terrace rights area measuring 128 sq.yds. built on property bearing no. 4233 & 4234, area measuring 266 sq.yds., situated at Chhatra Gossain, Jogiwara, Nai Sarak, Delhi 110006; vide Sale Deed dated 18.05.2001 executed by Sh. Upender Kumar (Doc. No. 2018). It has been informed by the Owner that third page of said sale deed has wrongly captured property address as bearing no. 3233 & 3234 instead of correct number 4233 & 4234, which seems to be clerical mistake as all other places correct address is mentioned. All persons are hereby informed that above mentioned Owner wants to mortgage the said property & intends to obtain loan from my client (i.e. HDFC Bank Ltd.) against the said property. If anybody has any objection/s upon the ownership of above owner over the said property, its mortgage/litigation, and any other objections, kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 03 days of this presentation.

PUBLIC NOTICE
General public is hereby informed that my client Leel Kumar Gupta (UID 9936 0357 5261), S/o Shri Kashmiri Lal, R/o 285, Sector-9, Shastri Nagar, Meerut, U.P. 250004, is the exclusive & absolute owner of property No. 416 alongwith its whole of the structure with roof/terrace rights, situated at Mohalla Maharam, Pandav Road, 301, Road, Shahdara, Delhi-110032, who acquired the said property after the death of his sister-in-law, Smt. Pushpa Devi, D/o Shri Behari Lal, W/o V.D. Gupta, by operation of law as sole legal heir of the said deceased. Smt. Pushpa Devi had purchased the same vide proper Sale Deed duly regd. No. 5286, Book No. 1, Volume No. 1106, on pages 44 to 47, dated 22.05.1964, in the office of S.R.I. Delhi. Now my client wants to dispose of the above said property. Any person or persons having any right, title or interest by way of inheritance or claim against the said property should send their claim in writing to the undersigned alongwith the documentary evidence in support of the said claim thereof within 07 days from the date of publication of the said notice, failing which such claims shall be deemed to have been waived. Rakesh KumarAdvocate

KAMAL KANT GUPTA (ADVOCATE)
Unit No. FF-2, First Floor, Mahalaxmi Metro Tower, Sec-4, Vashali, Ghaziabad, UP. Office: 0120-4198504. Mobile: 9810063351. Email: kamalkantgupta74@gmail.com

SMFG Grihashakti
Naya Awaaz Naya Vishwas

SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd.

Corporate Off.: 503 & 504, 5th Floor, G-Block, Inspire BKC, BKC Main Road, Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra (E), Mumbai - 400051.
Regd. Off.: Commerzone IT Park, Tower B, 1st Floor, No. 111, Mount Poonamallee Road, Porur, Chennai - 600116, TN

SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES

E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE OF 30 DAYS FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE ASSETS UNDER THE SECURITISATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002 READ WITH PROVISION TO RULE 8(6) OF THE SECURITY INTEREST (ENFORCEMENT) RULES, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the Public in General and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below listed immovable properties ("Secured Assets") charged to the Secured Creditor, the Possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd. (hereinafter referred to as SMHFC) ("Secured Creditor"), will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is" and "Whatever there is" on the date and time mentioned herein below, for recovery of the dues mentioned herein below and further interest and other expenses thereon till date of realization, due to SMHFC Secured Creditor from the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) mentioned herein below.

Sl. No.	Name of the Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) LAN	Description of the Properties	Reserve Price : Earnest Money Deposit :	Date & Time of E-Auction	Date of EMD Submission
1.	Lan No. 609139211642361 & 609139511706580 1. Damber Singh S/o. Pati Singh Saud 2. Parvati Devi W/o. Damber Singh	All The Piece And Parcel Of Property Of Area Measuring 75 Sq. Yds Right Side Portion Of Second Floor, Without Roof Rights, Built Up Property No. 1100, Gali No. 10, Out Of Area Measuring 150 Sq. Yds., Out Of Kharsa No. 93, Situated At Govind Puri, Kalka Ji, New Delhi-110019.	Rs 36,90,000/- Rs. 36,99,000/-	21.10.2026 at 11.00 AM to 01.00 PM	20.10.2026

Details terms and conditions of the sale are as below and the details are also provided in our/secured creditor's website at the following link website address (<https://BidDeal.in> and <https://www.grishashakti.com/pdf/E-Auction.pdf>) The Intending Bidders can also contact : Ashish Kaushal, on his Mob. No. 8527134222, E-mail : Ashish.Kaushal@grishashakti.com, and Mr. Niloy Dey, on his Mob. 9855619157, E-mail : Niloy.Dey@grishashakti.com

Place : Delhi
Date : 10.09.2026

Sd/-
Authorized Officer,
SMFG INDIA HOME FINANCE CO. LTD.

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Bonu Bheemayay, Father of No.8037698W NK(GD) Bonu Rambabu, R/o- Vill- Gangammapeta, Post- Joguladumma, Teh- Jiyammavalasa, Dist- Vizianagaram, Andhra Pradesh, have changed my name from Bonu Bheemayay to Bonu Bheemayya, vide affidavit dated 12/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Dinesh Bidichandani, son of Late Shri Khemchand Bidichandani, Rio G-32, First Floor, Lajpat Nagar-II, New Delhi, do hereby declare that I am the sole and absolute owner of the Entire First Floor of the Property No. G-32, Lajpat Nagar-II, New Delhi-110024, measuring 200 sq. yards, on the basis of last Will as well as as mentioned in Deed of Declaration dated 18.01.2024 and Testament dated 10.04.2005 duly registered as Document No. 5256 in Adl. Book No. 3, Volume No. 1365, on pages 50 to 58, on 19.04.2005, in the office of the Sub-Registrar, New Delhi, (left by Shri K.W. Bidichandani alias Shri Khem Chand Bidichandani, who died on 11.08.2011). Anybody claiming any right, title, interest or share in the above said Portion of the property may please his/ her/ their claim/objection regarding/ against my ownership in the above said Portion of the property within 15 days from the date of publication of this Notice

Dinesh Bidichandani
Mobile : 9811114277

PUBLIC NOTICE

Public is hereby informed that our clients, Mrs. Rashila Batra, Mr. Akhil Batra and Mr. Akshay Batra, being the widow and sons/legal heirs of Late Mr. Anil Batra, predeceased son of Late Mrs. Laj Batra, have rights and interest in property bearing House Nos. B-39/3-4, Block B-39, Double Storey, Ramesh Nagar, New Delhi, measuring approximately 103.39 sq. mtrs., formerly owned by Late Mrs. Laj Batra.

Public is cautioned not to purchase, mortgage, lease or otherwise deal with the said property without our clients' prior written consent. Any such transaction shall be at the concerned person's own risk and subject to our clients' rights and legal proceedings.

RAJESH KHAWARE, ADVOCATE
TLAS PARTNERS LLP, a Law Offices
Head Office: 204, 2nd Floor, Vishwa Sadan, 9, District Center, Janakpuri, New Delhi-110058, India

PUBLIC NOTICE

Public is hereby informed that our clients, Mrs. Rashila Batra, Mr. Akhil Batra and Mr. Akshay Batra, being the widow and sons/legal heirs of Late Mr. Anil Batra, predeceased son of Late Mrs. Laj Batra, have rights and interest in property bearing House Nos. B-39/3-4, Block B-39, Double Storey, Ramesh Nagar, New Delhi, measuring approximately 103.39 sq. mtrs., formerly owned by Late Mrs. Laj Batra.

Public is cautioned not to purchase, mortgage, lease or otherwise deal with the said property without our clients' prior written consent. Any such transaction shall be at the concerned person's own risk and subject to our clients' rights and legal proceedings.

RAJESH KHAWARE, ADVOCATE
TLAS PARTNERS LLP, a Law Offices
Head Office: 204, 2nd Floor, Vishwa Sadan, 9, District Center, Janakpuri, New Delhi-110058, India

PUBLIC NOTICE

Public is hereby informed that our clients, Mrs. Rashila Batra, Mr. Akhil Batra and Mr. Akshay Batra, being the widow and sons/legal heirs of Late Mr. Anil Batra, predeceased son of Late Mrs. Laj Batra, have rights and interest in property bearing House Nos. B-39/3-4, Block B-39, Double Storey, Ramesh Nagar, New Delhi, measuring approximately 103.39 sq. mtrs., formerly owned by Late Mrs. Laj Batra.

Public is cautioned not to purchase, mortgage, lease or otherwise deal with the said property without our clients' prior written consent. Any such transaction shall be at the concerned person's own risk and subject to our clients' rights and legal proceedings.

RAJESH KHAWARE, ADVOCATE
TLAS PARTNERS LLP, a Law Offices
Head Office: 204, 2nd Floor, Vishwa Sadan, 9, District Center, Janakpuri, New Delhi-110058, India

PUBLIC NOTICE

Public is hereby informed that our clients, Mrs. Rashila Batra, Mr. Akhil Batra and Mr. Akshay Batra, being the widow and sons/legal heirs of Late Mr. Anil Batra, predeceased son of Late Mrs. Laj Batra, have rights and interest in property bearing House Nos. B-39/3-4, Block B-39, Double Storey, Ramesh Nagar, New Delhi, measuring approximately 103.39 sq. mtrs., formerly owned by Late Mrs. Laj Batra.

Public is cautioned not to purchase, mortgage, lease or otherwise deal with the said property without our clients' prior written consent. Any such transaction shall be at the concerned person's own risk and subject to our clients' rights and legal proceedings.

RAJESH KHAWARE, ADVOCATE
TLAS PARTNERS LLP, a Law Offices
Head Office: 204, 2nd Floor, Vishwa Sadan, 9, District Center, Janakpuri, New Delhi-110058, India

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Kamlesh Devi, Mother of No.15808749M Sep Ajay Katara, R/o- Vill- Dahiya, PO-Khamani, Dist- Mathura, Uttar Pradesh- 281501, have changed my name from Kamlesh Devi to Kamalesh Devi, vide affidavit dated 12/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Dinesh Bidichandani, son of Late Shri Khemchand Bidichandani, Rio G-32, First Floor, Lajpat Nagar-II, New Delhi, do hereby declare that I am the sole and absolute owner of the Entire First Floor of the Property No. G-32, Lajpat Nagar-II, New Delhi-110024, measuring 200 sq. yards, on the basis of last Will as well as as mentioned in Deed of Declaration dated 18.01.2024 and Testament dated 10.04.2005 duly registered as Document No. 5256 in Adl. Book No. 3, Volume No. 1365, on pages 50 to 58, on 19.04.2005, in the office of the Sub-Registrar, New Delhi, (left by Shri K.W. Bidichandani alias Shri Khem Chand Bidichandani, who died on 11.08.2011). Anybody claiming any right, title, interest or share in the above said Portion of the property may please his/ her/ their claim/objection regarding/ against my ownership in the above said Portion of the property within 15 days from the date of publication of this Notice

Dinesh Bidichandani
Mobile : 9811114277

I, Chakali Badulaiah S/o Plot No-103, Pahal Apartment, Palam Village, Gali No-1, New Delhi- 110077, hereby declare that Chandra Mouli and Chakali Chandra Mouli are both are one and same person, my wife C Sowjanya and Chakali Sowjanya is both are one and same person & my son C Charan and Chakali Charan is both are one and same person.

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Asha Rani W/o Late Sh. Tara Chand R/o E-9, South Anarkali, Delhi-51 state that I am the owner of Bulitup Property No.E-9, South Anarkali area measuring 75 Sq. Yds. Situated at about of South Anarkali, Delhi-51 that Previous Ownership Document Agreement To Sell executed on 27/12/1987 in respect of the above said property No.E-9, South Anarkali Delhi-110051 duly notarized have been lost and I have already lodged the Information Report on 12.09.2026 vide LR No.625815/2026.The said property is absolutely free from any encumbrances whatsoever. If any person has any claim or interest over the said property, they are requested to forward their claim/s along with the relevant documents to me within 7 days of this public notice. If no claim is received, it shall be presumed after 7 days that it is free from all encumbrances.

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Asha Rani W/o Late Sh. Tara Chand R/o E-9, South Anarkali, Delhi-51 state that I am the owner of Bulitup Property No.E-9, South Anarkali area measuring 75 Sq. Yds. Situated at about of South Anarkali, Delhi-51 that Previous Ownership Document Agreement To Sell executed on 27/12/1987 in respect of the above said property No.E-9, South Anarkali Delhi-110051 duly notarized have been lost and I have already lodged the Information Report on 12.09.2026 vide LR No.625815/2026.The said property is absolutely free from any encumbrances whatsoever. If any person has any claim or interest over the said property, they are requested to forward their claim/s along with the relevant documents to me within 7 days of this public notice. If no claim is received, it shall be presumed after 7 days that it is free from all encumbrances.

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Asha Rani W/o Late Sh. Tara Chand R/o E-9, South Anarkali, Delhi-51 state that I am the owner of Bulitup Property No.E-9, South Anarkali area measuring 75 Sq. Yds. Situated at about of South Anarkali, Delhi-51 that Previous Ownership Document Agreement To Sell executed on 27/12/1987 in respect of the above said property No.E-9, South Anarkali Delhi-110051 duly notarized have been lost and I have already lodged the Information Report on 12.09.2026 vide LR No.625815/2026.The said property is absolutely free from any encumbrances whatsoever. If any person has any claim or interest over the said property, they are requested to forward their claim/s along with the relevant documents to me within 7 days of this public notice. If no claim is received, it shall be presumed after 7 days that it is free from all encumbrances.

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Asha Rani W/o Late Sh. Tara Chand R/o E-9, South Anarkali, Delhi-51 state that I am the owner of Bulitup Property No.E-9, South Anarkali area measuring 75 Sq. Yds. Situated at about of South Anarkali, Delhi-51 that Previous Ownership Document Agreement To Sell executed on 27/12/1987 in respect of the above said property No.E-9, South Anarkali Delhi-110051 duly notarized have been lost and I have already lodged the Information Report on 12.09.2026 vide LR No.625815/2026.The said property is absolutely free from any encumbrances whatsoever. If any person has any claim or interest over the said property, they are requested to forward their claim/s along with the relevant documents to me within 7 days of this public notice. If no claim is received, it shall be presumed after 7 days that it is free from all encumbrances.

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Asha Rani W/o Late Sh. Tara Chand R/o E-9, South Anarkali, Delhi-51 state that I am the owner of Bulitup Property No.E-9, South Anarkali area measuring 75 Sq. Yds. Situated at about of South Anarkali, Delhi-51 that Previous Ownership Document Agreement To Sell executed on 27/12/1987 in respect of the above said property No.E-9, South Anarkali Delhi-110051 duly notarized have been lost and I have already lodged the Information Report on 12.09.2026 vide LR No.625815/2026.The said property is absolutely free from any encumbrances whatsoever. If any person has any claim or interest over the said property, they are requested to forward their claim/s along with the relevant documents to me within 7 days of this public notice. If no claim is received, it shall be presumed after 7 days that it is free from all encumbrances.

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Asha Rani W/o Late Sh. Tara Chand R/o E-9, South Anarkali, Delhi-51 state that I am the owner of Bulitup Property No.E-9, South Anarkali area measuring 75 Sq. Yds. Situated at about of South Anarkali, Delhi-51 that Previous Ownership Document Agreement To Sell executed on 27/12/1987 in respect of the above said property No.E-9, South Anarkali Delhi-110051 duly notarized have been lost and I have already lodged the Information Report on 12.09.2026 vide LR No.625815/2026.The said property is absolutely free from any encumbrances whatsoever. If any person has any claim or interest over the said property, they are requested to forward their claim/s along with the relevant documents to me within 7 days of this public notice. If no claim is received, it shall be presumed after 7 days that it is free from all encumbrances.

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Asha Rani W/o Late Sh. Tara Chand R/o E-9, South Anarkali, Delhi-51 state that I am the owner of Bulitup Property No.E-9, South Anarkali area measuring 75 Sq. Yds. Situated at about of South Anarkali, Delhi-51 that Previous Ownership Document Agreement To Sell executed on 27/12/1987 in respect of the above said property No.E-9, South Anarkali Delhi-110051 duly notarized have been lost and I have already lodged the Information Report on 12.09.2026 vide LR No.625815/2026.The said property is absolutely free from any encumbrances whatsoever. If any person has any claim or interest over the said property, they are requested to forward their claim/s along with the relevant documents to me within 7 days of this public notice. If no claim is received, it shall be presumed after 7 days that it is free from all encumbrances.

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Asha Rani W/o Late Sh. Tara Chand R/o E-9, South Anarkali, Delhi-51 state that I am the owner of Bulitup Property No.E-9, South Anarkali area measuring 75 Sq. Yds. Situated at about of South Anarkali, Delhi-51 that Previous Ownership Document Agreement To Sell executed on 27/12/1987 in respect of the above said property No.E-9, South Anarkali Delhi-110051 duly notarized have been lost and I have already lodged the Information Report on 12.09.2026 vide LR No.625815/2026.The said property is absolutely free from any encumbrances whatsoever. If any person has any claim or interest over the said property, they are requested to forward their claim/s along with the relevant documents to me within 7 days of this public notice. If no claim is received, it shall be presumed after 7 days that it is free from all encumbrances.

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Asha Rani W/o Late Sh. Tara Chand R/o E-9, South Anarkali, Delhi-51 state that I am the owner of Bulitup Property No.E-9, South Anarkali area measuring 75 Sq. Yds. Situated at about of South Anarkali, Delhi-51 that Previous Ownership Document Agreement To Sell executed on 27/12/1987 in respect of the above said property No.E-9, South Anarkali Delhi-110051 duly notarized have been lost and I have already lodged the Information Report on 12.09.2026 vide LR No.625815/2026.The said property is absolutely free from any encumbrances whatsoever. If any person has any claim or interest over the said property, they are requested to forward their claim/s along with the relevant documents to me within 7 days of this public notice. If no claim is received, it shall be presumed after 7 days that it is free from all encumbrances.

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Asha Rani W/o Late Sh. Tara Chand R/o E-9, South Anarkali, Delhi-51 state that I am the owner of Bulitup Property No.E-9, South Anarkali area measuring 75 Sq. Yds. Situated at about of South Anarkali, Delhi-51 that Previous Ownership Document Agreement To Sell executed on 27/12/1987 in respect of the above said property No.E-9, South Anarkali Delhi-110051 duly notarized have been lost and I have already lodged the Information Report on 12.09.2026 vide LR No.625815/2026.The said property is absolutely free from any encumbrances whatsoever. If any person has any claim or interest over the said property, they are requested to forward their claim/s along with the relevant documents to me within 7 days of this public notice. If no claim is received, it shall be presumed after 7 days that it is free from all encumbrances.

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Asha Rani W/o Late Sh. Tara Chand R/o E-9, South Anarkali, Delhi-51 state that I am the owner of Bulitup Property No.E-9, South Anarkali area measuring 75 Sq. Yds. Situated at about of South Anarkali, Delhi-51 that Previous Ownership Document Agreement To Sell executed on 27/12/1987 in respect of the above said property No.E-9, South Anarkali Delhi-110051 duly notarized have been lost and I have already lodged the Information Report on 12.09.2026 vide LR No.625815/2026.The said property is absolutely free from any encumbrances whatsoever. If any person has any claim or interest over the said property, they are requested to forward their claim/s along with the relevant documents to me within 7 days of this public notice. If no claim is received, it shall be presumed after 7 days that it is free from all encumbrances.

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Asha Rani W/o Late Sh. Tara Chand R/o E-9, South Anarkali, Delhi-51 state that I am the owner of Bulitup Property No.E-9, South Anarkali area measuring 75 Sq. Yds. Situated at about of South Anarkali, Delhi-51 that Previous Ownership Document Agreement To Sell executed on 27/12/1987 in respect of the above said property No.E-9, South Anarkali Delhi-110051 duly notarized have been lost and I have already lodged the Information Report on 12.09.2026 vide LR No.625815/2026.The said property is absolutely free from any encumbrances whatsoever. If any person has any claim or interest over the said property, they are requested to forward their claim/s along with the relevant documents to me within 7 days of this public notice. If no claim is received, it shall be presumed after 7 days that it is free from all encumbrances.

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Asha Rani W/o Late Sh. Tara Chand R/o E-9, South Anarkali, Delhi-51 state that I am the owner of Bulitup Property No.E-9, South Anarkali area measuring 75 Sq. Yds. Situated at about of South Anarkali, Delhi-51 that Previous Ownership Document Agreement To Sell executed on 27/12/1987 in respect of the above said property No.E-9, South Anarkali Delhi-110051 duly notarized have been lost and I have already lodged the Information Report on 12.09.2026 vide LR No.625815/2026.The said property is absolutely free from any encumbrances whatsoever. If any person has any claim or interest over the said property, they are requested to forward their claim/s along with the relevant documents to me within 7 days of this public notice. If no claim is received, it shall be presumed after 7 days that it is free from all encumbrances.

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Asha Rani W/o Late Sh. Tara Chand R/o E-9, South Anarkali, Delhi-51 state that I am the owner of Bulitup Property No.E-9, South Anarkali area measuring 75 Sq. Yds. Situated at about of South Anarkali, Delhi-51 that Previous Ownership Document Agreement To Sell executed on 27/12/1987 in respect of the above said property No.E-9, South Anarkali Delhi-110051 duly notarized have been lost and I have already lodged the Information Report on 12.09.2026 vide LR No.625815/2026.The said property is absolutely free from any encumbrances whatsoever. If any person has any claim or interest over the said property, they are requested to forward their claim/s along with the relevant documents to me within 7 days of this public notice. If no claim is received, it shall be presumed after 7 days that it is free from all encumbrances.

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Asha Rani W/o Late Sh. Tara Chand R/o E-9, South Anarkali, Delhi-51 state that I am the owner of Bulitup Property No.E-9, South Anarkali area measuring 75 Sq. Yds. Situated at about of South Anarkali, Delhi-51 that Previous Ownership Document Agreement To Sell executed on 27/12/1987 in respect of the above said property No.E-9, South Anarkali Delhi-110051 duly notarized have been lost and I have already lodged the Information Report on 12.09.2026 vide LR No.625815/2026.The said property is absolutely free from any encumbrances whatsoever. If any person has any claim or interest over the said property, they are requested to forward their claim/s along with the relevant documents to me within 7 days of this public notice. If no claim is received

PAGE 7 NATION Kharge slams Gujarat Govt over water contamination	PAGE 8 USP BRICS seeks faster, safer cross-border payments	PAGE 9 GLOBAL Trump calls united Ireland fantastic in Dublin	PAGE 11 SPORTS I enjoy leadership and it helps my batting: Padikkal set to lead India A	AGENDA  BRICS & BRICKBATS
--	--	--	---	--

Big win for India: Terror stand gets global backing

BRICS leaders seek reforms to reflect changing global economic realities

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

The BRICS New Delhi Declaration, adopted at the 18th BRICS Summit on Saturday, has given strong political backing to India's positions on terrorism and a greater voice for the Global South in global decision-making. The declaration condemned in the strongest terms the April 22, 2025 terrorist attack in Jammu and Kashmir in which 26 people were killed. It described acts of terrorism as "criminal and unjustifiable, regardless of their motivation, whenever, wherever and by whomsoever committed."

BRICS leaders urged "zero tolerance for terrorism" and rejected "double standards in countering terrorism." They specifically called for action against the cross-border movement of terrorists, terrorism financing and safe havens,



Prime Minister Narendra Modi delivers the opening statement during the 18th BRICS Summit at the Bharat Mandapam PTI

and said all those involved in terrorist activities and their support must be held accountable under national and international law. The grouping also called for concerted action against all UN-designated terrorists and terrorist entities and urged the expeditious finalisation of the Comprehensive Convention on International Terrorism within the UN framework.

On global governance, the declaration reiterated support for comprehensive reform of the United Nations, including the Security Council, to make it more democratic, representative, effective and efficient and to increase the representation of developing countries. China and Russia, as permanent members of the Security Council, reiterated their support for the aspira-

BRICS HIGHLIGHTS

- Leaders plant great banyan tree saplings
- Leaders visit Bharat Innovates Exposition
- India Post releases commemorative postage stamps to mark two decades of BRICS
- Adopts New Delhi Declaration with consensus
- Seeks faster, safer cross-border payments
- Recognise women as decision-makers, growth drivers
- BRICS urges IMF, World Bank reforms, hits unilateral tariffs and sanctions

CONTINUED ON >> P4

XI BRINGS TOP AIDES CAI QI, WANG YI TO INDIA

New Delhi: Underlining the importance of his visit to India for the BRICS summit and bilateral talks with Prime Minister Narendra Modi on its sidelines, Chinese President Xi Jinping was accompanied by two of the most influential and powerful figures in his political and foreign-policy establishment. They are Cai Qi and Wang Yi.

More than 400 other delegates, including business leaders, also came along with the Chinese President, who landed here on Saturday. The selection of his entourage for the two-day visit signified Beijing's positive intentions to strengthen ties with New Delhi.

Their presence alongside Xi assumes significance as the Chinese president returns to India after seven years, at a time when New Delhi and Beijing are cautiously working to stabilise ties after years of tensions.

FULL REPORT ON >> P5

Xi's India return signals thaw in ties

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chinese President Xi Jinping on Saturday held bilateral talks on the sidelines of the BRICS Summit, discussing the next phase of India-China relations, including peace along the border, the unresolved boundary question, trade, investment and people-to-people exchanges.

Xi's visit to New Delhi, his first to India in seven years, comes as the two countries seek to consolidate the steady improvement in ties since the prolonged tensions that followed the 2020 eastern Ladakh standoff and the Galwan Valley clashes.

According to the Ministry of External Affairs, the two leaders welcomed the "steady progress" in bilateral relations since their last meeting in Tianjin in August 2025. They reaffirmed that both countries should take a strategic and long-term perspective on their ties.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi receives Chinese President Xi Jinping at the Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi PTI

"Differences should not become disputes," the MEA release said.

Prime Minister Modi underlined that the relationship should be guided by "three mutuals — mutual respect,

mutual sensitivity and mutual interest."

Peace and tranquillity along the disputed border emerged as a central element of the discussions.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Air India pilot found dead in hotel room

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

An Air India pilot, in the city for Boeing 787 conversion training, died after being found unconscious in his hotel room during a layover, with police ruling out any foul play.

The pilot had checked into a hotel in Vasant Kunj on September 10 and was found dead there the next evening, police said. The pilot, who had previously worked with Air India



Express, was undergoing conversion training to operate wide-body Boeing 787 aircraft, according to airline officials.

A PCR call regarding the ill health of the hotel guest was received at Vasant Kunj North police station on September 11, following which police personnel reached the hotel and found him unconscious and unresponsive.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Modi's gala dinner serves up Indian delicacies for leaders

RAJESH KUMAR ■ New Delhi

World leaders on Saturday savoured the world-famous traditional Indian cuisine from all across the country at Prime Minister Narendra Modi's gala dinner for the BRICS summit dignitaries. The vegetarian dishes ranged from Khandvi Mille-Feuille and Khumb Galouti to Paneer Lababdar, Millet Pulao and traditional Indian desserts.

The evening featured a specially curated Indian menu showcasing region-



al flavours and traditional preparations, along with a cultural performance by an ensemble of more than

100 artistes from India and other BRICS member countries.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Xi's N701 rolls into Delhi under black cover

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH ■ New Delhi

Delhi's streets have seen their share of high-security convoys. Still, few sights sparked as much instant curiosity as the black-shrouded limousines rolling through the Capital ahead of Chinese President Xi Jinping's arrival for the 18th BRICS Summit. Wrapped like oversized gifts no one was allowed to open, the vehicles moved under heavy tarpaulins before the leader himself landed. Once the covers came off, the machine at the centre of the speculation stood revealed: the Hongqi N701, China's most secretive presidential limousine.



The covering was never a last-minute panic measure. Heads of state routinely fly their own armoured cars in cargo aircraft days or hours before they arrive. The tarpaulins protect the vehicles from dust, rain, sun

and scratches during unloading and road transport. They also serve a quieter purpose: they keep the exact silhouette, window thickness, and antenna array and underbody details away from

cameras until the car is officially in service.

Similar wrapped convoys have been spotted on Xi's earlier trips. By the time he stepped onto Indian soil, the covers were gone, and the N701 was ready for duty. Hongqi means "Red Flag." First Automotive Works created the brand in 1958 specifically to build cars for China's top leadership.

The N701, introduced around 2022, is the current flagship of that tradition. It is not sold to the public. Production is tiny, reports suggest roughly five cars a year, or about fifty units over a decade, reserved strictly for the highest state duties.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

BRICS Summit: Where culture meets diplomacy

RAJESH KUMAR ■ New Delhi

The ongoing BRICS summit here is not only about the leaders discussing serious issues specific to the region and global events, but also gives an opportunity to showcase the rich culture of the member countries through traditional crafts, performances and artistic expressions.

Zahra Pezeshkian, daughter of Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, and her husband Hassan Majidi visited the pavilion and interacted with the artisans and representatives showcasing



Zahra Pezeshkian, daughter of Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, with artisans at the Iran Pavilion during the BRICS Bazaar in New Delhi PTI

Iran's rich art, crafts and cultural heritage on Saturday. They explored pavilions from BRICS member and partner



countries, including the Indian pavilion, witnessing the vibrant showcase of art, crafts and cultural heritage.

"Zahra Pezeshkian, daughter of the President of the Islamic Republic of Iran, visited the Pradhanmantri

Sangrahalaya in New Delhi. She explored the museum showcasing the journeys, contributions and legacies of India's Prime Ministers," the Iranian Embassy in India posted on X.

After Zahra Pezeshkian visited the BRICS Bazaar, Union Minister for Women and Child Development Annpurna Devi posted on X, "It was a pleasure to welcome Ms. Zahra Pezeshkian, daughter of Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian to the #BRICSBazaar at the National Crafts Museum, New Delhi."

CONTINUED ON >> P4





University of Patanjali

Haridwar

APPROVED BY

UNIVERSITY GRANTS COMMISSION

(U.G.C., Govt. of India)

ADMISSION OPEN

FOR DISTANCE LEARNING (2026-27)

Special discount of 50% on tuition fee for Employees of Patanjali, Bharat Swabhimani Trust & allied institutions

✱ B.A. (Yoga Science) - 3 Years

✱ M.Sc. (Yoga Science) - 2 Years

✱ M.A. Darshan (Philosophy) - 2 Years

✱ M.A. (Yoga Science) - 2 Years

✱ M.A. (Sanskrit) - 2 Years

Last Date to Apply: 13th October 2026

Apply Online : www.universityofpatanjali.com/odl/odl-form/
email: patanjali@odl@gmail.com

For Advance Registration
₹ (Fee : 1000)



For More Information, Contact :
7217035962, 9997011072
7217035957, 8954555111

Note :
1. Above Courses are highly useful for clearing Civil Services Exam
2. You Can Start Your own Yoga Studio to Train Foreign Nationals, Indian Diaspora.
3. One Can easily get jobs in Govt. Institutions (ITs, NITs, Degree Colleges, Army, ORDO, ISRO, CSIR etc.) and Multinational Companies Tourism Industry, Embassies, Pvt. Universities etc.

IN FOCUS



People carry an idol of Lord Ganesha to a worship venue ahead of the Ganesh Chaturthi festival in Mumbai

PTI

₹5,600 crore cyber fraud ring busted; 2 held: UP Police

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kanpur

Police here have busted an alleged inter-state cyber fraud network involving transactions of around ₹5,600 crore over three years and arrested two alleged members, a senior officer said on Saturday.

Police also seized ₹65 lakh in cash during a raid at an office in the Jainmau area, Commissioner of Police Raghubir Lal said.

The network allegedly involved online gaming, investment fraud, cricket betting, hawala transactions and bogus firms used to route suspected fraud proceeds. The arrested accused have



been identified as Shawez Waris of Beconganj and Salman of Chamanganj. Waris was arrested in Hyderabad after allegedly attempting to travel to Dubai following registration of a case against him on August 18.

Big win for India: Terror stand gets global...

They backed greater representation of developing countries in the IMF and World Bank and more transparent, merit-based leadership selection processes.

On trade, BRICS expressed serious concern over unilateral tariff and non-tariff measures that distort trade and are inconsistent with WTO rules. The declaration reaffirmed support for a rules-based multilateral trading system with the WTO at its core and called for the immediate restoration of a fully functioning two-tier binding dispute settlement mechanism. It also condemned unilateral coercive measures, including economic and secondary sanctions, as contrary to international law.

Beyond geopolitics, the declaration outlined practical cooperation on cross-border payments and local currencies, startups and MSMEs, digital technologies, artificial intelligence, cyber-security, space, health, agriculture, energy, hydrogen and critical minerals. It supported faster, cheaper and more secure cross-border payments while recognising that there is no one-size-fits-all approach, welcomed the BRICS Incubator Network, and backed cooperation on smart grids, energy storage, hydrogen and resilient critical-mineral supply chains.

Adopted under the theme “Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability,” the New Delhi Declaration positions BRICS, at its 20-year mark, as a platform for developing countries to demand a larger role in existing global institutions while deepening cooperation in trade, finance, technology and development.

Xi’s India return signals thaw in ties

Modi emphasised that “peace and tranquillity in the border areas remains an essential basis for the continued development of bilateral relations” and underlined the need for both sides to “observe existing agreements and understandings on border-related issues.”

The two leaders expressed commitment to a “fair, reasonable, and mutually acceptable resolution of the boundary question proceeding from the political perspective of their overall bilateral relations and the long-term interests of the two peoples.”

The talks come against the backdrop of renewed high-level engagement. National Security Adviser Ajit Doval and Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi, the designated special representatives for the India-China boundary talks, held discussions in Beijing last month. The Special Representative mechanism, established in 2003, remains the principal channel for addressing the boundary question.

On economic and people-to-people ties, the leaders “took note of the progress in people-to-people ties and underscored the need to further promote cultural exchanges, business linkages and greater mobility between the two countries.” On trade, they underlined the need to “address each other’s concerns, including structural trade imbalance and supply chain issues, and facilitation of meaningful and predictable market access.”

The economic focus assumes importance as India seeks to deepen domestic manufacturing and diversify supply chains while remaining sig-

nificantly engaged with China through bilateral trade. Greater economic engagement is also a key component of the broader effort to stabilise bilateral relations.

The two leaders agreed that both sides must continue to expand common ground on regional and global issues. Prime Minister Modi “appreciated China’s support for India’s BRICS chairship and its contributions towards the success of the BRICS Summit-2026.”

The meeting followed the leaders’ discussions in Tianjin on August 31, 2025, which had helped set the stage for efforts to stabilise ties. Since then, the two sides have gradually sought to restore economic and people-to-people engagement while keeping the unresolved boundary question within sustained diplomatic dialogue.

For New Delhi, the latest Modi-Xi engagement reflects a more pragmatic phase in the relationship: rebuilding economic and people-to-people ties while ensuring that border peace remains the foundation for any broader normalisation.

Air India pilot found dead in hotel room

He was immediately taken to a hospital, where he was declared dead, the police said. Police then called a crime team to the scene.

According to police, the pilot’s brother contacted the hotel manager on the evening of September 11 and told him his brother was not responding to his calls. The hotel manager then went to the room, which was locked from inside. It was opened with the help of the hotel’s master key, following which the pilot was found lying unconscious and unresponsive, police said.

The post-mortem examination was conducted at Safdarjung Hospital on September 12. The final cause of death will be ascertained after receipt of the final medical opinion.

Police said they were not suspecting foul play and were conducting inquest proceedings under Section 194 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita.

Earlier, officials had said the pilot died due to cardiac arrest. Air India, in a statement, had said it was deeply saddened by the passing of a cockpit crew member in Delhi.

“He was on a layover rest at a hotel in Delhi where he was found unconscious last evening. He was rushed to the hospital immediately, where he was declared dead,” the airline had said. Air India said it was in close touch with the pilot’s family and was extending all support during this time of grief. Further enquiry is in progress, police said.

Modi’s gala dinner serves up Indian delicacies...

Presented in both English and Hindi, the menu card incorporated varieties from regional classics to Old Delhi street-food favourites, giving the gala dinner a distinctly Indian touch.

Millet took centre stage at the dinner. A special note in the menu highlighted the significance of “Shree Anna”, describing millets as nutrient-rich grains that require fewer resources and support agricultural sustainability and climate resilience.

The menu incorporated three varieties of millets across the meal: pearl millet in the pulao, sorghum in the Indian bread and barnyard millet in the dessert. The menu also highlighted India’s efforts to promote millets globally,

ary and response measures are in place, and the overall situation remains under control,” the office of the Special Relief Commissioner (SRC) said in a statement.

The state recorded an average rainfall of 24.5 mm during the 24 hours, with Chitrakonda block in Malkangiri recording the highest rainfall of 192 mm, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD). Five blocks recorded more than 100 mm rainfall, while 33 blocks received between 50 mm and 100 mm, IMD officials said.

Director of the Meteorological Centre, Bhubaneswar, Manorama Mohanty said the state received 1,247.5 mm rainfall between June 1 and September 12, against the normal average of 997 mm, a surplus of 25.1 per cent.

Mohanty said the low-pressure area over the north-



west-westcentral Bay of Bengal and adjoining south Odisha-north Andhra Pradesh coasts was likely to become more marked and move west-northwestwards across north Coastal Andhra Pradesh and south Odisha during the next 24 hours.

The IMD has issued a yellow alert (Be prepared) for heavy rainfall of 7 cm to 11 cm at isolated places in Nuapada, Bolangir,

Kalahandi, Nabarangpur and Koraput districts. Thunderstorms accompanied by lightning and winds of 30-40 kmph are also likely in Balasore, Sundergarh, Keonjhar, Mayurbhanj, Nuapada, Bolangir, Kalahandi, Kandhamal, Nabarangpur, Rayagada, Koraput, Malkangiri, Gajapati and Ganjam, it said.

The Water Resources Department said all rivers in

Maharashtra: FDA seizes over 95 tonnes of food products, 172 litres of milk worth ₹4.45 crore

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

The Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration (FDA) seized more than 95 tonnes of food products and 172 litres of milk, collectively valued at about ₹4.45 crore, across the State over the last two days, officials said on Saturday.

The FDA said in a statement that it carried out special inspections in Ahilyanagar, Pune, Nashik and Buldhana as part of its drive to ensure the availability of safe, hygienic and quality food during the upcoming festive season.

In Ahilyanagar, officials raided a cold storage facility and seized 75,368.8 kg of pasteurised cooking butter (unsalted), labelled “Madurama Creamy Delight”, worth ₹3.95 crore.



The food-safety and regulatory agency said the stock was suspected to be of substandard quality and had labelling deficiencies. Officials sent samples to a laboratory for analysis and

sealed the stock in the cold storage.

In Pune, officials intercepted two vehicles after receiving information that they were transporting large quantities of adulterated paneer, ‘khoya’ (milk solids), and curd for sale during the festive season, which begins with Ganesh Chaturthi on September 14.

The FDA found several irregularities, including transporting milk products in vehicles without temperature-control facilities, paneer brought from suppliers in Karnataka without purchase or sale invoices, products kept in unsealed polythene bags, and incomplete labelling, the statement said.

Officials collected 24 samples from the first vehicle and seized 7,362.5 kg of paneer and other food products worth ₹17.15 lakh.

the state were below their respective danger levels and were being closely monitored. As of Saturday morning, the Mahanadi near Cuttack was at 22.91 metres, the Brahmani at Panposh at 172.66 metres, the Baitarani at Anandpur at 34.79 metres and the Jalaka at Mathani at 6.46 metres. The Hirakud reservoir level stood at 629.10 feet at 9 am, against its full reservoir level of 630 feet.

The SRC office said four blocks in Malkangiri — Malkangiri, Mathili, Kalimela and Podia — were being closely monitored. ODRAF teams have been deployed in Mathili and Kalimela as a precautionary measure.

Water was overflowing over Kangrukonda, Pangam, MV-96 and Kanyashrama bridges, it said. Rainfall stopped in Malkangiri in the evening, but the district remained under close watch, officials said. However, in

view of several areas, including roads and bridges, being submerged in rainwater and keeping public safety in mind, district magistrate-cum-collector Prathamesh Arvind Rajeshirke ordered the closure of all liquor shops in the district.

All licence holders and shop managers have been directed to strictly comply with the order. The administration also warned that strict legal action would be taken against any person or establishment found violating the order by illegally selling or serving liquor.

“The order has been issued as some people, under the influence of liquor, drive on submerged roads and have lost their lives in the past. To prevent such incidents, the closure of liquor shops has been ordered in the interest of public safety,” a senior official said.

6 lakh cases settled during Lok Adalats in Punjab

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

A total of 404 Lok Adalat benches were constituted across all districts in Punjab, in which around 5.99 lakh cases out of 6.54 lakh cases were amicably settled on Saturday.

Punjab State Legal Services Authority organised the National Lok Adalat under the patronage of Punjab and Haryana High Court Chief Justice Ashwani Kumar Mishra and under the leadership of Justice Deepak Sibal, Executive Chairman, Punjab State Legal Services Authority. Giving information in this



regard, Jagdeep Kaur Virk, member secretary of the legal authority, said this mega initiative was aimed at facilitating speedy, cost-effective and amicable settlement of disputes.

The Lok Adalat recorded active participation from litigants, judicial officers, advocates and allied stakeholders.

FROM PAGE - 3

noting that the United Nations had designated 2023 as the International Year of Millets.

The dinner menu opens with Khandvi Mille-Feuille, a steamed gram-flour roll tempered with mustard, coconut and curry leaves, served with Kesar mango, micro-greens and yoghurt dressing. The second starter is khumb galouti, tender pan-grilled mushroom kebabs with mint pearls, served on a bed of sheermal bread.

The main course includes Paneer Lababdar, featuring soft cottage cheese cubes simmered in a rich gravy of shallots and tomato, and Gucchi Marmik, Himalayan morel mushrooms and tender asparagus gently simmered with saffron, raisins and gemara almonds.

The menu also features Carrot Bean Poriyal, a blend of carrots and green beans toasted in aromatic South Indian spices and hand-pressed virgin coconut oil, finished with freshly grated coconut. Guests were also served Thakkali Belle Saaru, a light lentil broth made with toor dal, tomatoes and curry leaves. The meal was accompanied by Beetroot Raita and assorted Indian breads. Beetroot Raita and assorted Indian breads accompany the main course.

For dessert, the menu includes Old Delhi Fruit Cream with Jalebi, pairing seasonal fruits and lightly whipped cream with a crispy sweet fritter, and Shahtooot Phirmi, a slow-cooked milk and rice pudding topped with sweet mulberries and gold leaf. A special cultural performance, “Navarasa - The Universe of Shared Emotions”, was presented during the gala dinner. The cultural programme also features the BRICS Symphony — “One Rhythm, Many Cultures”, bringing together musicians from BRICS member and partner countries in a collaborative musical performance. Drawing from diverse musical traditions, the symphony seeks to showcase a shared artistic expression reflecting the cultural richness, diversity and spirit of togetherness of the BRICS family.

Smiles, handshakes strike a chord of unity

In another picture, Modi was seen engaged in an animated discussion with Putin, Xi and President of Indonesia Prabowo Subianto, while in a photograph, the prime minister and the Russian leader were seen going together, smiling broadly, flanked by security personnel and translators. India is hosting the BRICS Summit from September 12-13, and it is being attended by leaders of 11 member countries and 10 partner countries, as well as some international organisations.

The latest picture of three leaders sharing a light moment comes amid tensions over the wars in West Asia and Ukraine.

Prime Minister Modi also welcomed BRICS leaders against a backdrop featuring Tamil Nadu’s iconic Ramanathaswamy Temple, one of the Char Dham shrines where Lord Ram is believed to have performed puja after his victory over demon king Ravana.

The leaders shook hands and posed for pictures against the backdrop featuring the iconic Ramanathaswamy Temple in Rameswaram, Tamil Nadu. At Bharat Mandapam, where the 18th BRICS summit is underway, the prime minister received the leaders of BRICS nations, including Putin, Jinping and Pezeshkian.

India, China and Russia were among the four founding members of BRIC, along with Brazil, when the grouping took shape in 2006. South Africa was invited to join in 2010 and attended

its first summit as a member in 2011, giving BRICS the name it still uses today.

Putin arrived in New Delhi on Friday and held bilateral talks with Modi. During the meeting, Modi reiterated his call for dialogue and diplomacy to resolve the Ukraine conflict and raised the safety of Indian seafarers. Xi, meanwhile, is visiting India for the first time in seven years.

A day earlier, a photograph of the Prime Minister holding hands with the Iranian President went viral. It drew attention amid the conflict involving Iran, which has disrupted energy supplies and maritime trade.

As he did during his talks with Putin, PM Modi called for dialogue and diplomacy to resolve the conflict in West Asia during his meeting with the Iranian President.

The two photographs capture India’s continued focus on a non-aligned foreign policy in an increasingly fractured world.

New Delhi has maintained that it stands for peace and dialogue while avoiding alignment with rival geopolitical camps, an approach that also informs its stewardship of the BRICS Summit.

Xi’s N701 rolls into Delhi under black cover

The car stretches about 5.5 metres, weighs well over three tonnes, and carries Hongqi’s signature vertical-slat grille and red-flag emblem on the hood. It looks every bit the rolling statement of sovereignty it is meant to be.

What sits beneath the paint is more fortress than luxury sedan. The body uses composite armour and reinforced steel. Windows are multi-layer bullet-resistant glass. The 21-inch wheels carry run-flat tyres designed to keep moving even after a puncture. Reports credit the N701 with the ability to shrug off small explosive devices and an airtight cabin with an air-compression and filtration system intended to protect occupants from chemical or biological threats.

Inside, it functions as a mobile command post with encrypted communications linking the president to Beijing in real time. Power is believed to come from a 6.0-litre V12 producing around 408 horsepower, though some accounts mention a hybrid V6-electric setup; official figures remain unpublished, as they do for almost every presidential vehicle on Earth. The N701 has already accompanied Xi to Hong Kong, the United States, Russia, Egypt and now India.

Its presence on Delhi’s roads during the BRICS gathering sits alongside Russian President Vladimir Putin’s equally armoured Aurus Senat, two homemade limousines making the same point: great-power leaders no longer need to borrow Western marques for their most sensitive journeys. For China, the car is both shield and symbol. It projects industrial self-reliance at the highest level of statecraft while keeping the man inside as insulated from the outside world as modern engineering allows.

Once the black covers were peeled away, the N701 became just another (very large, very expensive, extremely well-protected) car in a long motorcade. Yet the brief mystery it created on Delhi’s roads reminded everyone how much ceremony, security, and national pride still travel with a head of state. In an age of open-source everything, a few secrets still ride under tarpaulin.

BRICS Summit: Where culture meets diplomacy

“Had the opportunity to show them around the Bazaar and share the rich traditions, art, crafts and cultural heritage showcased by BRICS member and partner nations,” the minister said.

Philippine First Lady Liza Araneta-Marcos, who is accompanying President Ferdinand R Marcos Jr., also explored the museum housed at the Teen Murti Bhawan complex, it is learnt.

From China’s Suzhou embroidery and Indonesia’s traditional weaving to Nigeria’s wood and calabash art, South Africa’s Zulu leather craft, Brazil’s clay art-one of the Americas’ oldest living traditions-and Belarus’s traditional willow weaving, the BRICS Bazaar at the National Crafts Museum & Hastkala Academy is bringing the cultural diversity of member nations to life.

The bazaar showcases the rich heritage of participating countries while creating a platform for cultural exchange and cooperation. It brings together over 40 artisans, designers and creative enterprises from 18 countries under one roof, will continue till September 15.

Lana Slastion celebrated willow weaver from Molodechno, from Belarus leads the Verbachka folk crafts collective. According to a note on the website, she is recognised as a People’s Master of the Republic of Belarus.

“Willow weaving in Belarus is a traditional folk craft that creates useful and beautiful objects from flexible willow branches. It’s an ancient craft that predates weaving and the potter’s wheel. Craftsmen create durable baskets, furniture, decorative elements, and household utensils from the natural material, preserving ancient hand-crafting techniques,” the note reads.

Cleaziana Ribeiro de Lima Paiva, a ceramic artisan and sculptor from Goias, Brazil, has also been featured on the website.

“Brazilian clay art is one of the Americas’ oldest living traditions. Indigenous peoples shaped riverbank clays into pots and vessels; colonisation blended these techniques with Portuguese and African methods, creating a distinctly Brazilian craft passed down through generations,” reads another artist’s note.

“The material is the soul: argila (clay) dug by hand from riverbanks and hillsides, each deposit carrying its own colour - deep reds in Pernambuco, warm browns in Goias and Minas Gerais. The process is slow and meditative: harvest, knead, model entirely by hand (no molds or wheels), dry, fire in open bonfires, and finish with natural or industrial pigments,” it adds.

Another artist, Serik Rysbekov, a Kazakhstani artist-jeweller whose silver jewellery combines hot enamel, natural stones and traditional Kazakh influences with contemporary design, has also made it to the list.

Nadia Karimi, whose work focuses on preserving and developing the traditional art of Balochi embroidery, is also represented on the website as an Iranian artist. “The craft is deeply rooted in the identity and heritage of Balochi women, passed down lovingly from mothers to daughters through generations. Every intricate pattern and motif is meticulously hand-stitched using silk thread without the aid of machines, representing hours of devotion, patience, and cultural memory,” reads a note attached to her craft description on the website. The website does not list the number of artists participating at the stalls.

24-hour visit, 15,000 personnel: How Xi Jinping’s India visit is being guarded

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

Chinese President Xi Jinping landed in the capital on Saturday for a visit measured almost to the hour: a day in Delhi for the 18th BRICS Summit, and his first return to India in seven years.

The diplomacy is compressed. The security around it is not. An Air China Boeing 747 brought him into Palam Air Force Station near noon. Union Minister Jitin Prasada received him.

A tri-services guard of honour and a brief cultural welcome, Bihu, Manipuri dance, Garba and Kathak, preceded the motorcade into the city. By evening, Prime Minister Narendra Modi is due to meet him at Bharat Mandapam. Trade, investment and the still-fragile effort to keep the border

quiet are expected to dominate the conversation. A gala dinner for BRICS leaders follows. The last time Xi was in India was October 2019, at Mamallapuram.

Saturday’s arrival therefore carries more weight than a routine summit stop.

It comes after years of frozen high-level contact following the 2020 clash in eastern Ladakh, and after a cautious thaw that has included talks between Special Representatives Ajit Doval and Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi. Beijing has framed the meeting as the third consecutive year the two leaders will sit across a table, after Kazan and Tianjin.

New Delhi has described the talks as “constructive discussions.” Neither side is treating the visit as ceremonial. Nor is the security plan. Xi is staying at the Taj Palace

in Chanakyapuri, a property taken largely out of ordinary service for the night. Chinese protection officers were already in place before he landed. Indian agencies have thrown a second ring around the same ground: Special Cell officers, anti-terror and bomb-detection units, and sweeps for chemical, biological, radiological and nuclear threats.

Authorities have examined underground pipelines and other infrastructure around the hotel. Authorities have placed the airspace above the building under a temporary no-fly restriction. Surveillance runs from rooftop to basement. The Chinese side flew in more than personnel.

A cargo consignment included Xi’s Hongqi state limousine, a backup car and specialised communications equipment. Indian rules still



Chinese President Xi Jinping during the BRICS Summit 2026 session on Inclusive Global Governance and Strengthening Multilateralism at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi

apply. Satellite communication gear is not permitted. Certain weapons and devices must be deposited with customs on arrival. Coordination between the two security systems has been one of the quieter pieces of summit planning. Across Delhi, the numbers tell the rest of the story. About 15,000 police personnel and some 200 companies of paramilitary forces have been mobilised for the summit, with National Security Guard units and other central agencies in support.

Some estimates put the total security measures even higher. Barricades, vehicle checks, and sector commands now line the routes between Palam, the diplomatic hotels, and Bharat Mandapam. Hundreds of cameras, including those that read number plates and identify faces, send footage to central control rooms.

A drone ban is in place during the summit. Officers watch for low-flying threats as closely as they monitor the ground. The security operation is not just for Xi. Russian President Vladimir Putin arrived a day earlier and is staying at a different hotel.

Other BRICS leaders are also staying in the city’s luxury area. Traffic will be diverted on certain roads as motorcades move. Xi’s visit will be brief. He is expected to attend summit sessions on Sunday and leave for the airport around midday, staying for about 24 hours.

During this time, India must move a heavily guarded guest through a busy city and see whether a short meeting can help strengthen a relationship still being rebuilt.

China’s quiet giant in the sky: Xi Jinping’s Boeing 747-8



Chinese President Xi Jinping waves as he arrives to attend the 18th BRICS Summit at the IGIA in New Delhi

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

Although the world is familiar with the special livery and callsign of America’s Air Force One, the arrangements for moving China’s top leaders are much less clear.

President Xi Jinping uses a specially adapted Boeing 747-8 Intercontinental that displays the colours of the state-owned Air China rather than any special presidential insignia.

The aircraft, registered B-2479, serves as a flying office and command post on long-haul international trips. Air China handed over B-2479 in December 2014.

From 2015 to 2016, Lufthansa Technik’s plant in Hamburg, Germany, gave it an extensive VIP conversion. Since that time, it has mainly been reserved for the Chinese president’s international travel. Unlike the current U.S. VC-25A aircraft, which are modified Boeing 747-200Bs, the Chinese jet is a later-generation 747-8.

It is longer and is equipped with more efficient GENx engines, which have been developed from the 787 programme; it has raked wingtips and has a greater fuel capacity; its maximum takeoff weight reaches 975,000 pounds, and it is capable of flying more than 8,000 nautical miles, enabling

non-stop flights on most of Xi’s usual routes with sufficient reserves. Yet no official photographs of the interior have ever been released.

Aviation experts and earlier reports say this setup is standard for presidential 747s. It includes a private suite with a bedroom and office for the president and first lady, a conference area, staff workspaces, a medical facility, and secure communication equipment.

Some Chinese observers call it “Flying Zhongnanhai.” Support aircraft often fly with it. Another 747-8, usually called B-2482, carries officials, while a 747-400 freighter transports vehicles like the armoured presidential limousine Hongqi N701 and other equipment.

China’s top leaders use two main air transport systems. For most domestic and short regional flights, the People’s Liberation Army Air Force’s 34th Transport Aviation Division provides planes. Based in Beijing, this division operates Boeing 737-300s, 737-700s, 737-800s, Airbus A319s, and Bombardier Challenger business jets.

These planes have civilian-style registration numbers and are flown by military crews. Usually, only the president and prime minister can use dedicated long-range presidential aircraft for international trips. Other

leaders typically fly on chartered commercial jets.

Before the 747-8 was used for dedicated service, China relied on Air China’s Boeing 747-400s, such as B-2445, B-2447, and B-2472.

These planes had their commercial seats removed and were fitted with suites and meeting rooms for state visits, then returned to regular passenger service. This practice mostly stopped when the newer jet became available in 2016-2017.

The arrangement balances practicality and caution: using an aircraft painted in Air China’s paint scheme is both practical and cautious.

Using a plane with Air China’s paint scheme makes the president less of a clear target, while still offering the range, payload, and four-engine safety of a 747.

It also allows China to use the national airline’s global support network. Crews are carefully selected, and several aircraft usually fly as support.

China’s presidential aviation programme evolved from earlier attempts, including the 2000 acquisition of a Boeing 767 that was later found to have listening devices. This incident strengthened Beijing’s desire for more control regarding modifications. The current 747-8 reflects a more mature, although still secret, capability.

3 held over pro-Khalistan graffiti at Singhu Border ahead of BRICS

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police arrested three men from Punjab for allegedly painting pro-Khalistan slogans and graffiti at the Singhu Border. Police say they acted on instructions from Gurpatwant Singh Pannun, the US-based chief of the banned group Sikhs for Justice and a designated terrorist. Police announced the arrests on Saturday, as India hosted the 18th BRICS Summit in Delhi. This incident, though minor in scale, became a high-profile security issue because of the timing.

Police discovered the slogans and graffiti on walls near the Singhu Border, which connects Delhi and Haryana, on 6 September. Investigators also found similar markings the next day near the Guru Tegh Bahadur Memorial in Alipur, on Delhi’s edge. The Special Cell filed a first information

report and began a detailed investigation.

The graffiti included phrases like “Dismantle Modi’s BRICS,” “Khalistan Zindabad,” “Khalistan SFJ,” and “SFJ Khalistan America First.” Pannun later claimed responsibility for the incident in a post on X.

Police sources say this supports their belief that the act was directed from abroad. Police have identified the accused as Preetpal, Haminder Singh, and Sheeshpal. Investigators reviewed CCTV footage from the Singhu Border, tracked the suspects’ movements, and arrested them in Faridkot, Punjab.

Police also recovered the car allegedly used to reach the site and carry out the graffiti. The three men are being questioned at Alipur police station by teams from the Special Cell and the Intelligence Bureau (IB). According to police sources, Preetpal was in direct contact with Pannun and



received instructions to write the slogans near the border. They describe him as the operational head of Sikhs for Justice in India. Preetpal, about 31, was out on bail when this incident happened.

The Delhi Police Special Cell had previously arrested him in 2023 for similar graffiti before the G20 Summit. He already faces a case under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act and has several cases linked to Sikhs for Justice activity in Punjab and Haryana.

Officials say this history made him a key suspect once they reviewed the footage

Intelligence reports say these groups have moved some of their focus from direct violence to visible political actions, such as wall writing, online statements, and timed provocations, to stay in the news and make law enforcement’s job harder.

The timing of the graffiti raised official concern, as it appeared just days before the BRICS Leaders’ Summit on 12 and 13 September at Bharat Mandapam. Security in Delhi has been increased, with thousands of police officers, nearly 200 paramilitary units, and dog squads deployed around the venue and main routes into the city.

The Singhu Border has been a politically sensitive area since the farmers’ protests in 2020 and 2021. Agencies see any secessionist slogans there as attempts to use a well-known, visible location. Police say the investigation is ongoing and not limited to the three men in custody.

Foreign delegates flock to Connaught Place



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As India hosts the 18th BRICS Summit in the national capital, Connaught Place has been drawing a larger number of foreign visitors, with delegates and their families exploring traditional shops and restaurants in the heart of Delhi, traders said on Saturday.

The New Delhi Traders Association (NDTA), which represents traders in Connaught Place, said, “Many foreign delegate families are visiting CP today.”

An NDTA official said Chinese, Egyptian and African nationals were among the foreign visitors mostly spotted at Connaught Place. Many of them were seen exploring traditional shops selling ethnic Indian clothes and handicrafts, besides visiting the Tibetan Market.

“They are interested in seeing the traditional side of Delhi. Many foreign visitors are going to shops selling ethnic Indian dresses and are also visiting the Tibetan Market,” he said. The visitors are also exploring traditional restaurants and fine-dining establishments in and around Connaught Place, he said.

“Some restaurants have introduced millet-based dishes on their menus, giving foreign visitors an opportunity to sample Indian ingredients in contemporary preparations,” according to the association. The BRICS summit has also added to the atmosphere in Connaught Place, with BRICS-related

banners and posters put up and with no hawkers in the area and decorative lighting enhanced in the market.

The NDTA official said the foreign footfall was higher on Saturday compared to a normal day. While some foreign visitors can normally be spotted at Connaught Place, there were visitors at several shops and fine-dining restaurants on Saturday, he said.

He said that traders had not expected such a large number of foreign visitors over the weekend, especially with restrictions in place for the movement of delegates and other dignitaries. He further said that the restaurants are expected to witness a good number of visitors for dinner.

Connaught Place has remained open during the summit period, even as authorities have put traffic restrictions and diversions in place for the movement of VIPs and foreign dignitaries. The 18th BRICS Summit is being held at the Bharat Mandapam on September 12 and 13 under India’s chairship. BRICS currently has 11 member countries, while 10 partner countries are part of the expanded grouping.

With delegations and visitors from across the expanded BRICS grouping in the capital, traders said the international gathering had brought an unusual buzz to Connaught Place, with visitors combining official engagements with shopping, dining and a glimpse of Delhi’s traditional commercial culture.

BRICS artists create Sangam mural at venue

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Inspired by the Indian concept of *Sangam* — meeting of rivers — artists from various member countries of BRICS have come together to create a large-scale thematic mural at the Summit venue, symbolising friendship and a confluence of cultures. The vibrant canvas, born out of the “BRICS Friendship Mural project”, is displayed on a wall inside the main Bharat Mandapam building, which houses the Summit Room, a senior official of the Indian Council for Cultural Relations (ICCR), the cultural arm of the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), said.

It was created under the theme “Sangam: Confluence of Cultures” and brings together the diverse artistic traditions of the BRICS member countries in a single collaborative public artwork.

Conceived as a people-centric outreach initiative, it reflects India’s BRICS Chairship theme of ‘Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability’ and highlights the



Artists perform during a Gala dinner hosted by Prime Minister Narendra Modi for visiting leaders of the 18th BRICS Summit in New Delhi

importance of cultural and people-to-people exchanges as one of the foundational pillars of BRICS, the official said. The art project has been helmed by the ICCR. The wide colourful mural depicts the Summit logo at the centre, crowned by the image of the iconic Hawa Mahal of Jaipur in Rajasthan, flanked by a pair of elephants, representing India.

The canvas also portrays nature, flora and fauna, and cultural heritage of various other BRICS member countries. Elements of a Russian artwork, and landmarks depicting other countries, including Brazil, are also part of this art project.

“The collaborative artwork

was created from August 29 to September 8 in New Delhi ahead of the 18th BRICS Summit,” according to a note shared by the ICCR official, which added that the project saw “participation of 11 artists from India and fellow BRICS member countries”.

Working together on site over eleven days, the artists combined their distinct visual traditions, motifs and artistic expressions into a unified composition that “symbolises friendship, mutual respect and shared aspirations” among the BRICS countries, the note added. The MEA described the mural project as a celebration of friendship and unity in diversity.

Dengue Prevention is Simple!

Alertness can save you & family from Dengue

Dengue mosquito breeds in clean stagnant water

Prevent Mosquito breeding

Don't allow water to stagnate inside your home, in flower vase and anywhere in the surroundings.

Always cover the bucket, water tank, other utensils properly

Prevent Mosquito bites

Empty the water cooler every week or put some oil / petrol in it.

Use mosquito net at home & hospitals regularly during fever

Symptoms of Dengue

High Fever

Severe pain behind the eyes that increases with eye movements

Headache, muscle and joint pain

Stomachache

Nausea and vomiting

Rashes on body

For Any Queries, Please Contact : Name of DHOs with Contact Number & Zone (District)

1. Dr. Hemant Kumar City SP (Old Delhi) 9990978034	5. Dr. V.N. Bhagat KPZ (Central North) 9717750141	9. Dr. Ajay Handa Shahdra-s (East) 9811015714
2. Dr. Nageshwar Marandi Central (South East) 9958001160	6. Dr. Madhuri Panth Narela (Outer North) 9958648615	10. Dr. Santosh Tomar Shahdra-s (North East) 9818579090
3. Dr. Sandeep Salve Civil Line (North) 8600598179	7. Dr. Vishal C. Soyam Najafgarh (South West) 9560945471	11. Dr. Deepak Mittal South (South) 8130698279
4. Dr. Aniket Sirohi KBZ (Central) 7217785459	8. Dr. Kanika Singh Rohini (North West) 9319733556	12. Dr. Ajay Kumar West (West) 9871663908

Issued in Public Interest by: Public Health Department Municipal Corporation of Delhi

National Vector Borne Diseases Control Program Directorate General of Health Services, Delhi Government

RO No. 27/DPMCD/2026-27



At BRICS summit, PM Modi calls for Global South to be rule-shaper

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday called for a fundamental transformation of global governance, saying the Global South must move from being a “rule-follower” to a “rule-shaper” and urging nations to replace the existing “pyramid of privilege” with a “platform of partnership”.

Addressing the opening session of the two-day BRICS summit in New Delhi, Modi proposed a 10-point roadmap for global governance reforms under the grouping. He said the roadmap should be finalised by the next BRICS summit and focus on representation, responsiveness and rule-making.

“The current structure of global governance resembles a pyramid,” Modi said, pointing out that power and decision-making remain concentrated at the top, while many countries affected by global decisions have limited influence over them.



PM Modi delivers the closing remarks during the BRICS Summit at the Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi

He said reform of the United Nations Security Council could no longer be postponed and called for negotiations to be conducted within a clear timeframe and with definite outcomes. He also stressed the need to align voting rights, leadership positions and policy priorities in international financial institutions with present-day economic realities. Modi further

called for greater participation of developing countries in framing international rules for emerging technologies, including artificial intelligence, cyberspace, outer space, biotechnology and other critical technologies.

The prime minister also proposed the creation of a “Seafarers’ Emergency Support Network” to assist sailors facing dangers arising

from conflicts and regional crises. The proposed network would link maritime authorities and diplomatic missions to facilitate distress assistance, medical aid, family notifications and evacuations.

The initiative assumes significance amid continuing instability in West Asia and risks to commercial shipping around the Strait of Hormuz.

Xi Jinping lands in India for BRICS with top aides Cai Qi, Wang Yi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Underlining the importance of his visit to India for the BRICS summit and bilateral talks with Prime Minister Narendra Modi on its sidelines, Chinese President Xi Jinping was accompanied by two of the most influential and powerful figures in his political and foreign-policy establishment. They are Cai Qi and Wang Yi.

More than 400 other delegates, including business leaders, also came along with the Chinese President, who landed here on Saturday. The selection of his entourage for the two-day visit signified Beijing’s positive intentions to strengthen ties with New Delhi.

Cai, a member of the Standing Committee of the Political Bureau of the Communist Party of China (CPC) Central Committee and director of the General Office of the CPC Central Committee, is one of Xi’s



Chinese President Xi Jinping arrives at Bharat Mandapam ahead of a session for BRICS member countries during 18th BRICS Summit in New Delhi

closest confidants. Wang, China’s foreign minister, has been at the centre of Beijing’s foreign policy for more than a decade.

Their presence alongside Xi assumes significance as the Chinese president returns to India after seven years, at a time when New Delhi and Beijing are cautiously working to stabilise ties after years of tensions.

Cai, 70, occupies a key position in the ruling party’s organisational and administrative machinery and is among Jinping’s closest political allies. As director of the General Office of the CPC Central Committee, he oversees a powerful party apparatus and plays a central role in Xi’s administration.

The two have longstand-

ing ties dating back to their overlapping careers in the provinces of Fujian and Zhejiang. Cai’s rise within the Communist Party gathered momentum in 2017, when he joined the then 25-member Politburo, the party’s second-highest decision-making body, as Xi began his second term as Communist Party leader.

His influence has expanded further in recent years. In June this year, Cai was appointed head of the CPC Central Party School and the National Academy of Governance.

Wang Yi, meanwhile, is one of China’s longest-serving foreign ministers. He assumed this responsibility in 2013 and remains a prominent figure in China’s engagement with the world. Wang is currently a member of the Political Bureau of the CPC Central Committee, director of the Office of the Central Commission for Foreign Affairs and minister of foreign affairs.

Harish Rawat quits Congress posts after ED raid on his personal assistant

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi/Dehradun

Former Uttarakhand Chief Minister Harish Rawat resigned from key Congress posts a day after the Enforcement Directorate conducted raids at the premises of his personal assistant (PA) as part of a money laundering investigation, saying he does not want anything associated with him to weaken the party’s fight against corruption ahead of the State Assembly elections.

Rawat stepped down as a member of the Uttarakhand Pradesh Congress Committee executive and as a permanent invitee to the Congress Working Committee.

The ED investigation is linked to alleged irregularities in an examination conducted by the Uttarakhand Subordinate Service Selection Commission (UKSSSC) in 2016. A dozen luxury wristwatches and ₹32 lakh in cash were seized from the premises of Chandan Singh Jeena during the ED raids undertaken on Thursday. Jeena is currently



(L-R) Former Uttarakhand Chief Minister Harish Rawat

Rawat’s personal assistant and had earlier served as an officer on special duty during the Congress leader’s tenure as chief minister during 2014-17.

In a Facebook post, Rawat referred to reports that a large amount of cash and jewellery had been seized from his former OSD and aide, Jina, in Dehradun. In a social media post in Hindi, Rawat said that while he did not believe the allegations of irregularities in recruitment exams levelled against Jeena, who has long been his associate, he absolutely did not want the issue to weaken the party’s campaign.

“Shri Jeena is an extremely decent, humble, and hard-working person. If there is evidence that he tampered with OMR sheets during the recruitment of village development officers or committed any such error, then I am ashamed of this alleged audacious act. However, I do not believe these allegations at all,” Rawat said.

The Congress leader said that he did not want any action or conduct on his part to weaken the Congress’ ongoing fight against corruption. He said he had decided after remembering his “Isht Devta”.

Punjab Police extradite gangster Amrit Dalam from Moldova

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH ■ New Delhi/Chandigarh

The Punjab Police secured its first extradition from Europe on Saturday, returning Amritpal Singh, who goes by the name Amrit Dalam, a 27-year-old member of the Jaggu Bhagwanpuria gang wanted in 21 criminal cases, including seven murders.

Dalam landed at Indira Gandhi International Airport in New Delhi on Saturday morning. He was taken into custody at Chisinau Airport in Moldova on Friday by a four-member Anti-Gangster Task Force (AGTF) team. He was brought to India through Baku, Azerbaijan. Director General of Police Gaurav Yadav called the operation a breakthrough in the fight against transnational organised crime.

“The Punjab Police have obtained the first extradition from a European country, which represents a major achievement in our efforts to combat organised crime,” the DGP said. Dalam, from Dalam Nangal village in Batala, left India in late October 2024 using a fake



passport in the name of Guralpal Singh, a resident of Kurukshetra in Haryana.

Police say he travelled through the UAE and Turkey before reaching eastern Europe. Moldovan authorities arrested him on February 24 as he tried to cross the Otaci border into Ukraine. The six-month operation, called Operation Eastern Reach, was led by the Anti-Gangster Task Force and the Overseas Fugitive Tracking and Extradition

Cell, with help from the CBI’s International Police Cooperation Unit, the Ministry of Home Affairs, the Ministry of External Affairs, and officials in Moldova and Azerbaijan. Punjab Police requested a Red Corner Notice, which Interpol issued.

On May 26, the Chisinau Court approved the extradition. Dalam challenged the decision, but the Centru Court of Appeal rejected his appeal on July 16, making the

decision final. The escort team, led by Superintendent of Police Bikramjit Singh Brar and including Inspector Pushvinder Singh, Sub-Inspector Jaspreet Singh, and Assistant Sub-Inspector Varinder Kumar, stayed in Moldova for a week to complete the legal process.

Police say Dalam is named in cases involving murder, attempted murder, extortion, and violations of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, the Arms Act, the Explosives Act, and the NDPS Act. Additional Director General of Police (AGTF) Promod Ban said he is wanted for the 2019 murder of Dalbir Singh in Batala, the 2024 double murder of Amrjeet Lal and Kashmiri Lal in Hoshiarpur, the 2025 killing of Dharamjit Singh (also known as Dharna), the 2025 double murder of Kanav Mahajan and Sarabjit Singh (also known as Kaka), and the 2025 murder of Jasdeep Singh (also known as Deep Cheema).

A police team from Hoshiarpur, made up of deputy superintendents, has reached Delhi to take

custody of the accused in connection with FIR No. 168 dated October 20, 2024, filed at Bulloval police station for the Hoshiarpur double murder. Of the 21 cases against him in Batala, Gurdaspur, Hoshiarpur, Amritsar, and Ludhiana, four are on trial, and 17 are still under investigation.

DGP Yadav praised the AGTF and OFTEC and thanked the authorities in Moldova and Azerbaijan, along with the CBI, the Home Ministry, and the External Affairs Ministry. “The Punjab Police will continue to remain firmly committed to bringing criminals to justice no matter where they may be hiding,” he said.

Dalam, whom investigators describe as a key hitman and frontman of the Bhagwanpuria network, is being seen as a test of whether the Punjab overseas fugitive unit can turn intelligence and Interpol notices into actual courtroom appearances. The police have said the accused will now have to stand trial in the cases where he is already on trial.

Ladakh: Ex-MP warns Sonam Wangchuk against new protests

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Jammu

Veteran Ladakh leader and former Member of Parliament Thupstan Chhewang on Saturday warned climate activist Sonam Wangchuk and representatives of the Ladakh and Kargil Apex bodies against “hitting the streets” while advising them to exercise restraint and avoid any action that could create another tense situation in Ladakh.

He warned that if agitation resumed and another situation like that of September 24, 2025 arose, those leading or calling for it would have to take responsibility for the consequences.

Interacting with the media after returning from New Delhi, where he participated in the September 9 meeting with the MHA sub-committee, Thupstan Chhewang said the recent meeting between the LAB, KDA and the Union Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) was “fruitful” and witnessed positive discussions

on several key issues concerning the Union Territory of Ladakh.

He, however, expressed disappointment over how the meeting’s outcome was presented to the public by the LAB and the KDA, noting that several positive developments and points of consensus discussed during the meeting were not brought before the people.

Immediately after the talks, the LAB and the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA) leadership expressed disappointment over the outcome, saying the Government failed to produce the much-awaited draft on a proposed elected body for the Union Territory.

Climate activist and Leh Apex Body (LAB) member Sonam Wangchuk said there has been “no special progress” since the May 22 meeting. He warned that the Ladakh groups could resume agitation if major decisions were taken before an elected democratic body was established.



Ex-MP Thupstan Chhewang. Sonam Wangchuk



Chhewang stated that he had generally refrained from appearing in public on these matters but felt compelled to speak out now because of the “positive developments” achieved after several rounds of discussions.

The recruitment and constitutional safeguards had been discussed extensively, he said, adding that a consensus emerged on several aspects, including the demand for safeguards under Article 371, which was discussed during the May 22 meeting.

He mentioned that while

demands for statehood and inclusion under the Sixth Schedule remained part of the broader political discourse, discussions eventually moved towards finding practical constitutional and administrative safeguards for Ladakh.

Highlighting the recent MHA meeting, Chhewang said the proposed UT-level representative body was among the major issues discussed.

He said the LAB and the KDA discussed direct elections, and several options were considered regarding

the electoral mechanism.

He also emphasised Ladakh’s tribal character and said that, given the presence of Scheduled Tribes, there should be adequate representation and provisions for nomination in the proposed system.

The issue of constituencies and ensuring equal representation and rights across areas was also discussed, with suggestions sought from the participants, he said.

Chhewang said that the discussions had reached a stage where there was a clear understanding that the proposed UT-level body should be taken forward.

He claimed that the delay in moving forward was not from the MHA side but from differences within the LAB and KDA over the sequencing and implementation of the proposed institutions.

The former MP also criticised Wangchuk’s ‘call’ for renewed agitation, including an ultimatum linked to the fulfilment of Ladakh’s demands.

Sagar liquor deaths: MP forms judicial panel to probe incident

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Bhopal

The Madhya Pradesh Government has constituted a one-member judicial commission to investigate the deaths linked to suspected toxic liquor in Banda tehsil of Sagar district. The commission will be headed by retired Madhya Pradesh High Court judge Justice Vishnu Pratap Singh Chauhan and will submit its report to the State Government within three months.

According to an order issued by the General Administration Department, the commission will function from Sagar and examine the case on three key points. First, it will determine the cause, nature and circumstances surrounding the deaths and illnesses reported after consumption of the suspected poisonous liquor. Second, it will assess whether officials of the Excise Department, police and other responsible agencies discharged their prescribed duties. Third, the commission will recommend measures to strengthen monitoring and enforcement so that such incidents do not recur.

The judicial inquiry follows Chief Minister Mohan Yadav’s visit to Sagar earlier this week, when he met survivors and ordered a judicial probe into the tragedy. The State Government had officially confirmed 15



Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav

deaths by September 10, though some media reports placed the toll considerably higher. Authorities have also been treating several affected people at hospitals in the region.

The case initially triggered a magisterial inquiry after residents of villages in the Banda area fell ill following consumption of suspected spurious liquor. Investigators have since focused on an alleged interstate supply network. Reports have linked the suspected counterfeit liquor to a racket with connections in Lalitpur in neighbouring Uttar Pradesh, with bottles allegedly packaged to resemble legitimate Madhya Pradesh liquor brands.

Police action has intensified as the investigation has expanded. Recent reports said investigators had identified around 30 accused and arrested 17 people in connection with the alleged illegal liquor network.

In historic first, 3 Indian Air Force pilots deployed to train UK’s Royal Air Force

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Trainees have become trainers, thereby proving India’s excellence in the niche field of fighter jet flying. In a historic first, three Indian Air Force (IAF) pilots will train the young Royal Air Force (RAF) pilots in the UK. The appointment comes nearly 100 years after the British formed an air force in colonial India. The IAF celebrates its raising Day every year on October 8.

Sharing a photograph of the three pilots on social

media, the IAF said: “Three IAF QFIs have joined RAF Valley, Wales, to instruct Royal Air Force pilots — marking the first deployment of Indian QFIs to the UK.” The IAF described the move as “a landmark step in strengthening our shared commitment to professional excellence, interoperability and enduring India-UK ties”.

The team is led by a Squadron Leader-level officer. The Indian instructors will train RAF pilots on the BAE Hawk T2 aircraft, which is also used by the IAF for the

final training module of its fighter pilots.

The three trainers will train the British pilots at RAF Valley in Wales. They joined as Qualified Flying Instructors (QFI), a first in the deployment of Indian QFIs for training RAF pilots. Their posting to the UK will be for two years. They will be under IAF command while working under RAF commanders for instructional duties.

The Indian instructors will train RAF pilots on the BAE Hawk T2 aircraft, which is also used by the IAF for the



final training module of its fighter pilots.

The Hawk is the RAF’s advanced jet trainer and forms the final stage of training for pilots before they graduate to the more sophisticated frontline, heavier and faster aircraft.

The decision to send IAF pilots to the UK was taken in February this year after the two countries agreed to enhance military training engagements following the conclusion of the 19th UK-India Air Staff Talks in New Delhi.

The deployment adds to an expanding exchange of military instructors between the two countries. Three British military academies currently host Indian officers as instructors from the respective services.

In January this year, an IAF officer was posted as an instructor at the Royal Air Force College Cranwell, which trains the next generation of RAF officers. The Britannia Royal Naval College Dartmouth has had an Indian Navy officer as an instructor since May 2024, while an

Indian Army officer was deployed as an instructor at the Royal Military Academy Sandhurst in May 2025.

The growing defence cooperation stems from the “India-UK Vision 2035”, released in June last year. Defence is one of the five key pillars of the vision. The two countries have also adopted a 10-year Defence Industrial Roadmap aimed at deepening collaboration in advanced technologies and complex weapons, besides supporting innovation and co-development.

States Focus



PRASHANT KISHOR MOCKS JD(U)'S RENAMING BID

Jan Suraaj Party founder Prashant Kishor has derided the JD(U) over its leadership considering renaming the party 'JD(U)-Nitish', saying it "does not matter" as the outfit was run by "appointees of Union Home Minister Amit Shah" to serve the interests of its ally, the BJP.

The Bankipur MLA, who is a former JD(U) national vice president, made the remark late on Friday night, when reporters sought his response to the Nitish Kumar-led party's renaming bid. "It does not matter what new name the JD(U) is given. The fact is, today the JD(U) is not being run by Nitish Kumar. The party is being controlled by Union Home Minister Amit Shah. A couple of his appointees are there whose job is to ensure that the party serves the BJP's interests," he said. Kishor did not drop any hints as to whom he was calling "appointees" of Shah. His remarks assume significance against the backdrop of disgruntled JD(U) leaders pointing fingers at national working president Sanjay Kumar Jha and Rajiv Ranjan Singh "Lalan". (PTI)



CM REVANTH MOBILISES YOUTH FOR TELANGANA 2047 VISION

Underscoring that the State Government is bringing in transformational changes in education, Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy on Friday said he would involve not only Gen Zs, but Gen Alpha and Gen Beta to achieve the vision of making the State a 3 trillion dollar economy by 2047. In a marathon speech of more than two hours in the Assembly on Friday night, the CM, who holds the education portfolio, said the State Government aims to increase the State budget's allocation to education to 15%. He claimed that the previous BRS regime allocated 18,955 crore (6.53 %) to education in 2023-24, while his administration increased it to ₹23,729 crore (7.78%) in 2025-26. (PTI)

Telangana Assembly passes bill to decriminalise minor offences

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

The Telangana Legislative Assembly on Saturday passed a bill aimed at improving ease of doing business and decriminalising minor offences, in line with the Union Government's Jan Vishwas legislation.

State Legislative Affairs and Industries Minister D Sridhar Babu said the Telangana Praja Vishwasam (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2026 has been drafted in accordance with the Central legislation, which decriminalised over 180 minor offences and replaced them with monetary penalties.

He said the objectives of the bill also include providing scope for compromise in certain offences of law to reduce legal disputes, improving transparency and regulatory efficiency and scrapping outdated and



unnecessary legislation.

Replying to the debate, he said the Industries department officials held consultations with various other departments and identified over 400 offences that can be decriminalised to promote ease of doing business.

The Industries Department would make efforts to create awareness on rules and regulations of the legislation, he said.

Responding to concerns raised by members, he said the Government would

Bihar flood situation remains grim, nearly 48 lakh affected

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

The flood situation in Bihar deteriorated on Saturday, with the number of affected people increasing to nearly 48 lakh across 15 districts, while several rivers, including the Ganga, were flowing above the danger levels.

The Water Resources Department (WRD) cautioned against sudden and rapid riverbank erosion and directed its officials to maintain close vigil at vulnerable locations.

"Due to the rise in water levels of several rivers, approximately 47.92 lakh people in 575 gram panchayats across 87 blocks in 15 districts have been affected by the floods," the Disaster Management Department said in a statement issued on Saturday.

The flood-hit districts are Patna, Bhojpur, Saran, Vaishali, Bhagalpur, Begusarai, Buxar, Samastipur, Munger, Katihar, Lakhisarai, Khagaria, Purnia, Madhepura and Araria.

The count of flood-affected



people was 47.33 lakh on Friday evening.

The Government also instructed officials to ensure prompt reporting of any erosion incident and to keep adequate resources readily available at vulnerable locations.

Incessant rain in Bihar, coupled with downpours in catchment areas of Nepal, has caused several rivers and streams to swell, officials said.

The state has recorded 104.1 mm of rainfall in September so far, about 27 per cent above normal, they said.

The Disaster Management

Department said the Ganga at Sultanganj in Bhagalpur was flowing at 36.48 metres at 6 am on Saturday, 1.98 metres above the danger level, though the water level was receding.

The water levels of the Gandak at Dumariaghat, the Kosi at Baltara and Kursela, the Burhi Gandak at Khagaria, the Ganga at Digha, Gandhi Ghat, Hathidah, Bhagalpur, Kahalgao and Munger, the Punpun at Sripalpur, the Bagmati at Benibad, and the Ghaghra at Darauli and Gangpur Siswan were flowing above the danger marks, the Water Resources

ECI meets Mamata-led TMC, Ritabrata group over rival organisational claims

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Election Commission of India (ECI) on Saturday met with the representatives of both the Mamata Banerjee-led Trinamool Congress and the group led by West Bengal LoP Ritabrata Banerjee amid their competing claims over the party's authorised signatories and organisational elections.

The separate meetings with the two groups took place ahead of the Nandigram and Rejinagar Assembly bypolls scheduled for October 6.

The Mamata Banerjee-led party, in its submissions before the poll panel, maintained that there was no dispute over the party's organisational structure and questioned the basis of the rival claim, the Trinamool Congress (TMC) said in a statement issued after the meeting.



A five-member delegation, comprising Derek O'Brien, Kalyan Banerjee, Sagarika Ghose, Saket Gokhale and advocate Abhinav Singh, represented the Mamata-led party before the ECI.

The delegation pointed out that the MLAs backing the rival claim had contested the elections on a TMC ticket only five months ago, with Mamata Banerjee signing the party symbol under which they fought the polls, the statement said.

Department said. It stated that a sudden reduction in water levels could increase the risk of bank erosion, posing a threat to vulnerable stretches of riverbanks and embankments.

The department officials have been directed to immediately inspect any location showing signs of sudden erosion, bank collapse, or rapid movement of the river current towards the bank, and to initiate necessary preventive and protective measures without delay.

"A total of 1,245 community kitchens are being operated in various districts for flood-affected people. In addition, 13 relief camps remain functional. In these facilities, arrangements for accommodation, food, medical care and other essential items have been made for 12,260 flood-affected people", the Disaster Management Department said.

So far, approximately 3.50 lakh polythene sheets, 57,100 dry-ration packets and 1,400 food packets have been distributed among flood-hit people.

Will withdraw candidate if Mamata contests bypoll: Ritabrata Banerjee

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Ritabrata Banerjee-led faction of the Trinamool Congress on Saturday said it would withdraw its candidate from the upcoming West Bengal Assembly bypoll if Mamata Banerjee decides to contest, saying it wants the former chief minister back in the Assembly.

Ritabrata Banerjee, Leader of the Opposition in West Bengal, said the faction had more or less finalised its candidate for the bypoll but would withdraw the nominee if Mamata Banerjee chooses to contest, even as an independent.

"We want Dr Mamata Banerjee to come to the Assembly. It will be better if she comes from Nandigram," he said, referring to the constituency from which she lost the 2021 Assembly election.



The remarks came amid a dispute between the Mamata Banerjee-led All India Trinamool Congress and the Ritabrata faction over the party's name and election symbol.

The Election Commission is hearing the rival claims, with two Assembly bypolls scheduled in the State.

NIA searches 10 locations across J&K in LeT terror case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

The National Investigation Agency (NIA) on Saturday conducted searches at 10 locations in Jammu & Kashmir in connection with a cross-border terror conspiracy involving Pakistan-based handlers of the proscribed terrorist organisation Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) and their alleged network of local Over Ground Workers (OGWs). The searches were conducted at locations in Kupwara, Kulgam, Bandipora, Baramulla and Sopore to unearth further evidence relating to the conspiracy and to ascertain the roles of individuals providing logistical and other support to infiltrated terrorists.

The case, initially registered as FIR No. 0024/2026 at Police Station Zakoor, Srinagar, was subsequently re-registered by NIA as RC-02/2026/NIA/JMU under Section 23 of the UA(P) Act, 1967, Sections 7 and 25 of the Arms Act, 1959, and Section



4 of the Explosive Substances Act, 1908. According to a statement issued by the NIA, the investigation commenced following the arrest of an OGW, associated with LeT, during the late-night hours of 31st March 2026 at a naka point. A hand grenade and live ammunition were recovered from his possession. Further investigation subsequently led to the arrest of Pakistani nationals linked to the conspiracy and revealed the identities and suspected roles of members of the local support network.

Investigation conducted so far has revealed linkages

between Pakistan-based LeT handlers and their local associates, who were being used for communication, movement and concealment of infiltrated terrorists, provision of shelter, reconnaissance and other logistical facilitation. NIA is also examining the financial trail, communication channels, movement of the accused, and the source and supply chain of arms and explosives, to establish the complete network and uncover the extent of its activities.

The searches conducted on Saturday are part of NIA's continuing investigation

into the larger conspiracy and the support mechanism facilitating cross-border terrorism. During the searches, further incriminating material relevant to the case was seized/secured, which is being examined and corroborated with other evidence collected during the investigation. NIA continues its investigation to identify all persons involved in the conspiracy and establish their respective roles.

Meanwhile, the State Investigation Agency (SIA), Jammu, also conducted searches at five locations in the Mandi and Surankote areas of District Poonch and the Ramnagar area of District Udhampur in connection with an ongoing investigation into a case involving alleged propagation of secessionist narratives and radicalisation activities through online and offline communication channels, including social media platforms from across the border.

MP HC refuses to drop Damoh school hijab coercion case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jabalpur

The Madhya Pradesh High Court has declined to quash criminal proceedings against four former office-bearers and employees of a school in Damoh accused of compelling girl students to wear hijabs and follow certain religious practices.

Justice Himanshu Joshi, while dismissing the petitions on Friday, observed that the allegations recorded in the FIR were specific in nature and could not be brushed aside at the preliminary stage. The court said the truthfulness of the accusations would have to be examined during trial on the basis of evidence.

The petitions had been filed by former school office-bearers Shaileendra Kumar Jain and Abdul Wasim Bari,



teacher Anas Athar and peon Rustam Ali. They had sought quashing of the FIR registered in connection with allegations concerning Ganga Jamuna Higher Secondary School in Damoh.

The controversy dates back to May 2023, when a poster showing girl students, including Hindu students, wearing hijabs triggered complaints and prompted

the State Government to order an inquiry into the functioning of the school.

Following complaints from students, the district administration constituted an inquiry committee. On the basis of its findings, police registered a case under Sections 295-A, 120-B and 506 of the Indian Penal Code, along with relevant provisions of the Juvenile Justice

Act and the Madhya Pradesh Freedom of Religion Act, 2021.

The allegations included claims that students were required to wear hijabs, offer namaz and study Urdu, while practices such as wearing a tilak and kalava were allegedly discouraged or prohibited.

The High Court noted that the FIR referred to allegations of pressure, intimidation and coercion being used to enforce a particular dress code and religious practices upon students. In view of these specific accusations, the court held that the case could not be treated as groundless at this stage. It said the claims and counterclaims would have to be tested through evidence before the trial court. Police have already filed a chargesheet in the matter, and further proceedings will continue in accordance with law.

Security forces recover body of JeM terrorist in Jammu & Kashmir

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

A joint team of security forces on Saturday recovered the decomposed body of a Pakistani Jaish-e-Mohammed (JeM) terrorist along with an M4 rifle from the forested area of Seoj Dhar in Doda district.

J&K Police, in a post on X, said that SOG Doda, Rashtriya Rifles (RR) and CRPF retrieved the remains of a Pakistani Jaish-e-Mohammed terrorist who had been neutralised earlier in a joint operation.

"You Can Run, But You Can't Hide!" the police said, adding that a night-enabled M4 rifle was also recovered.

According to police, natives in the Seoj Dhar



area initially reported the sighting of a suspected decomposed body along with an M4 rifle in the general area of Divshetar on Saturday.

The security forces were mobilised and rushed to the area to retrieve the dead body.

The body of the terrorist, neutralised during an earlier encounter, was found in the upper reaches of Seoj Dhar, connecting Bharderwah

valley with Udhampur and Kathua districts. "Security forces have reached the area and are conducting further investigation to ascertain the identity of the deceased and establish other relevant details," a senior police officer said. Since last year, the Doda-Kishtwar belt has witnessed a series of high-intensity anti-terror operations to neutralise the foreign terrorists hiding in the area.

According to official sources, security forces have neutralised several terrorists, including Pakistani JeM commander Adil, in Kishtwar's Chhatroo.

The security forces also neutralised three JeM terrorists during Operation Trashi in February 2026 in Kishtwar.

Kharge slams Gujarat Govt over water contamination



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Saturday targeted the Gujarat BJP Government over a CAG report revealing water contamination in select villages and alleged that, during its 28-year rule, the party has only peddled false rhetoric and propaganda in the State.

"Modi ji's 'Har Ghar Jal' claims have been washed away in contaminated water," he said in a post on X, claiming that 90 per cent of water samples in the state were found to be unfit for drinking. "When Modi ji was CM, the 'Sujalam-Sufalam' scheme was loudly trumpeted in 2004. Even today, Gujarat's people are still

yearning for a drop of water," he said in his post in Hindi.

The Congress chief claimed that when he became the prime minister, the same empty rhetoric reached the 'Jal Jeevan Mission'. "Now, the CAG has exposed the BJP Government's claim of 100 per cent tap connections in 2022. 14 lakh households are still waiting for water," Kharge alleged.

He claimed that the situation is such that just last week in Dholka, Ahmedabad district, there was news of 54 deaths from cancer due to drinking contaminated water. In Saurashtra, areas like Rajkot and Jamnagar are still yearning for drinking water, he claimed, adding that farmers in Kutch-Saurashtra are struggling due to drought.

Activist Jarange announces indefinite stir in Mumbai from September 19



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jalna

Activist Manoj Jarange on Saturday announced that he and his supporters would start an indefinite hunger strike at Azad Maidan in Mumbai from September 19 for Maratha quota in jobs and education, the stir coming amid the heavily-patronised Ganpati festivities from September 14 to 25. He will begin his march towards Mumbai from September 15, Jarange said at a press conference in Antarwali Sarati as his stir in Jalna entered the 15th day.

The protesters marching towards Mumbai will halt in Patoda in Beed on September 15, Srigonda in Ahilyanagar district the next day, Hadapsar in Pune district on September 17, Khopoli in Raigad district on September 18, before camping in Khoparkhairane in Navi Mumbai and proceeding to the metropolis, he said.

The protesters would cover around 100 kilometres each day before reaching their designated halting points, Jarange said, adding the indefinite hunger strike at Azad Maidan in south Mumbai would begin at 10 am on September 19.

"We have to continue the agitation peacefully until we return from Mumbai with reservation for our community. No one should resort to stone-pelting or arson. Vehicles should be driven properly and everyone should follow the code of conduct. We want to protest through democratic means and secure our rightful demand," Jarange said.

BRICS seeks faster, safer cross-border payments

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

BRICS leaders on Saturday called for practical measures to make cross-border payments among member countries faster, cheaper, more transparent and secure, as the grouping seeks to deepen financial cooperation.

In the New Delhi Declaration, the grouping recognised the need for harnessing the collective potential of BRICS to build a more self-reliant BRICS insurance ecosystem to support trade among members, and further discussion on enhancing reinsurance capacities.

In this regard, the Declaration said members expressed interest in taking forward the discussions on India's proposal to host a BRICS Risk Lab, open to participation by interested members, at the GIFT City International Financial Services Centre (IFSC) in Gujarat. "We look forward to further discussions regarding enhancing BRICS members' (re)insurance capacity, with the voluntary participation of relevant stakeholders, com-



prising regulators and reinsurance companies from BRICS countries," it said.

The Leaders acknowledged the efforts of the BRICS Payment Task Force (BPTF) towards exploring pragmatic solutions for efficient cross-border payment mechanisms, drawing on the guidance provided by us in the Kazan and Rio Declarations, on the BRICS Cross-Border Payments Initiative.

"In this regard, we

acknowledge the work done to study the cross-border interoperability of payment and messaging channels, and the discussions on promoting trade settlements and investments using BRICS local currencies, while respecting national priorities and acknowledging that there is no one-size-fits-all approach," it said.

Leaders agreed that the BPTF will continue discussions, building on the

ines central bank measures and sustainable finance trends, including efforts to explore the possibility of making climate finance projects more bankable, globally as well as within BRICS countries.

It reaffirmed commitment to deepening pragmatic economic cooperation and advancing a closer economic partnership among BRICS members.

It recognised that the Strategy for BRICS Economic Partnership continues to serve as the overarching framework guiding our cooperation, providing the basis for the further development of sectoral strategies, programmes and roadmaps under the ownership of member countries.

Recognising the progress made towards the conclusion of the Strategy for BRICS Economic Partnership during Brazil's Chairship in 2025, it commended India for its leadership in 2026 in fulfilling the mandate given by Leaders in 2025, by successfully steering progress of the Strategy for BRICS Economic Partnership 2030.

USFDA conducts assessment of Dr Reddy's Mexico facility



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Pharmaceutical major Dr Reddy's Laboratories on Friday said the US health regulator has conducted a records assessment of its active pharmaceutical ingredient (API) manufacturing facility in Mexico and issued two observations.

The assessment at the facility – Industrias Químicas Falcon de Mexico, SA de CV (Dr Reddy's Laboratories Ltd) – has been completed by the United States Food and Drug Administration (USFDA), the company said in a regula-

ry filing. The assessment was carried out between July 17 and September 8, the filing said, without sharing details of the observations made by the US health regulator.

A records assessment by the USFDA refers to a regulatory review where the agency requests and examines a manufacturing facility's documentation and records to evaluate compliance.

"At the conclusion of the assessment, the USFDA issued a Form FDA 2953 containing two observations, to which we will respond within given timeline," Dr Reddy's Laboratories said.



Photonence, the Indian distribution partner of South Korean medical aesthetics company Classys, has launched Ultraformer in India, combining Volnewmer and Ultraformer technologies for non-invasive skin tightening and lifting. The treatment aims to improve skin firmness, smoothness and youthful appearance with minimal downtime. The launch comes amid rising demand for advanced aesthetic procedures in India, where the market is projected to reach \$383.79 million by 2032. Priced at approximately ₹2.5 lakh, Volformer reflects growing access to Korean aesthetic innovation. Photonence will support dermatologists and plastic surgeons through practitioner training and technology support, strengthening India's evolving medical-aesthetics ecosystem.

GST department seizes 50 tonnes of goods at Nizamuddin station

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government's Goods and Services Tax (GST) department, in coordination with railway officials, has seized a consignment of around 50 tonnes of goods, including 25 tonnes of copper scrap, at Hazrat Nizamuddin Railway Station. The total estimated value of the seized goods is around Rs 5 crore. The department had received intelligence that goods were being transported through the railway network without mandatory documents such as invoices and e-way bills.

Acting on the information, the department carried out the operation in coordination with railway officials. According to Chief Minister



Rekha Gupta, the government's aim is not just to take action but also to put in place an effective system that ensures businesses operate transparently and every due tax is collected.

The consignment had arrived at Hazrat Nizamuddin Railway Station on a train that originated in Renigunta, Andhra Pradesh. During the inspection, officials seized around 25 tonnes of copper scrap, estimated to be worth approximately Rs 3 crore. In addition,

around 25 tonnes of mixed scrap, clothing and other goods were found, with an estimated value of around Rs 2 crore. The total estimated value of the seized goods is therefore around Rs 5 crore.

The seized goods were not accompanied by the required invoices and e-way bills. The department is now conducting a detailed verification of the goods and the documents associated with them. It is also examining statutory compliance related to the transportation of goods under GST law.

According to the department, the action is an important step towards strengthening surveillance of goods transported through the railway network, in addition to road transport.

AstraZeneca's breast cancer drug Ectamah fails to achieve primary goal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Biopharmaceutical major AstraZeneca has said its Phase III SERENA-4 trial evaluating Ectamah (camizetrant) in combination with palbociclib did not meet its objective of statistically significant improvement in progression-free survival in patients with advanced breast cancer.

However, a numerical improvement was observed in the first-line treatment of patients with estrogen receptor (ER)-positive, HER2-negative advanced breast cancer who had not received any systemic treatment for advanced disease, the company said in a statement. The SERENA-4 trial evaluated the Ectamah and palbociclib combination versus an aromatase inhibitor (anastrozole) combined with palbociclib. Palbociclib is a cyclin-dependent kinase (CDK) 4/6 inhibitor. Regarding the



drug's safety, the company noted that the safety profile of Ectamah in combination with palbociclib was consistent with the known profiles of each medicine, with no new safety concerns identified.

"Whilst we are disappointed by the SERENA-4 outcome, it sharpens our focus on maximising the number of patients who can benefit from Ectamah today based on SERENA-6 and reinforces the importance of ESRI testing for patients on first-line therapy," said Susan Galbraith, Executive Vice

President, Oncology Haematology R&D, AstraZeneca.

Galbraith added that early breast cancer represents an important opportunity, and the company remains confident in the long-term potential of the drug.

AstraZeneca stated that Ectamah is also currently being evaluated in early breast cancer through the CAMBRIA-1 and CAMBRIA-2 Phase III trials, encompassing approximately 10,000 patients at intermediate and high risk of recurrence in the adjuvant setting.

NDB crucial institution for promoting sustainable development: BRICS members

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BRICS countries on Saturday said the New Development Bank (NDB) is a crucial institution for promoting sustainable development, reducing inequalities and supporting resilience in emerging economies.

"As the New Development Bank embarks on its second golden decade of high-quality development, we recognise and support its growing role as a robust and strategic agent of development and modernisation in all shareholder countries and in the Global South," said the 'New Delhi Declaration' issued by BRICS members.

The members underscored the NDB's growing role in meeting the development priorities and infrastructure needs of Emerging Markets and Developing Countries (EMDCs). BRICS also encouraged further efforts by the bank to expand steadily its capacity to mobilise resources, foster innovation,



expand local currency financing, diversify funding sources, and support impactful projects that advance sustainable development, reduce inequality, and promote infrastructure investments and economic integration.

"We recognise NDB as a crucial BRICS institution for promoting sustainable development, reducing inequalities, and supporting resilience in emerging economies," the Declaration said. The BRICS countries further encouraged the NDB to follow a member-led and demand-driven principle and continue strengthening its governance framework to enhance its institutional resilience and operational effectiveness. The BRICS also

reiterated support for the further expansion of NDB membership and expedited consideration of applications of interested BRICS countries, in line with the NDB General Strategy and its related policies.

Established in 2015 by BRICS countries, the New Development Bank is a multilateral development bank aimed at mobilising resources for infrastructure and sustainable development projects in BRICS and other EMDCs. The leaders of BRICS countries are meeting in the National Capital on September 12-13 for the 18th BRICS Summit, being held under the theme: 'Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability'.

SEBI proposes changes to expiry-day settlement price methodology

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Markets regulator SEBI on Saturday proposed changes to the methodology for determining expiry-day settlement prices of index and single-stock derivatives, following a review of the newly introduced closing auction session (CAS) framework.

In its consultation paper, Sebi proposed two options for determining the settlement prices — a blended Volume Weighted Average Price (VWAP) based on trades executed during the last 30 minutes of the continuous trading session (CTS) and the 10-minute CAS, or continuation of the existing CTS VWAP

methodology.

The proposals followed feedback received from market participants on the use of the CAS-determined closing price for settling derivative contracts on expiry. Determination of derivative settlement prices based on the closing price arrived at through CAS was among the significant areas of feedback received by SEBI.

"In view of the hyperactivity in expiring index options contracts along with IEP based derivatives trading during CAS, it is proposed to review the existing methodology for determining the settlement price of both index and stock derivatives contracts on the expiry day,"



SEBI said. Accordingly, the regulator has proposed two options for determining the settlement price.

Under the first option, called Blended VWAP, the settlement price would be based on transactions executed during the last 30 minutes

of the Continuous Trading Session (CTS) and the 10-minute CAS. The contribution of each period would be based on its actual traded value, with no fixed weight assigned to either.

Under the second option, Sebi has proposed continuing

with the existing CTS VWAP methodology, under which only trades executed during the last 30 minutes of CTS would be considered.

The regulator said the CTS VWAP could be retained as an interim methodology to provide continuity and allow market participants more time to familiarise themselves with CAS.

The methodology could subsequently transition to the blended VWAP after at least one year, subject to adequate liquidity and participation in CAS and an assessment of its functioning across different market conditions.

CAS was introduced in the equity cash segment for stocks having derivatives con-

tracts from August 3 with the objective of facilitating efficient and transparent price discovery of closing prices. Before CAS, closing prices were determined using the VWAP of trades executed during the last 30 minutes of CTS.

Under CAS, the closing price is determined through an equilibrium price discovery mechanism based on aggregate buy and sell orders in the auction. Derivatives trading, however, continues while the underlying securities undergo the CAS process.

Sebi said this assumes particular significance on expiry days, when derivatives activity can remain significant towards the close and market

participants may respond to evolving prices of underlying securities during the auction.

Sebi's initial review found significant derivatives activity immediately before and around CAS. The regulator said feedback had also highlighted movements in the Indicative Index Value (IIV) and certain index option contracts nearing expiry.

Sebi has proposed discontinuing the display of IIV, while continuing to provide the Indicative Equilibrium Price (IEP) for individual securities. It clarified that IEP is an indicative and evolving value based on orders available in the auction book and does not represent a price at which an actual transaction has

taken place. The IIV, which is derived from the evolving IEPs of constituent securities, similarly should not be interpreted as the index actually trading at that level.

The regulator has also sought views on the relative timing and duration of CTS, CAS and derivatives trading, besides certain operational aspects of the auction framework. Sebi has invited comments and suggestions from stakeholders on the proposals till October 3. On September 3, Sebi had said it may propose changes to the methodology following the feedback and indicated that a consultation paper on the proposed framework was likely to be released in about a week.

FROM THE WORLD

BULGARIA

Govt probe depot explosion

Bulgarian authorities have launched investigations into an explosion at a weapons storage site in central Bulgaria overnight that came in the wake of another blaze at a munitions depot in recent weeks.

Interior Minister Ivan Dermendzhiev on Saturday told reporters that no one was injured in the blaze with investigations ongoing.

He also indicated that the incident might be linked to a previous fire at another facility of the EMCO in August. "There is a neglect of the conditions," Demerdzhiev said, putting blame on the management. "There is also neglect of the method of security – we have one incident, we have a second. (AP)

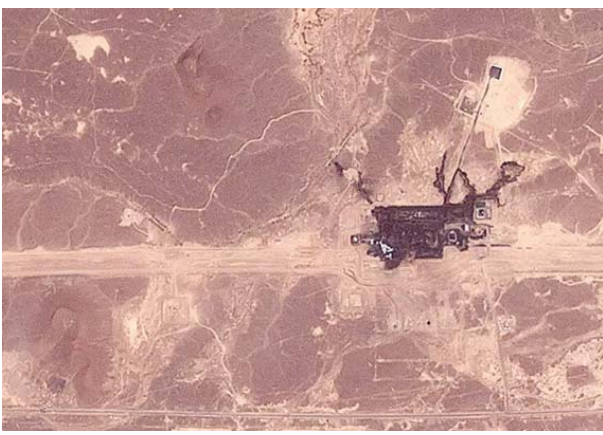
Iraq Govt scrambles as militia attack shuts Saudi pipeline

JULIA FRANKEL/ QASSIM ABDUL-ZAHRA
■ Baghdad

Iraq's Government was racing on Saturday to contain the fallout after local Iran-backed militias were accused of attacking and shuttering a key Saudi pipeline.

Though an umbrella group of Iran-backed militias in Iraq denied their involvement, Iraq's Government confirmed the attacks had originated from its territory. The Government pledged to investigate and dismissed a military commander. The country is under mounting pressure to prevent local militias from aiding other Iran proxy groups across the region. The Iraqi Government has set a Sept. 30 deadline for nonstate groups to disarm, but several of the most powerful militias have said they will not comply.

Pressure to disarm the militias is especially acute as the Iran-backed Houthi rebels



A general view of an infrastructure site after it was damaged by fire southeast of Medina along the general route of Saudi Arabia's pipeline

make an advance across Yemen's west coast in a major setback to the Saudi-backed coalition that risks escalating the war in the region. The Houthis on Friday seized an island in the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, a key shipping lane through which around 12 per cent of global trade passes.

Their virtual control of the strait could send global oil prices - already inflated by the six-month Iran-US war - spiralling.

Iraq to probe attack on Saudi pipeline

A group of Iran-backed militias in Iraq denied they were responsible for the attacks on the east-west Saudi oil pipeline in a statement Saturday, while praising the

Houthis for their "ongoing battlefield victories against Saudi forces." The group said it would cooperate with the Iraqi Government's investigation. Iraqi Prime Minister Ali al-Zaidi said earlier Saturday that he'd ordered an investigation into the operations command of Maysan province, along the border with Iran, and dismissed the province's commander.

Saudi Arabia shut down the major, cross-country oil pipeline on Friday, saying it was a "precautionary measure" after the pipeline came under drone attack. It blamed the attacks on several drones that came from Iraq, but said the kingdom would not retaliate, to give the Iraqi Government "an opportunity to take the necessary measures." Several Arab countries on Saturday, including Kuwait, the United Arab Emirates, Oman and Egypt, condemned the attack, according to the Saudi state news agency. (AP)



Ferry MV June Aster smolders off Palawan province, western Philippines days after it caught fire

Rescuers pull more bodies from burned Philippine ferry as death toll hits 76

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Coron

Rescuers retrieved more remains from a passenger ferry in the Philippine that was gutted by fire, bringing the death toll on Saturday to 76 with 13 missing.

Forty-three people survived the fire on Wednesday night among the 132 on board. The ferry sailed from the capital, Manila, and was some 39 kilometers (24 miles) from its destination in Coron, in southwestern Palawan province, when the fire erupted.

The cause has not been determined but the coast guard spokesperson quoted a survivor as saying it may have started from the cargo hold. The survivor recounted hearing a blast, with smoke and fire quickly spreading, fanned by the

winds, officials said. Tents were put up in the Port of Borac in Coron, where body bags were brought down from a ship that transported them from the ferry.

Commodore Noemie Cayabyab, the coast guard spokesperson, said authorities were looking for the ship's captain, who reportedly survived but is not listed among the survivors.

The multiagency maritime safety and criminal investigations will look into all angles, and the possible liability of the captain and crew, she added.

Cayabyab said survivors recounted the fire spread quickly, with no time to get life jackets. A tarpaulin that shielded the open areas of the ship from the rain "may be a possible contributing factor but we can't deter-

mine now if they were trapped inside," she added.

Investigators will also check if fire emergency procedures were followed, including if the captain sounded an alarm or gave a warning and instructions, and if the crew assisted the passengers.

Ferries are frequently used for transport in the Philippine archipelago. Sea accidents are not uncommon due to storms, badly maintained vessels, overcrowding and spotty enforcement of safety regulations, especially in remote provinces.

In 1987, the ferry Dona Paz sank after colliding with a fuel tanker in the central Philippines, killing more than 4,300 people in the world's deadliest peacetime maritime disaster.

**SOUTH CENTRAL RAILWAY**
Follow us on [@SCRRailwayIndia](#)
Details of the Tender Notices of S.C.Railway can be seen on our website : [www.scr.indianrailways.gov.in](#)

TENDER NOTICE
On behalf of The President of India, Sr. Division Signal & Telecom Engineer, Hyderabad Division, South Central Railway, Secunderabad Invites open Tenders For The Following Works Through E-procurement Up To 11.30 Hours of **Dated.06.10.2026** Tender Dated 10.09.2026

Tender No.: Y-SG-36-2026-27-18
Name of the work: Hyderabad Division: Signal & Telecom arrangements (1) Reliability improvement of GWD-PASR & PASR-IRC Section Block Circuits and Provision of Multi Section Digital Aisle Counter (MSDAC) Complete System in dual detection to existing Track Circuits at PASR Station Yard, (2) Modification of Circuits to suit Kavach at 4 Stations i.e., BMO, FM, UR & DTP (as per new policy, 3) Provision of Path Redundancy and Media Redundancy for Signalling Systems i.e., Electronic Interlocking, Automatic Signalling, MSDAC and Data Logger in Automatic Signalling Section of MED-BMO and FM-UR Sections, 4) Extension of existing RCC ABS Hut (Relay Room & Battery Room) in connection with the work of "Replacement of Track Circuit with Multi Section Digital Aisle Counter (MSDAC) on STPD A' KCG-FM and STPD 'B'-MUF-CVB-BMO Auto Sections", 5) Extension of existing RCC ABS Hut (Relay Room & Battery Room) in connection with the work of Replacement of Analog Aisle Counter on Loop Lines with MSDAC on entire Station at VDI, GWD, KOQ, WPR, MQN & BDHN Stations" & 6) Proposed Construction of Gate Hut (Relay Room & Battery Room) in connection with "Interlocking of Level Crossing Gate Nos. 57, 95, 174, 231, 235 & 238". **Tender value** (₹): 17,76,93,993.67 **EMD** (₹): 35,53,900.00

For document and other details, login to <http://www.irops.gov.in> Any corrigenda will be issued online only

Sr. Division Signal & Telecom Engineer, Hyderabad

TENDER NOTICE NO: 24/2026. Dt.11.09.2026.

SUPPLY OF STORES ITEMS e-Procurement Tender Notice

The Following Tenders Have Been Floated Online. Tenders Are Requested To Visit The Website [www.irops.gov.in](#) And Submit Their Offers Online. The Tender Description, Qty, EMD, SD May Be Seen In Website. Offers Manually Will Not Be Accepted. Offers By Post Will Not Be Entertained. Tender Closing Time is 14.30 Hrs Of The Due Date Of The Tender. "For All Indigent Offers, EMD Will Be Accepted Only Via Online System As Available On [www.irops.gov.in](#)."

Tender No.	Brief Description
LH257455B	Supply and installation of FRP modular toilet
LU256192A	Track measuring system for surveying railroad geometry model track scan 2.01 for broad gauge 1676 mm
LT265989	Digital rail clip force computing equipment as per attached Specification
LH265746B	Eddy current array equipment
LH265747A	Supply and commissioning of portable LIBS spectrometer
33261588	Silent block
LH266472	Traction alternator complete
LT265305	Track measuring system for surveying railroad geometry model track scan 2.01 for broad gauge 1676 mm. as per RDSO specification attached

Note:-Due dates of Tender Opening:SL.No.01 on dt.15.09.2026. SL.No.02 on dt. 22.09.2026 SL.No.03 on dt.23.09.2026 SL.No. 04 & 05 on dt. 24.09.2026 SL.No.06 on dt 28.09.2026. SL.No. 07 & 08 on dt.05.10.2026,
Beside Above Mentioned Tenders There Are Other Tenders Having Value Above **Rs.50 Lakhs**. For Details, Please Visit Railway Website
Principal Chief Materials Manager/Secunderabad

Train derails in France and injures 44 as authorities probe possible sabotage

THOMAS ADAMSON ■ Paris

French authorities are investigating whether sabotage caused a train derailment that injured 44 people in Normandy, after a piece of rail was found on the track, police told The Associated Press on Saturday.

The regional train was carrying 186 passengers from Rouen to Caen when it derailed Friday evening at Cleon, in the Seine-Maritime department of northwestern France.

An 18-year-old woman was among the injured and was evacuated by helicopter to Rouen University Hospital, police said.

A spokeswoman for the French national police communications service, known as SICOP, said that the piece of rail found on the track was "probably" linked to the derailment. She spoke on condition of anonymity because she wasn't authorised to be publicly named in line with police policy. Investigators were working to establish whether the circumstances were accidental or involved sabotage,



the service said. The prosecutor's office remained cautious about drawing conclusions, according to the police. France's previous rail disasters include the July 2013 derailment at Bretigny-sur-Orge, south of Paris, which killed seven people.

In November 2015, a high-speed TGV train carrying out tests derailed at Eckwersheim, near Strasbourg, killing 11. More recently, a crash involving two high-speed trains at Adamuz in southern Spain killed 46 people and injured more than 100 in January, according to the Andalusian regional Government. (AP)

NOTICE INVITING e-TENDER
(through <https://irops.gov.in>)

CE/C-II/SC, CE/C-III/SC & CE/C/CPC/SC Construction Organization, S.C. Railway, Secunderabad, respectively, invites e-tender on behalf of the President of India for the following works:

1. NIT No.: EPC-12-CAO- C-SC- 2026
Date: 31/08/2026 **Name of work:** Engineering, Procurement and Construction (EPC) Contract for Quadrupling (Laying of New 3rd & 4th Lines) of tracks between Sulehali west and Kurugunta (KOT) stations including Electrification and Signalling & Telecommunication works in connection with Wadi- Secunderabad Quadrupling project in the state of Karnataka. **Estimated Cost** (₹): 11227773386.83 **EMD** (₹): 224555500.00 **Completion Period:** 36 (Thirty Six) Months.**Date of Opening:** 12/11/2026 15:00hrs

2. NIT No.: EPC-13-CAO- C-SC- 2026
Date: 08/09/2026 **Name of work:** South Central Railway (Construction Organization): Engineering, Procurement and Construction (EPC) Contract Agreement for "Construction of new BG railway line between Chainage 114.400 Km and Chainage 146.180 Km (i.e., 31.78 Km) between Pro. Siricilla (Excl.) - Pro. Vemulawada (Incl.) - Pro. Kothapalli (Excl.) Stations of Manoharabad - Kothapalli Section of Hyderabad Division, in the State of Telangana" **Estimated Cost** (₹): 7492938012.60 **EMD** (₹): 149858800.00 **Completion Period:** 36 (Thirty Six) Months.**Date of Opening:** 18/11/2026 15:00hrs.

3. NIT No.: 46-CAO-C-SC-2026
Date: 07/09/2026 **Name of work:** SCR Construction Organization: Hyderabad Division - Secunderabad - Dhone section - Provision of new Additional Loop line (as common loop line) at Divitipalli station in Telangana State **Estimated Cost** (₹): 131582821.01 **EMD:** (₹) 2631700.00 **Completion Period:** 12 (Twelve) Months. **Date of Opening:** 29/09/2026 15:00hrs

i) For bid document and other details, please login to website <https://irops.gov.in>.

ii) Tenderers can submit their offers online during tender submission period which is the Fifteen days period prior to closing of tender.

iii) Tenderers should watch for any corrigenda (issued online only) up to the date of commencement of the tender submission period.

Chief Administrative officer/Const/ A744 Secunderabad

For further tender conditions / details and for downloading the tender documents, Please visit website at <https://www.irops.gov.in> or www.scr.indianrailways.gov.in

Niger's junta leader appoints new head of military following mutiny

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Niamey

Niger's junta leader appointed a new armed forces chief, less than two weeks after a deadly mutiny threatened the junta's grip on power.

General Abdourahmane Tchiani named Brig. Gen. Mamane Sani Kiaou chief of staff of the armed forces in a decree read on state television late Friday. No reason was given for the change.

Kiaou replaces Maj. Gen. Moussa Salaou Barmou, a junta member who had served as top military commander since the July 2023 coup that ousted democratically elected President Mohamed Bazoum.

The reshuffle followed a nearly 24-hour mutiny in the capital Niamey on Aug. 28 and 29. Mostly young soldiers took other members of the armed forces hostage at Base 101, a military base at Diori Hamani International



Airport, and fired at sensitive sites, according to Niger's Defense Ministry.

The mutineers appeared to be aggrieved over worsening militant violence and poor conditions within the military, analysts and diplomats said. Some came from areas in Niger's south and west that have been hit

hardest by attacks. New armed forces chief Kiaou previously served as army chief. He is a veteran field commander who has overseen operations against armed groups in the western Tillaberi region and southeastern Diffa region, according to local media.

US President Trump calls united Ireland fantastic in Dublin

DARLENE SUPERVILLE/ JILL LAWLESS ■ Dublin

US President Donald Trump said on Saturday that a unified Ireland would be "fantastic," wading into a complex and politically charged subject during a weekend visit to a major golf tournament at his Irish golf course.

At a meeting with Irish Prime Minister Micheal Martin in Dublin, Trump said he would love to see the reunification of the Republic of Ireland with the UK's Northern Ireland.

"I don't want to cause any problems but I'd love to see it unified," Trump said. "It's going to happen eventually. It may as well happen now. "I think it would be a fantastic

thing," he said, adding that "the UK will have something to say about it, obviously."

Competing visions of Northern Ireland — whether it's Irish or British — drove decades of violence in Northern Ireland that left some 3,600 people dead. Previous American presidents have avoided commenting directly on the subject, even those, like Biden, with strong emotional ties to Ireland.

When Ireland, long dominated by its bigger neighbour Britain, became a self-governing Roman Catholic-majority country a century ago, a six-county region in the north with a Protestant majority remained part of the United Kingdom.

Northern Ireland was split between two main commu-



nities: nationalists — most of them Catholic — who desired union with the rest

of Ireland, and largely Protestant unionists, who wanted to stay British.

Tensions eventually exploded in the Troubles, three decades of violence involving paramilitary groups on both sides and British troops.

A 1998 peace accord that the US was instrumental in striking largely ended the violence, but left Northern Ireland's ultimate status unresolved. Trump also held talks on Saturday in Dublin with his Irish counterpart Catherine Connolly and will address the US and Irish business leaders at the US ambassador's official residence in Dublin, before travelling to his oceanfront golf club in Doonbeg, on the other side of the country, to watch the Irish Open.

Connolly is a left-wing politician who was among those who protested when

Trump visited Ireland in 2019, during his first term in office. She is now Ireland's elected, largely ceremonial head of state. A supporter of the Palestinian cause, she in the past has criticised US policy in the West Asia and called Trump a "bully."

Trump plays golf just about every weekend at clubs he owns in Florida, New Jersey and Virginia.

His attendance at the Irish Open continues his trend of appearing at high-profile sporting events — and having a hand in organising some of them in ways that benefit his family business. His clubs in Doral, Florida, and Bedminster, New Jersey, have each hosted professional golf tournaments this year. (AP)

Lebanese authorities have detained a relative of ousted Syrian President Bashar Assad along with the son of a notorious drug dealer in northeast Lebanon on charges of carrying weapons and drugs, officials and the Lebanese army said on Saturday.

Suleiman Assad and Ali Zeiter, son of Noah Zeiter, the suspected drug trafficker arrested last year, were detained Friday near the northeastern city of Baalbek, said the two judicial officials, who spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorised to speak to the media. Suleiman Assad is the son of Hilar Assad, a cousin of the ousted president. A number of Syrian officials and relatives of Assad have fled from Syria to other countries including Lebanon, after the five-decade Assad family rule came to an end in December 2024, when Islamist rebels seized power. Bashar Assad and his younger brother, Maher, have been living in Russia. (AP)

Lebanese Army detains Bashar Assad's relative



BASSEM MROUE ■ Beirut

BRIEFLY

Deepika, Atanu, Dhiraj among stars for second edition of APL



Four-time Olympian Deepika Kumari and World Championship silver medalist Atanu Das will lead the home recurve squad when the second edition of the Archery Premier League (APL) begins on October 8 in Hyderabad, featuring international stars such as world number one Marcus D'Almeida and Dutch compound legend Mike Schloesser. India's 36 best archers, reigning Asian champion Dhiraj Bommadevara, will compete alongside 12 international stars from 10 different countries in Hyderabad. India's compound section is equally stacked, anchored by multi-time World Cup and Asian Games champion Jyothi Surekha Vennam and Abhishek Verma, joined by former World Champion Ojas Pravin Deotale. The domestic stars will go head-to-head against an international lineup featuring Tokyo 2020 Olympic champion Mete Gazoz of Turkiye, Paris 2024 bronze medalist Casey Kaufhold of the United States, Barzil's D'Almeida, World Number 2 Ella Gibson of Great Britain.

(PTI)

Muay Thai event held in Delhi

In a bid to popularise Muay Thai in India, a live demonstration of the martial art that originated in Thailand was held here, with leading Thai promoter Khun Ariyawat and trainers from the country showcasing the sport recently. Muay Thai is a traditional Thai martial art and full-contact combat sport that uses eight points of contact – the fists, elbows, knees and shins. During the event, Gongsak Yodmani, Governor of the Sports Authority of Thailand, unveiled the Royal Thai Government's vision of bringing India and Thailand closer through Muay Thai in a video message. Yodmani described Muay Thai as a key national soft-power asset for Thailand, combining cultural heritage with economic potential, and said the Sports Authority of Thailand would wholeheartedly support the initiative in India.

(PTI)



Lowry sets record at Doonbeg, builds 3-shot lead in Irish Open



Shane Lowry finally had a great day with the putter and made the most of it by setting the course record with an 8-under 62 at Trump International Ireland to build a three-shot lead going into the weekend at the Irish Open. Lowry went from wanting to get off the course as quickly as possible in the wind-blown opening round to wishing a day like this wouldn't end. He made birdie on half of the holes and was hitting his irons so well that only three of the birdies were outside 10 feet. "Every time I kept making birdie, I just kept going, wanting to birdie the next," Lowry said. "I felt like I was in control out there. So it was good fun. It's been awhile since I've had that much fun on the golf course, so I'll take it." He was at 11-under 129, three shots clear of Haotong Li (63) and the Danish duo of Jacob Skov Olesen and Niklas Norgaard, who each shot 64. Li also enjoyed a spell of good weather on the Doonbeg course along the Atlantic coast after Thursday when the wind was so strong it took some six hours to play. The first round had to be completed Friday. "Yesterday was kind of like a little bit bad weather. Even some of the 3-feet par putts, I felt like they were shaking," Lie said. "But today it was kind of like birdie heaven." That wasn't the case for defending champion Rory McIlroy, pleased with his game from the tee until he had the putter in his hand. McIlroy struggled to read the greens, and the 18th summed up his round of 69 when he three-putted from 4 feet for bogey, missing a 20-inch par putt.

(AP)

India storm into junior Women's Asia Cup final

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Moqi (China)

Drag-flick specialist Supriya put up a fine show as the Indian women's team entered the final of the AHF Junior Asia Cup with a convincing 5-1 victory over South Korea in the first semifinal here on Saturday. Supriya was the star of the show, completing a hat-trick through three clinical penalty-corner conversions, as the defending champions underlined their title credentials. India will now face the winner of the second semifinal between hosts China and Japan in the summit clash. Both teams began cautiously, with the intensity of the

knockout encounter leading to a cagey opening phase. India gradually settled into their rhythm and began creating openings, eventually breaking the deadlock in the 13th minute. A well-constructed attacking move saw Madhu Sidar provide the finishing touch to give India a 1-0 lead. The goal gave India added momentum and they began dictating proceedings in the second quarter, making regular incursions into the Korean circle. Their pressure earned a penalty corner in the 17th minute, and Supriya stepped up to unleash a precise drag-flick past the Korean defence and double India's advantage.



India continued to control possession and territory, and their attacking intent was rewarded again in the 21st

minute. A superbly directed aerial ball into the Korean 23-metre area found an Indian winger, whose well-timed

Solheim Cup: Europe builds 7-5 lead after US pair Korda and Corpuz finally lose

STEVE DOUGLAS
■ Den Bosch (Netherlands)

Team Europe finally took down the record-setting U.S. partnership of Nelly Korda and Allisen Corpuz at the Solheim Cup on Saturday on the way to winning the morning four-somes and building a 7-5 lead after three sessions. The top-ranked Korda and Corpuz had won their first five matches as a team dating to 2023 - an unprecedented feat in the Solheim Cup - but were beaten, 3 and 2, by Swedish pair Maja Stark and Linn Grant in the lead match at Bernardus Golf in the Netherlands early on Day 2.

It set the tone for a big session by the Europeans, who got another point from Mimi Rhodes and Nastasia Nadaud as they became the first rookie duo to win two matches at a single Solheim Cup. Then, in a significant late-morning rally, Leona Maguire and Esther Henseleit won two of the final three holes to beat Jennifer Kupcho and Rose Zhang, 1 up, in the final match of the session. It was the only one that went to No. 18. The only negative on



a big morning for Europe was another setback for its star English pairing of Charley Hull and Lottie Woad, who were thrashed 6 and 5 by Alison Lee and Lauren Coughlin in a result that tied the record margin of victory in a Solheim Cup foursomes match. Hull and Woad, the only European players in the world's top 10, have contributed just a half-point from three outings together so far this week but have been retained as a pair by captain Anna Nordqvist for the afternoon four-balls. Korda, meanwhile, was rested by U.S. captain Angela Stanford. Coughlin, still unbeaten in the Solheim Cup (5-0-2), will go out again and be the only American to play five matches.

After back-to-back split sessions on Day 1, there was finally separation between the teams, and history suggests that is a big deal. Since 1998, the team that held a lead at the end of the third session has gone on to win 11 of those 13 occasions. The United States, which has an 11-7-1 advantage in a series that dates to 1990, is the defending champion and needs 14 points to retain the crystal trophy. In the last match on the course, Maguire and Henseleit were 1 down and in trouble on the 16th hole, with Maguire having pushed a wild second shot near to the grandstand. Henseleit chipped along a bank and down to 6 feet, with Maguire making the hole-winning

birdie putt to tie the match. There was more short-game magic to come from Henseleit, whose chip from left of the green on No. 18 settled inside 2 feet to ensure a par. Kupcho and Zhang couldn't match it, with Zhang putting the face of a fairway bunker with her second shot. "A little short game master class from Esther," said Maguire, who has reached 10 points in the Solheim Cup quicker - in 14 matches - than any other player in history. Indeed, it was quite the final hour for Henseleit, who removed her shoes and socks, put on some wet-gear and stepped into a stream beside the 15th green in an attempt to hack out a second shot after Maguire hit a drive that dribbled into the water. It was all in vain - Henseleit's recovery shot plopped straight up and down off the bank and rolled back into the water. "Why not?" That was the reaction from Nordqvist when she was asked what made her throw together Nadaud and Rhodes in their first Solheim Cup.

Maaya, Sushkova bow out in US Open junior doubles semis



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New York

India's Maaya Rajeshwaran Revathi and her Ukrainian partner Antonina Sushkova's impressive run at the US Open junior girls' doubles came to an end with a 6-7(2), 2-6 semifinal loss to American twins Annika and Kristina Penickova here. The unseeded Indo-Ukrainian combination, however, put together an impressive campaign, knocking out seeded opposition on their way to the last four. Maaya and Sushkova began their giant-killing run by stunning the fifth-seeded Czech pair of Jana Kovackova and Katerina Zajickova, before producing another major upset against the fourth-seeded Russian duo of

Felitsata Dorofeeva-Rybas and Anna Pushkareva, winning 6-4, 6-4 in the quarterfinals. Their semifinal opponents, the Penickova twins, had reached the last four after beating the eighth-seeded Alyssa James of Jamaica and Polina Skliar of Ukraine 6-4, 6-4. For Maaya, the doubles run provided a strong response after her singles campaign ended in the second round. The 15th seed had opened her singles campaign with a comfortable 6-2, 6-2 win over American Emery Combs before going down fighting to Russian qualifier Arina Malygina 3-6, 7-5, 5-7 in a marathon second-round contest. Maaya fought back from a set and a break down in the decider and saved four match points before narrowly missing out.

Pranavi Urs targets Asian Games medal, eyes LET breakthrough and LPGA dream

AMIT KUMAR DAS
■ New Delhi

Indian golfer Pranavi Urs believes India's women's team has the firepower to challenge for gold at the Asian Games, but says consistency, sound driving and creating enough birdie chances will matter more than chasing unrealistic numbers in Japan. India will field a six-member golf squad at the Asian Games, with Aditi Ashok, Diksha Dagar and Pranavi forming the women's team, while Yuvraj Sandhu, Veer Ahlawat and Saptak Talwar will represent the country in the men's competition. "I don't really want to think about the outcome. I think I'm just going to stick to my process and give it my best shot," the young golfer from Mysuru, who will next play at La Sella Open in Spain, told PTI in an interview. "As

golfers we don't play a lot of team sport, it's more of an individual sport. So to go out there and try and like do for your country and as a team is something that I really look forward to this year. And with Aditi and Diksha being on the team, it'll be a good week." Shiv Kapur is the last Indian to win the gold medal at the 2002 Asian Games. "I think just giving ourselves opportunities a lot more, chances for birdies and driving the ball well. I think as a whole, it just needs to kind of come together and not necessarily a low number. But I think if you're being consistently like shooting three-four under every day would automatically put you in contention," Pranavi said. The 23-year-old, who has been competing extensively on the Ladies European Tour (LET), said the Asian Games field should not feel dramatically different from the



regular international circuit, with several leading players from countries such as Singapore and Hong Kong also familiar opponents from the LET. "I'm not going to look at it as like a separate event or anything. I think I'm just going to go out there and try and do my best and hopefully win a medal," said Pranavi, who finished tied 17th at Irish Open in August. Pranavi will also draw confidence from her growing experience on the interna-

tional circuit and her strong performances in India. She was the first woman to win an event in the Indian Golf Premier League (IGPL), beating a field that included leading male professionals. Her victory came after an impressive 60, a performance that remains among the highlights of her career. "Honestly, what IGPL has done for Indian golf is phenomenal. I don't think any of the other tours have done what they've done," Pranavi

said, describing the mixed-gender format as a "good healthy competition" that shows the capabilities of both men and women golfers. Her recent international campaign has also included good showings at events such as the Irish Open and Dutch Open, while she has previously registered top-10 finishes in Spain and Sweden. The Mysuru-born golfer's journey began almost by accident. She picked up golf at around five-and-a-half years of age and initially visited the Mysuru Golf Course more for the horses at the adjoining turf club than the sport itself. A year later, her father entered her in a South Zone event in Mysuru. It was her first tournament on a golf course, and she won. "I think from then onwards, it's just been golf," said Pranavi, who finished tied 4th in her rookie year at the Hero Indian Open in 2024.

Pranavi has since built a reputation as one of India's longest hitters, identifying driving as one of the strongest parts of her game. But she believes her approaches and course management are the areas that must improve if she is to make the next jump in her career. "My coach and I, we have the stats app that I fill in my stats after every round. And he has all the data. So, by the end of the week, we get on a call and kind of see what areas have improved and what areas can be improved," she said. "To get to the next level, I think I had to kind of focus on that a little bit more and kind of course management." Pranavi is working with coach Steven Giuliano and said her immediate focus remains on improving her approach play and putting herself in better positions to score.

(PTI)

Ben Shelton to play Zverev for US Open title

BRIAN MAHONEY
■ New York

Ben Shelton and Frances Tiafoe had a packed crowd sprinkled with celebrities cheering equally for them, as the two fan favourites fought to reach their first major final. The crowd figures to be almost entirely on Shelton's side Sunday, because now he's the American hope to end a lengthy Grand Slam drought. Shelton pulled out a 4-6, 6-3, 6-3, 7-5 victory on Friday and will play No. 1 seed Alexander Zverev on for the U.S. Open title. The host nation hasn't had a men's major winner since Andy Roddick won in Flushing Meadows in 2003. "I'm going for it here, and I'm going to leave it all on the court," Shelton said. "I hope you guys come and back me. Let's do it for the USA."



Carlos Alcaraz in a quarterfinal match that ended Wednesday at 3:33 a.m., the latest finish ever at the U.S. Open. Now he needs to stop the French Open champion, who knows what's at stake for the other side. "Hopefully I can not make the American dream come true on Sunday," Zverev said. Zverev beat Karen Khachanov 6-3, 7-6 (7), 7-6 (6)

in the first semifinal. Shelton and Tiafoe drew a star-studded crowd that included stars from sports, including Serena Williams, Jalen Brunson and of course U.S. soccer player Trinity Rodman, Shelton's girlfriend; and actors Salma Hayek, Ben Stiller and Rami Malek. "This is where we want to be: at the tail end of this tournament," said Shelton, a

23-year-old from Georgia who was less than a year old when Roddick won his title. "This is both of our favorite tournament in the world, our favorite court in the world and to be able to light it up in front of (this crowd) is the best feeling that there is." Tiafoe fell to 0-3 in the U.S. Open semifinals, the last two against fellow Americans. Taylor Fritz beat him in 2024 before losing to Jannik Sinner. "I wanted to be in a Grand Slam final. Obviously it was a big match," Tiafoe said. "Ben played well tonight. Served really well tonight, which made it really tough on me." After a ceremony to mark the 25th anniversary of the 9/11 attacks in which a giant American flag was unfurled across the court, it was Tiafoe who played the cleaner tennis in the first set. He committed just three unforced errors to 14 by Shelton, whose double-fault at 4-4 gave Tiafoe the break he needed.

(AP)

Last non-European to win men's tennis major says Shelton can end drought

ERIC NUNEZ ■ New York

Ninety Grand Slam tournaments have passed since Andy Roddick defeated Juan Carlos Ferrero in the 2003 final at Flushing Meadows. Since then, no other US male player has managed to win the US Open on home soil or any of the other three majors. Apart from Argentina's Juan Martin del Potro at the 2009 US Open and his compatriot Gaston Gaudio at the 2004 French Open, every champion across the world's four major tournaments has been European. On Friday night, Ben Shelton won in four sets the all-American US Open semifinal with Frances Tiafoe and now will attempt to end the long wait for another men's Grand Slam champion from the United States. Shelton will play Alexander Zverev in



the final. "You know the history; it was the era of the Big Three" (Roger Federer, Rafael Nadal, Novak Djokovic) - something unmatched," Del Potro told media ahead of the Shelton-Tiafoe semifinal. "But American tennis has the potential to break this pattern. There are so many good players now with the potential to be Grand Slam champions, and I sincerely believe Tiafoe or Shelton

can do it." As the last Grand Slam champion born outside of Europe, Del Potro takes pride in walking the grounds of the US Open. Talking for a living The winner of the 2009 Open - who defeated Federer in the final to deny the Swiss star a sixth consecutive title at Flushing Meadows - now works as an analyst for ESPN Latin America. "I'm so happy to be back in this special place," the Argentine said.

"It's always a pleasure to be here. They still treat me like a champion, which feels great." His first day in this new role was grueling, featuring two men's quarterfinals: First, Tiafoe's victory over Alex Michelsen, followed by Shelton's win over Carlos Alcaraz - a match that set the record for the latest finish in tournament history, ending at 3:33 a.m. on Wednesday. "I don't have the experience and it's not easy at all, but I'm enjoying it a lot," Del Potro said. "My first day ended at 4 a.m." His triumph at Flushing Meadows at age 20 hinted at further major victories. However, a punishing series of injuries intervened: He underwent three surgeries on his right wrist, one on his left wrist, and four on his right knee from 2019-21.

(AP)



1st T20I: Tough choice between Samson and Sooryavanshi

KUSHAN SARKAR
■ New Delhi

India face a dilemma over whether to opt for 'Boy Wonder' Vaibhav Sooryavanshi's no-holds-barred aggression or stick with the experience and unmatched flair of Sanju Samson as they take on Afghanistan in the opening game of the three-match T20I series starting Sunday.

While Sooryavanshi was drafted in the playing eleven in England at the expense of Samson, it is only fair to

mention that by the last match of the series, the 15-year-old had to make way for his senior partner's return.

It is not a straightforward choice although Samson-Abhishek Sharma is a more stable T20I pair which has done fairly well. One can only hope that Gambhir and skipper Shreyas Iyer will give equal chances to both Samson and Sooryavanshi if possible before finalising the XI for the Asian Games matches in Japan.

During Friday's evening net session, Samson did look

slightly more in control compared to Sooryavanshi, who got a masterclass from Jasprit Bumrah on how to face quick bowling with movement off the surface. It could have been a case of the youngster taking time to adjust after playing three back-to-back red-ball games.

Also Sooryavanshi could take the Afghan attack to the cleaners with none of the opposition bowlers remotely close to Bumrah's quality. The pace at which they bowl could also suit Sooryavanshi's minimal footwork and stand-



and-deliver game. In Samson's case, dropping him in England after just three failures in a high-risk format seemed unfair. But the

remain insulated from outside noise.

But there could be a scenario where both Sooryavanshi and Samson end up playing if Ishan Kishan, who had a back injury scare during Friday evening's net session, is ruled out of the game. Kishan, who is coming into the game after a magnificent Duleep Trophy final in which he scored 270 and 80, wouldn't want to miss playing the only format where he is an India regular.

For the Indian squad that will be taking part in the

Asian Games, three matches against a full-strength Afghan team with a world class spin attack in Rashid Khan, Noor Ahmed and Mujeeb ur Rahman is the best preparation that one can get.

Not to forget that seam attack comprising Fazalhaq Farooqi, Naveen-ul-Haq supported by all-rounders Gulbadin Naib and Azmatullah Omarzai which can pose a few problems if the 'tired' Feroz Shah Kotla track, after a month-long DPL, offers assistance to the bowlers. Save for the dilemma at the

top of the order, the other talking point in India's playing XI will be the spinners who take the field. Gambhir's affinity for multi-skilled players is well known by now, and hence Axar Patel and Washington Sundar are expected to feature in the line-up. The question is whether India would go for a third specialist spinner in Varun Chakravarthi or field a specialist seamer Yash Thakur. Bumrah and Arshdeep Singh are automatic picks along with all-rounder Nitish Kumar Reddy. (PTI)

India eye eighth title win in Women's T20 Asia Cup final against Sri Lanka



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dubai

Seven-time champions India will look to Shafali Verma and Deepti Sharma to deliver once again when they take on a resilient Sri Lanka in the Women's T20 Asia Cup final here on Sunday.

With 168 runs including two fifties, Shafali has not only been India's best batter but also the leading run-scorer in this iteration of the continental event, going about her task unfazed by the slow and spin-friendly nature of the wickets here at the Dubai International Cricket Stadium. Even as Smriti Mandhana (154) has blown hot and cold for having struck a brilliant century but also two single-digit scores, Shafali has been able to maintain consistency with the bat.

More importantly, Shafali has relatively executed her strokes with ease in games where others around her have struggled.

Deepti, the tournament's leading wicket-taker alongside Sri Lanka skipper Chamari Athapaththu with 11 wickets each, has been at the forefront of India's bowling attack. Even with the bat, the senior Indian all-rounder has been a key presence. Her six-ball 13 against Bangladesh in the semifinal

was instrumental in pushing the total close to the 150-mark. With the parsimonious Shree Charani in the mix and Prema Rawat also finding her rhythm, Deepti leads the all-important spin attack which has played a dominant role in several matches of this tournament.

While both teams have wind in their sails having gone undefeated so far in their march to the final, India will be wary of the gritty Sri Lanka side which had handed them a crushing eight-wicket defeat in the last edition's final in 2024. Athapaththu's side has displayed the same determination that their skipper has shown throughout her chequered career, with the most recent example being their perseverance to secure a win over Pakistan against the odds in the semifinal.

Being reduced to 5/2 inside the first two overs and slipping further to 33/4 in the seventh, Sri Lanka did not give up the chase of 131.

Harshitha Samarawickram a top-scored with 36 and found strong support from fireworks each, has been at the forefront of India's bowling attack. Even with the bat, the senior Indian all-rounder has been a key presence. Her six-ball 13 against Bangladesh in the semifinal

I enjoy leadership and it helps my batting: Padikkal set to lead India A

G UNNIKRI SHNAN
■ Bengaluru

Top-order batter Devdutt Padikkal says the opportunity to captain India A is a fine "learning experience" and believes that it will have a positive influence on his batting ahead of the upcoming tour to New Zealand.

Padikkal will lead India A against Australia in two red-ball games at Puducherry from September 22.

"It's a great opportunity to be captain of India A. I'm looking forward to it. I think leadership is something that I really enjoy doing, especially starting off with Karnataka last year," Padikkal told select media. "It was a great learning curve for me, so I'm really looking forward to carrying that experience to India A as well," he added.

Padikkal has proved that that leadership role sits lightly on his shoulders while

guiding Karnataka in last season's Ranji Trophy.

His 85-ball 120 helped Karnataka overcome Punjab in a must-win group game at Mohali and reach the quarterfinals. On that occasion, Karnataka chased down 250 in just 28 overs.

"Personally, I enjoy captaincy. That's just an added responsibility to go out there and make sure that I'm helping the side. I've always played cricket that way. 'I've always wanted to make sure that the team wins. As a captain, that's your sole focus. You want to make the team win. That just helps my batting even further,'" he said.

Padikkal, who returned from the recent tour to Sri Lanka with two fifties and the Player of the Series award, continued to be in good touch in the Duleep Trophy final. The left-hander made an assured 62 for South Zone



against East Zone at Chepauk earlier this week.

"It always feels great to get some runs. I think the purpose behind coming here was to try and help the South Zone win, but obviously that couldn't happen. But personally I'm happy with the fact that I was able to get some time out there and hopefully I can continue that." More than those exter-

nal aspects, Padikkal was delighted to see the constant evolution of his batting, a by-product of playing cricket regularly against quality opponents in various conditions.

"It's a constant learning curve. There's a lot of things that I've learnt throughout the season. I think more technically than mentally. There were a few changes

that I needed to make to evolve as a batter in the last season or so.

"We're playing in different conditions. Obviously, Sri Lanka and Chennai were quite similar. But moving forward, going to New Zealand as well, it'll be interesting to see how I can adapt to different conditions," he said. The Karnataka batter emphasised that playing in

Dhiraj eyes WC final medal ahead of Asian Games

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Saltillo (Mexico)

India's top-ranked recurve archer Dhiraj Bommadevara, the lone from the country to make the cut for the season-ending World Cup Final this year, will be eyeing a maiden medal at the coveted event when he starts out against Turkey's Berkim Tumer, here on Sunday.

The one-day competition follows a straightforward knockout format beginning with the quarterfinals, meaning two wins will be enough for an archer to assure himself of a medal.

Dhiraj qualified for the elite eight-member field by virtue of his victory at the World Cup Stage 3 in



Antalya. No other Indian archer has made the cut across the recurve and compound sections in the men's and women's categories.

As for the draw, it is a relatively favourable one for the 25-year-old Army man, who opens against Tumer, an archer he defeated in the pre-quarterfinals during his

last World Cup appearance in Madrid in July, before bowing out in the last eight.

Should he clear the opening hurdle, the Vijayawada archer is likely to run into American great Brady Ellison in the semifinals. Ellison, a multiple world champion and two-time Olympic medallist, will be in Mexico to defend his recurve men's title after winning his sixth World Cup Final trophy in Nanjing in 2025. But Dhiraj has already shown that he can beat the American great, having defeated Ellison in the pre-quarterfinals of the 2023 World Cup in Antalya, a victory that helped him secure his maiden World Cup medal — a bronze.

Since then, Dhiraj has added two more bronze medals and a gold to his World Cup tally.

The Saltillo final will also serve as an important final competition for Dhiraj ahead of the Asian Games in Japan next week, with the Indian set to fly directly to Aichi-Nagoya after the World Cup. (PTI)

BRICS backs India's proposal for working group on sports technology



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Describing sport as a vehicle for social development, the BRICS New Delhi Declaration on Saturday backed India's twin proposals of forming a Working Group on Sports Technology and the organisation of a Sports Goods Manufacturing Conclave for enhanced cooperation among member nations.

The working group on sports technology and the conclave for sports goods manufacturers were among the three key initiatives that Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya listed during the BRICS Sports Ministers' meet in Visakhapatnam last month under India's Chairship.

Mandaviya had said India would play its part by contributing experts across key sporting domains to the proposed group.

"We welcome the proposal for the BRICS Sports Goods Manufacturing Conclave to promote cooperation in sports goods manufacturing, research and innovation," it added. "We also recognise the growing role of technol-

ogy in enhancing quality of performance, welfare, governance and inclusion in sports and encourage discussions on the formation of the Working Group on Sports Technology," the declaration stated. Once formed, the Working Group will strengthen BRICS cooperation in sports science, athlete performance, governance, Artificial Intelligence, digital transformation and innovation, the Sports Ministry had stated after the Ministerial meet in Visakhapatnam.

The Sports Goods Manufacturing Conclave is being planned in Udaipur, Rajasthan, in November this year and will focus on exchange of technology and innovation, while bringing together manufacturers, exporters, investors, technology providers, SMEs, start-ups and research institutions.

On the first day of the two-day BRICS summit, being held at Bharat Mandapam here, the elaborate declaration, titled 'Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability', commended the progress made by the BRICS Sports Working Group.

Townsend and Siniakova win their first US Open women's doubles title

STEPHEN WHYNO
■ New York

Taylor Townsend was tight, not moving well and could sense she was off swinging her racket early in the US Open women's doubles final.

"I wanted this really badly, and I knew that I wanted it," she said. "I felt it in my body and my spirit because I was so nervous."

Partner Katerina Siniakova talked her through the rough start Friday, and then they found their groove and rolled. Townsend and Siniakova completed their career Grand Slam as a team by defeating the wild card pair of Ashlyn Krueger and Robin Montgomery for their first US Open doubles title

together. "It just means the world to me," Townsend said. "This really means everything to me, not only just to be able to win the US Open but to be able to complete a career Slam." It looked dicey early, when Townsend and Siniakova lost the first three games and dropped the first set. At one point, the ball dropped between them, an uncharacteristic mistake for the top two women's doubles players on the planet.

Then the top seeds started looking like it with aggressive shots at the net, and they took control of the match on the way to a 5-7, 6-0, 6-2 victory at Arthur Ashe Stadium. "The match was very tight, very tough for us,



but we found a way to win it," Siniakova said. "We found a solution. I'm just really happy that we have this one, and we can celebrate it together."

The result validated Townsend's confidence in

her play after getting knocked out in singles by Number 1 Aryna Sabalenka. The 30-year-old American expressed confidence in her tennis at the time, knowing she still had another opportunity in doubles. That

turned into her fourth major championship after she and Siniakova won Wimbledon in 2024, the Australian Open in 2025 and the French Open earlier this year. It was Siniakova's 12th Grand Slam title after winning seven with fellow Czech player Barbora Krejickova and one with Coco Gauff. "It helps to have someone that's been here so many times and who has been able to get over the hump - what is it, 12? Twelve times," Townsend said.

It was an impressive run for Krueger and Montgomery, who respectively rank 570th and 610th in doubles and went through each half of defending champions Erin Routliffe and Gabriela Dabrowski separately in the quarterfinals and semifinals. Krueger and Montgomery reunited five years after winning the US Open girls' doubles title and advancing a round at the women's level in 2021.

"We're both just trying to take it all in," Montgomery said. "What we've just done has been amazing. I think we did forget that we were offered a wild card, so I'm just glad we made good use of it." Townsend and Siniakova got retribution after falling short against Routliffe and Dabrowski in the final a year ago. Townsend dropped to her knees after the final point and was all smiles as she said to Siniakova that they finally did it. (AP)

Dropped from Asian Games team, wushu player Divyanshi alleges unfair treatment, harassment

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Dropped from the Asian Games squad on medical grounds, Wushu player Divyanshi Choudhary on Saturday alleged physical and mental harassment at the hands of national federation, claiming that she has been replaced despite getting the doctor's clearance to compete in Japan.

Divyanshi was included in the seven-member wushu team for the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games in the list released by the Sports Ministry on August 22. But on Friday, she was replaced by two-time Asian Games medallist Naorem Roshibina Devi in the women's 60kg

sanda category on the ground that she has suffered an ACL tear.

The Wushu Association of India (WAI) claims that an MRI done on the athlete revealed a partial high-grade ACL tear with large effusion and that's why she was replaced.

"I am really fed up. I have been harassed so much mentally from June, July to now, it's September, I am being harassed, because she (Roshibina) wanted to go (to the Asian Games)," she said in a video which has surfaced on social media.

"Why is she not letting anyone else go? I have defeated her (in the selection trial). I have the right to go to Asian Games," said a sobbing Divyanshi, who hails from

Kota but is currently training at the NIS Patiala.

At one point, she even threatened to commit suicide, moving herself closer towards to the edge of the terrace of the building where she was standing and showing the ground below.

WAI though insisted that Divyanshi was dropped from the team only due to am injury. In a statement, WAI claimed that Divyanshi herself told the federation that she had sustained injury during the 2026 SCO Wushu Sanda Championship in Hubei, China, from June 24 to 29. Divyanshi rejoined the national camp at NIS Patiala on August 10 after spending one month at home.

"On 14th August 2026,



during training, she complained of pain stating it was due to a hamstring issue, and did not train on 14th and

15th August. During training on 17th August, she again complained of hamstring pain and thereafter did light training for the next 2-3 days," the WAI statement said.

"Due to recurrent injury, the coach asked the player and she informed that she had sustained injury during SCO event in China and she had informed her parents upon return.

She spent a month at home and then joined training camp at Patiala." WAI said after obtaining consent from her parents, an MRI was done on August 23 under the supervision of two physios at Manipal Hospital at Patiala.

"The MRI report was shown to HPD of Sports Medicine of SAI on 24th

August and she referred the athlete to an Orthopaedic doctor at Manipal Hospital for further consultation. On further clinical examination and review of the MRI by the Orthopaedic Doctor and a medical officer, she was found to have a partial high-grade ACL tear with large effusion."

"Keeping the athlete's health, safety and long-term sporting career paramount, the WAI, based on the medical advice and available medical reports, informed the Indian Olympic Association (IOA), Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports (MYAS), and Sports Authority of India (SAI) through email that the athlete had sustained an injury and had

been medically advised to refrain from competitive activity and full training session till her recovery."

On her part, a distraught Divyanshi alleged that she has been physically harassed by some people in the past also. "You know, when our 10-day camp was held in Srinagar. They injured my shoulder forcefully. Because of that, I didn't practice for 4-5 days. Then, I recovered and went to play SCO event (in China). And, I tolerated all this. In the first Dehradun trial, they forcibly defeated me. I have a video on my YouTube channel."

She claimed that doctors told her that she could play with the injury. "I had an injury. I showed it to the

doctor. The doctor said, 'by taping, you can play easily'. I wanted to play. But, my MRI reports, which were with my coach here, and with the federation, went to them. And they have it. So, why? Why are my reports being sent?"

"The doctor himself is writing in the prescription, that this player can play. So, why is this not being accepted? And, when you are taking such a big decision, at least inform the athlete. Shouldn't I have had the knowledge of all these things even once if you are removing my name," she said.

"I also needed to tell my side (of story). This is not just. It's my big dream to go for Asian Games and win there for India." (PTI)

Welcome home Bappa

Passed down through families, this art of shaping wet mud remains a deeply personal, living promise to welcome Bappa home year after year

beautiful survival of faith.

Tucked away in the canvas tents of Mayur Vihar and the packed streets of Karol Bagh, entire families pour their hearts into this intense seasonal rhythm. True heritage never really belongs behind spotless museum glass. It lives right here on these dirt floors, mixed with scattered damp newspapers and accidental splashes of bright paint. Maya squats on the ground, pulling her knees close. Her skin bears the permanent, colorful stains of raw pigment. She keeps her focus tight on the elaborate crown taking shape beneath her quick brush. "We bring plain *murtis* all the way from Kolkata," she says with a quiet, undeniable pride. "Then we redesign them completely with our own hands. We have to paint every single day. It is Bappa, so we create this beauty to welcome him every time we look at his face."

Just a few feet away, Lokesh steadies a frayed brush against a serene face, adding a single dark stroke to the eyes to capture that familiar, comforting gaze. Hundreds of finished figures sit around them, waiting patiently in bright orange turbans and cheap, glittering stones. While raw forms are imported across states, these families also build countless idols entirely from scratch, kneading their silent, everyday prayers directly into the soil.

The actual miracle of this season is not the massive public crowds. It rests entirely in the fierce devotion of these everyday creators who surrender their own spirits to carve out the divine. Through their paint-crust hands, the clay breathes, the old stories hold their ground, and a loud, joyous truth rings out: *Welcome home, Bappa.*

Ganpati Bappa Morya!

DEVOTED HANDS
Rooted in deep history, Bappa first takes form in the paint-stained hands of everyday artisans. Every sculpted smile is a raw, living prayer

PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

The Enduring Promise of 'Un Film de Almodóvar'

As Pedro Almodóvar returns with *Amarga Navidad*, a look at the filmmaker who has evolved while staying true to his cinematic instincts

GAUTAM CHINTAMANI

There was a time when Pedro Almodóvar would not have made it to my list of three filmmakers whose next film was awaited with any great impatience. This was probably true through much of the 1990s and perhaps even into the 2000s. There were filmmakers one followed more obsessively, whose new work seemed like an event even before one had seen it. Almodóvar was different. You watched a film of his and, almost invariably, came away wondering about it. Somewhere along the way, that changed.

Today, the words *Un film de Almodóvar* mean considerably more to me than they did thirty years ago. Curiously, this has happened without Almodóvar dramatically changing the world he films. The women, mothers and daughters, desire and abandonment, sex and death, actors and performance, memory and secrets have always been there.

Perhaps that is because he has never seemed embarrassed by his own instincts. *From Women on the Verge of a Nervous Breakdown to All About My Mother*, from *Talk to Her*, *Volver*, *Julieta*, *Pain and Glory*, and his best in recent years, *Parallel Mothers*, the terrain remains recognisable but the people travelling through it have changed.

Desire acquires memory, sex acquires consequence, bodies age, mothers grow older and loss begins to occupy spaces once dominated by possibility. By the time Almodóvar arrived at *Pain and Glory*, even the act of remembering desire had become as important as desire itself. This is evolution of a particularly difficult kind: evolution without repositioning.

Filmmakers with long careers are invariably encouraged to discover new audiences. Sometimes they begin speaking the language of a generation that arrived long after them. At other times, they retreat into endlessly reproducing the film for which their original audience loved them. Almodóvar has done neither. His cinema has simply grown older alongside them; Almodóvar, instead, seems to have travelled with his viewer.

This, to me, is one of the least discussed achievements of a long filmmaking career. We talk endlessly about whether a filmmaker has remained relevant but rarely ask: relevant to whom? It also makes me think of Mani Ratnam. Watching his later films, I sometimes wonder who the imagined viewer is. Ratnam has remained contemporary partly by continually recalibrating his cinema for the audience before him; the filmmaking remains recognisably his, but the conversation seems increasingly directed towards the viewer of today rather than the viewer who first entered his world through *Mouna Ragam*, *Nayakan*, *Agni Natchathiram* or *Bombay*.

Almodóvar, like Scorsese and, in a somewhat different fashion, Quentin Tarantino, belongs to an increasingly rare category of filmmakers who have maintained a compact with their audience and allowed their audiences to age. Someone who discovered Almodóvar through *Women on the Verge of a Nervous Breakdown* has aged more than three decades along with his cinema. Perhaps this explains why one is looking forward to *Amarga Navidad*, or *Bitter Christmas*, differently from the way you usually anticipate a new film from a much-followed filmmaker.

I don't particularly want to know whether, approaching five decades as a filmmaker, Pedro Almodóvar has reinvented himself yet again. I am more interested in discovering what has happened to that familiar universe since we last visited it. There are filmmakers one discovers and immediately loves. There are others whose importance reveals itself through the years, almost without announcement. Almodóvar has been the latter. Once, *Un film de Almodóvar* merely told you who had made the film; now, it tells you why you want to see it.

The writer is a historian whose work spans cinema, politics and contemporary Indian history. He is the author of *Dark Star: The Loneliness of Being* Rajesh Khanna and *Rajneeti: A Biography of Rajnath Singh*, among other books

ART CORNER

Artists break forced silence

At Delhi Art Week, galleries turn Bikaner House into a fierce defence of fading ecological history

TEAM VIVA

Have societies completely lost the ability to comprehend the shifting winds and the erased histories of the natural world? The crisis of a collapsing climate and the forced silence surrounding marginalised botanical knowledge suddenly break through the noise. This thematic reckoning anchors the ninth edition of Delhi Contemporary Art Week.

Across the halls of Bikaner House, audiences come face to face with the physical reality of a broken environment in *Bye-Bye Monsoon*. Curated by Adwait Singh, this segment pulls from Amitav Ghosh's documentation of a freak 1978 Delhi tornado to map a broader ecological collapse, connecting global oceanic breakdowns directly to the changing monsoons hitting the subcontinent. The conversation then moves fluidly into Annalisa Mansukhani's *This Animate Earth*. Here, the focus shifts to the complex relationships between plants, caste and empire. The exhibition raises difficult questions about how local communities can possibly protect their rooted histories when the ground they stand on remains so fiercely divided by old power structures.

Instead of surrendering to these challenges, the creators push back. They reclaim botany from a heavily gendered past where women's deep ecological fieldwork was written off as polite domestic decoration. As you walk through the rooms hosted by Blueprint12, Exhibit 320, Gallery Espace, Latitude 28, Shrine Empire and Vadehra Art Gallery, the raw physical toll of their work is obvious. The artists grab hold of discarded archival scraps, roots and bare earth, moulding them into blunt, tactile records of our shared loss. Taking it all in, the afternoon completely stops feeling like a predictable commercial showcase. It becomes a fierce, deeply felt response. It shows us that even when left with almost zero stage to stand on, these artists outright refuse the forced silence, making absolutely sure our oldest ecological memories stay wide awake.

FIERCE CREATORS RESCUE OUR FADING HISTORY

PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

Curated festive dressing

SAKSHI PRIYA

The festive energy of Ganesh Chaturthi inspires a beautiful refresh of our celebratory closets. Today's designers are changing how we experience heritage clothing, weaving ancient Indian craft into fluid, contemporary silhouettes where comfort takes the spotlight. Modern festive dressing relies on pairing unexpected colours with relaxed separates that transition easily from morning pujas to family dinners. To celebrate, we curated a sartorial guide featuring Matsya's quiet royalty, Punit Balana's artisanal craft, and Satya Paul's bold prints. This edit proves that heritage wear can feel wonderfully effortless.

REGALIA
Matsya captures real royal heritage, minus the heavy fuss. Expect meticulously crafted, breezy luxury built for today's festive scene.
The Edit: Whether choosing the delicately sequined Aquamarine Aurum Tissue Saree or The Polo Saree, go entirely maximalist with heavy polki chokers, vintage silver chandelier earrings, and chunky kundan bangles, keeping fresh dewy makeup for effortless modern grace.

FESTIVE PRINT
Satya Paul brings signature bold prints and fluid modern shapes together beautifully in the *Untamed* collection for your Ganesh Chaturthi celebrations.
The Edit: Pair the Gilded Chintz Saree with chunky gold studs and keep your makeup minimal to let those warm golden-hour hues shine.

BOHEMIA
Punit Balana blends royal Jaipur craft roots with relaxed, modern shapes. Classic bandhani prints and delicate resham work meet effortless kurtas and breezy pieces.
The Edit: For the vibrant sharara or that flowy kaftan kurta, just throw on some heavy antique silver earrings and simple, comfy flats. Let that gorgeous coin embroidery actually stand out. Try wearing the oversized Moh shirt tucked loosely with chunky rings for those dressy daytime parties.

Vibrant magenta and sunny mustard anchor these relaxed, flowing silhouettes with intricate traditional embroidery

Luminous floral sarees and draped dhoti skirts pair beautifully with relaxed kaftans, blending rich sunset tones for elegant

The rich, undeniably deep hue of the Polo Saree brings beautifully effortless drama to modern festive wardrobes

CELEBRATION

WHY GRANDPARENTS DAY IS OUR MOST BEAUTIFUL TRADITION

TEAM VIVA

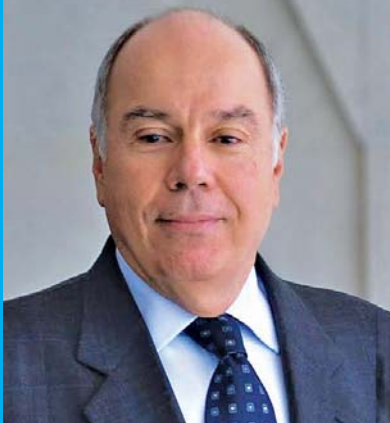
Society eagerly marks Mother's Day and Father's Day with grand gestures every single year. Yet the absolute most important celebration for every child remains National Grandparents Day, falling this year on September 13. Back in the late seventies Marian McQuade established this meaningful occasion to honour the strength of our elders and bridge a widening generational divide. Urgent office tasks constantly push family aside today while we brush off their gentle invitations to share a warm meal. We become entirely consumed by relentless daily schedules while they spend long afternoons hoping a familiar face will walk through the door. Today provides the perfect excuse to finally leave those spreadsheets behind and travel to their home. We could spend a lovely afternoon turning the pages of old photo albums to share forgotten stories. Cooking a favourite traditional recipe together brings immense warmth to the house. Even a slow walk around the local neighbourhood creates a beautiful memory. Our physical presence remains the absolute greatest joy they could ever receive.

The Pioneer AGENDA

International cooperation, multilateralism is indispensable.
— Hans Blix

BRICS SUMMIT 2026

BRAZIL



Mauro Vieira
Foreign Minister

RUSSIA



Vladimir Putin
President

INDIA



Narendra Modi
Prime Minister

CHINA



Xi Jinping
President

SOUTH AFRICA



Cyril Ramaphosa
President

FOUNDING MEMBERS

JOINED IN 2010

FULL MEMBERS

Masoud Pezeshkian
President, Iran

Abdel Fattah el-Sisi
President, Egypt

Prabowo Subianto
President, Indonesia

Abiy Ahmed Ali
Prime Minister, Ethiopia

Sheikh Khalid bin Md bin Zayed Al Nahyan
Crown Prince, Abu Dhabi

Prince Faisal bin Farhan Al Saud
Foreign Minister, Saudi Arabia

BRICS & BRICKBATS

As leaders of the BRICS nations gather in New Delhi, the summit assumes significance far beyond the conference halls. At a time when global power equations are shifting and multilateral institutions face growing challenges, BRICS represents an evolving effort to reshape the international order. The summit offers India an opportunity to strengthen cooperation among emerging economies, address shared challenges and assert its vision of a more balanced and inclusive global system

BRICS@20: India's vision for a wider world



HARSH VARDHAN SHRINGLA

The story of BRICS over the last two decades is, in essence, the story of the redistribution of global economic and political weight — away from a narrow, post-1945 core and towards a wider, more representative table. That redistribution reaches a symbolic culmination this month, as New Delhi hosts the eighteenth BRICS Summit at Bharat Mandapam on September 12 and 13, under the theme “Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability.” It marks twenty years since the idea of institutionalised BRICS cooperation was first floated, and it marks the fourth occasion.

It is worth recalling how modest the beginnings were. In September 2006, foreign ministers of Brazil, Russia, India and China met on the margins of the United Nations General Assembly in New York. BRICS today has 11 members and 10 partner countries spanning Latin America, Africa, the Gulf, Southeast Asia and Central Asia. This is no longer an acronym of convenience but arguably the most representative grouping the Global South has produced.

India assumed this fourth Chairship on January 1, 2026, and has run it at a

scale that few outside the diplomatic community have fully registered. The theme - drawn from Prime Minister Narendra Modi's articulation of “Humanity First” and a people-centric approach to multilateral engagement - has been operationalised across thirty-five ministerial and heads-of-agency tracks and roughly a hundred working and sub-working groups. More than 350 meetings have already been held across nearly thirty Indian cities, from Chandigarh to Kochi and Bhopal to Nagpur, making the Chairship a genuinely whole-of-nation exercise rather than a Delhi-centric one. The engagement has also travelled well beyond foreign ministries: Supreme Audit Institutions, Supreme Judicial Authorities, the BRICS Business Council, the BRICS Women's Business Alliance, the Think Tanks Council and the Civil BRICS Council have all been drawn into a process that India has deliberately widened beyond traditional diplomatic channels.

Underneath the architecture, the substantive work has been organised around four pillars, and it is here that the Chairship's claim to seriousness rests on outcomes rather than atmospherics. Under Resilience, ministers of health, agriculture, energy, environment and disaster management converged on a single logic: treat food, health, energy and supply-chain shocks as connected risks rather than isolated crises, and build shared institutional capacity to absorb them before they cascade across borders. That logic produced institutionalised cooperation on traditional medicine and mental wellness, a dedicated early-warning mechanism for infectious disease outbreaks, the BRICS Agriculture Research Platform and a Digital Agriculture Network intended to shield farmer livelihoods from climate volatility, and - on the energy and logistics side — Smart Grid principles paired with a Logistics Supply-Chain Cooperation Framework designed to de-risk cross-

border trade dependencies.

Under Innovation, industry, science-and-technology and ICT ministers moved the grouping towards shared cross-border facilitating: the premise that an entrepreneur or researcher in any member state should be able to plug into common financing, incubation, research and payments infrastructure. The result is a proposed Startup Innovation Fund and Incubator Network, an MSME Cooperation Portal backed by a dedicated finance dialogue, and a Science and Research Repository that Indian officials have taken to calling, with some justification, one library of science for eleven countries. The most consequential outcome for India's own digital diplomacy, however, is the Cross-Border Payment System pilot, in which India has offered its Unified Payments Interface (UPI) as the reference implementation for real-time, low-cost payment rails across the grouping — a quiet but significant projection of Indian digital public infrastructure onto a multilateral stage.

Under Cooperation, trade, justice and customs tracks reinforced a single underlying argument: that BRICS seeks to reform multilateralism from within existing rules rather than replace them, even as it builds the practical architecture for deeper economic integration among members.

CONTINUED ON >> PII

BRICS needs the K-factor to become BRICKS



ROBINDER SACHDEV

When BRICS leaders of eleven member states and representatives of ten partner countries gather in New Delhi on 12 and 13 September, the members alone will represent nearly half of humanity and around two-fifths of world output. That is considerable weight. But weight is not the same as meaning. At twenty, BRICS has accumulated the first faster than the second.

BRICS wants reformed institutions, fairer trade and a multipolar order. Fair enough. But what does BRICS believe in? Wanting is not believing. The G7, for all its contradictions, can still state an organising idea in a sentence. BRICS cannot. It has an agenda, a bank, a summit calendar, partners and aspirants. What it still lacks is a political ethic strong enough to matter when bargains stop paying.

So what is missing? I would call it the K-factor. BRICS needs a K, for kinship. Add it and the acronym spells the material -

BRICKS. But a brick becomes a brick only after firing, and this clay has been sitting in the yard for twenty years. The point is not the wordplay. The point is whether membership of BRICS means anything when it becomes inconvenient.

Today, the world and we are living in an age that I call the New-Muco Era. That is, this is a period in which a 'New World Matrix is Under Construction'. The old order of the past century is fraying and crumbling. We all seem to be in a state of worry, fear, ambiguity and hope as to what the world of tomorrow will be. This age in which we live has the opportunity and potential to architect the world of tomorrow in which our children and future generations will live.

The world of the 21st century increasingly looks to be an age in which nations, cultures and communities will inter-operate in a matrix, or can be imagined as a mesh network of states tied together by trade corridors, payment rails, data cables, energy routes and mineral chains.

That changes the arithmetic of power. Comprehensive National Power asks what a state possesses. In a networked world, position matters too: which critical connections run through you, and whom do they connect? I call this Comprehensive Nodal Power. But nodes can be bypassed. Under pressure, purely transactional networks discard weak links.

This is where kinship stops being sentimental and becomes strategic. What keeps a relationship alive when it becomes costly is not utility alone, but obligation. BRICS membership cannot abolish national interest, nor should it. But kinship lengthens the horizon of interest. Reciprocity asks what comes back. Kinship asks what is owed even when the return is not immediate. That obligation can survive disagreement and outlast a transaction.

enough obligation for disagreement not to become disintegration.

Most commentary asks what BRICS can do about a West-dominated world. I think the harder question for leaders when they meet in Delhi is this: what do you intend to do for each other? The eleven members bring different systems, interests, disputes and rivalries. Two major wars now touch BRICS directly: the Russia-Ukraine war and the US-Israeli war against Iran, which has already strained relations inside the grouping. None of this is disqualifying. Kin quarrel. But a grouping that cannot manage its own conflicts cannot credibly prescribe solutions for everybody else's.

Four tests would tell us whether BRICS is acquiring the K-factor.

FIRST: kin do not leave each other's seat at the table in doubt. BRICS demands reform of global governance, yet one permanent UN Security Council member still stops short of explicitly backing India's claim to a permanent seat in the very institution being reformed. The contradiction is hard to miss.

SECOND: kin do not price each other at market rates in a hard year. When a member faces sanctions, tariffs, a currency run or another external shock, nobody is asking others to absorb unlimited costs. The simpler question is: does BRICS membership alter the calculation at all? If it makes no difference when support becomes costly, then it is a transaction, not kinship.

THIRD: kin try the household before they go to the neighbours. BRICS will not eliminate bilateral disputes, nor should it become a supranational court. But where feasible, members should first try bilateral or intra-BRICS accommodation rather than reflexively carry their quarrels to rival power centres.

CONTINUED ON >> PII



The test is inside the room
BRICS now faces a battle of coherence. Coherence does not mean conformity. It means



"I HAVE NEVER ADVOCATED WAR EXCEPT
AS A MEANS OF PEACE"
— ULYSSES S. GRANT

Middle East war is bigger than 'Iran-vs-America'



BHOPINDER SINGH

The most revealing developments in the Middle East are no longer occurring along the conventional Iran-United States (with Israel) axis. They are unfolding in Yemen, Iraq, Saudi Arabia and the maritime choke-points interconnecting them. The recent Houthi takeover of a strategically located Yemeni island, their persistent attacks on shipping, and the reported drone attack on Saudi Arabia launched from southern Iraq point towards a conflict considerably more complex than the familiar narrative of "Iran-versus-America", with Israel in tow. Iran undoubtedly occupies a central position in the region's network of armed allies and partners. Houthis in Yemen and Iran-aligned militias in Iraq are not identical organisations, nor are they simply puppets controlled from Tehran. Each has its own domestic interests and political objectives. Yet they operate within an ideological and strategic ecosystem in which Iran's revolutionary worldview, Shia political mobilisation, and opposition to the American-backed regional order have created durable relationships.

The significance of the Houthi advance lies in its geography. Control around the Bab el-Mandeb (maritime gateway connecting the Red Sea with the Gulf of Aden) gives the Houthis leverage over one of the world's critical commercial arteries. Their ability to threaten shipping is no longer merely an extension of Yemen's civil war. It provides an Iran-aligned movement with the capacity to impose costs on Western powers, Israel and, crucially, Saudi Arabia without Iran itself having to fight every battle directly.

More revealing still is what has happened on Saudi Arabia's northern flank. Recent drone attacks against Saudi Arabia have reportedly been launched from Iraqi territory, including the southern province of Maysan. The geography matters. Southern Iraq is the country's predominantly Shia heartland and part of the wider area where Iran-aligned political and armed groups have accumulated substantial influence. Iraqi authorities' response, including the dismissal of a military commander following the attacks, underscores the seriousness of the development.



This should not, however, be interpreted as equating Iraq's Shia population with Iran-aligned militancy. Iraq's Shia communities are politically diverse, and Iraqi nationalism has often competed with Iranian influence. The significance lies in the armed organisations operating from a region where Tehran has developed considerable strategic relationships. The resulting geography is striking.

Saudi Arabia is potentially being pressured from both ends of the Arabian Peninsula - by the Houthis from Yemen and the Red Sea to the south, and by Iran-aligned armed networks operating from Iraq to the north. Iran itself sits across the Gulf. What appear to be separate theatres therefore begin to resemble elements of a wider strategic architecture of sectarian dimension. Saudi Arabia is not merely an American ally caught in an Iranian war. It is the principal Sunni Arab power confronting an increasingly assertive Iranian regional order. The rivalry between Riyadh and Tehran has always involved more than oil, territory and strategic influence. It also reflects competing political and religious identities - a Sunni Arab order dominated by established states and monarchies on one side, and an Iranian-led ecosystem of Shia or Shia-aligned movements on the other.

Yemen illustrates this convergence particularly well. The Houthis emerged from Yemen's Zaydi Shia tradition and have developed close military and strategic ties with Iran. But reducing them to Iranian proxies is equally simplistic. Their rise is rooted in Yemen's own political grievances, social divisions and civil war. Iran has provided military capabilities and strategic support; it did not manufacture every grievance sustaining the movement.

The same logic applies in Iraq. Iran does not need to command every militia or dictate every decision. It benefits from relationships with groups whose interests sometimes converge with its own: opposition to American military presence, hostility towards Israel, resistance to Saudi influence and the pursuit of greater political power within Iraq. Such relationships provide Tehran with strategic depth without requiring direct Iranian intervention in every theatre.

That is why describing these organisations merely as "proxies" can obscure more than it clarifies. They possess independent interests and local constituencies. Their relationship with Tehran is better understood as converging interests between autonomous movements and a regional power. The Middle East is therefore witnessing several wars increasingly

sharing the same battlefield.

The danger of the simplistic "Iran-versus-America" narrative is that it encourages policymakers to search for a bilateral solution to a fundamentally regional problem. Even if Washington and Tehran theoretically reached an accommodation, the underlying rivalries in Yemen, Iraq, Lebanon and the Gulf would not necessarily disappear. The larger question is not simply whether Iran can withstand the United States and Israel. It is whether the Sunni Arab states can prevent an increasingly interconnected network of Iran-aligned movements from Iraq to Yemen from converting geographical fragmentation into strategic encirclement.

The map is telling a story that the headlines often miss. The Middle East is not simply a chessboard on which Washington and Tehran are moving pieces. It is a region where local conflicts, sectarian identities, state rivalries and great-power competition are increasingly converging. That is the deeper story emerging from the Red Sea, the Gulf and southern Iraq. It is more complicated than "Iran-versus-America". And it may prove far more enduring.

The writer is a former Lieutenant Governor of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands and Puducherry, and a military veteran

FROM AGENDA COVER



BRICS@20: India's vision for a wider world

Trade ministers reaffirmed their commitment to a WTO-centred trading system while advancing the Global Value Chains Action Plan for 2026-2030; customs heads reached an in-principle agreement on a Mutual Administrative Assistance Agreement; and justice ministers adopted a declaration strengthening alternative dispute resolution mechanisms across the grouping. This is a Chairship, notably, that has resisted the temptation to frame BRICS as a rival architecture to existing institutions, choosing the more patient instead - and arguably more durable - language of reform from within.

Under Sustainability, environment, energy and industry ministers embedded community and traditional knowledge into formal climate policy, effectively turning India's own Mission LiFE ethos into a multilateral agenda. This included new Principles for People-Centric Climate Resilience built on indigenous adaptation knowledge, a Solar PV Cooperation Roadmap that extends India's International Solar Alliance leadership into the BRICS framework, fresh frameworks on forest-fire preparedness and sustainable lifestyles, and - most significant for the Global South - stronger initiatives on climate financing aimed squarely at the financing gap that has stalled climate action across developing economies.

At its core, New Delhi's participation in the grouping reflects a pursuit of strategic autonomy. It is within this grouping that India has found room to pursue partnerships, from energy security to digital payments to climate finance, on terms that reflect its own priorities and its own pace, while remaining anchored to a rules-based order. Herein lies the true import of the current Chairship: a clear manifestation of India's practised diplomatic posture - balanced engagement across varied global platforms, advancing broader inclusivity alongside concrete domestic

imperatives, while leveraging venues like BRICS to construct the resilient, self-reliant and cooperative systems required for its long-term trajectory. Twenty years after that first ministerial huddle in New York, the leaders converging on New Delhi are, in that sense, gathering around a table that India has helped make wider, and one at which it has unmistakably found its own voice.

Harsh Vardhan Shringla, Member of Parliament and former Foreign Secretary of India

BRICS needs the K-factor to become BRICKS

A family that always needs an outsider to settle its arguments has not built much confidence at home. **FOURTH:** kin show up. They show up when invited. They show up in loss and mourning, in crisis, and in happiness and celebration. Presence matters. Attendance may look ceremonial, but in relationships it is evidence.

BRICS certainly needs more capacity and better implementation. It has no permanent secretariat. But even if it had one, no secretariat, working group or task force can make members turn up for one another. Institutions can organise cooperation. They cannot manufacture obligation. And then there is expansion. Beyond the eleven sits a widening circle of partner countries. For now, I am less interested in who joins next than in whether the existing eleven can demonstrate the K-factor. Let the Delhi Declaration show that first. Enlargement can follow. An expanding family with no settled duties is not a family. It is a guest list.

Twenty years of mass. The next twenty will be decided by whether the members owe each other anything.

Robinder Sachdev is President of the Imagindia Institute, New Delhi, and author of *Trumpotopia - A Guidebook to Decode Donald Trump*

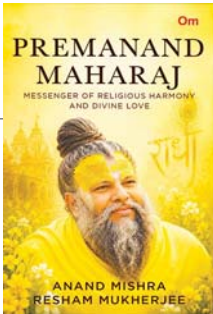
Delving into India's faith faultlines

MANISH ANAND

Premanand Maharaj draws followers from all faiths and beliefs. He trends on the internet. Star powers come to see him in Vrindavan. Yet he's content with Vrindavan and stays there. He's not opening his ashram across the country and abroad. He doesn't polarise people. He just speaks of Bhakti, reciting Radha. That's an absolute and unconditional submission to the divine, argues Premanand Maharaj in his "Ekantik Vartalaps". Journalists Anand Mishra and Resham Mukherjee, in their book *Premanand Maharaj: Messenger of Religious Harmony and Divine Love*, have arguably brought out the first authoritative biography of the saint from Vrindavan. The book traces the life journey of the saint. In the course, India's age-old spiritual heritage shines, as tales of renunciation find new subjects. Along with Premanand Maharaj, through the turns and twists in his life, the book also offers readers a fine glimpse into the philosophical evolution of a truth seeker.

In an age when instant coffee syndrome cuts through all walks of life, including spiritual teachers who offer immediate relief from the pains of life to their followers, the book reveals Premanand Maharaj holding out against the commercialisation of faith. "Your body pain will not go away with Baba's ashirvad."

To superstitious followers, the Vrindavan saint remains stern, stressing that "even if 100 cats cross my path, I will still stay on my course." The book, published by Om Shakti, states the widely known fact that Premanand Maharaj's kidneys had failed long ago and he undergoes dialysis. The saint hasn't yet accepted any offer from his followers, saying that he lives by the will of Radha. Born Amirudh Kumar Pandey in 1972 in Akhari village in Kanpur, the book states that the saint confronted the moot philosophical question at the age of 13 - what is the meaning of life? A wealthy neighbour had passed away,



Book: Premanand Maharaj: messenger of religious harmony and divine love
Author: Anand Mishra Resham Mukherjee
Publisher: Om Shakti
Price: ₹399

The young boy saw the grandeur of life reduced to ashes. To find an answer to his question, the young Pandey left home to launch himself on a spiritual path. Staying briefly with gurus, he finally made the ghats of Kashi his abode.

With singular devotion to Lord Shiva, he meditated. To beat hunger, he ate handfuls of sand. After watching *Chaitanya Leela* and *Ras Leela*, the Shiva devotee yearned to go to Vrindavan. Soon he fulfilled his wish, and over the years he has emerged as a key attraction of Vrindavan.

Premanand Maharaj comes out, per the book, as an exemplar of religious harmony as he speaks no ills of other religions. He also comes out as a voice of reason, for he rejects superstition. The saint also raises a spiritual weight against the commercialisation of faith, where the new-age Baba writes immediate remedies for the woes of the followers. Both Mishra and Mukherjee have heavily researched to find sources for the book, as they admit that ready-made materials weren't available. They went through accounts of followers on the internet. They also listened to several videos. In the end, the authors presented a lucid commentary on the life of Premanand Maharaj.

The writer is a columnist who writes on social and religious issues

DAIV ASTRO

Ancient Wisdom. Timeless Guidance.
<https://daiv.co>

This Week's Zodiac Insights

Profession • Money • Family • Relationships • Health • Travel



Mesha | Aries: This week, pending work may finally start moving, and your ideas can gain appreciation at work. You may also think seriously about creating an extra source of income. Love and family matters remain supportive, while true friends become easier to recognise in a difficult moment. **Watch out for:** Poor sleep and mental fatigue.



Vrishabha | Taurus: This week begins with confidence and clear thinking, but the latter half may bring some unexpected pressure. Support from seniors can help you complete an important assignment, while your dedication earns professional respect. Personal equations need patience, especially when emotions run high. **Watch out for:** Relationship misunderstandings and neglecting your health.



Mithuna | Gemini: This week, your communication improves and your efforts at work can bring recognition or financial benefit. Social connections remain warm, and you may feel drawn towards helping others or supporting a meaningful cause. Large financial commitments need careful thought before you proceed. **Watch out for:** Stress and concerns around a family member's health.



Karka | Cancer: This week feels lighter emotionally, and you may enjoy your work even without immediate rewards. Long-term plans can move ahead with support from people who trust you. Finances, however, need tighter control, and personal relationships may become sensitive if discussions turn rigid. **Watch out for:** Overspending, emotional friction and ignoring health discomfort.



Simha | Leo: This week, professional stagnation may begin to ease and work can bring better financial results. Colleagues may test your patience, but a calm and practical approach will help you handle them. Old friends may reconnect, while personal relationships need more compromise than confrontation. **Watch out for:** Rising expenses, family tension and physical strain.



Kanya | Virgo: This week, something you start on your own may face resistance initially but can gain support once results become visible. Career and finances remain strong, and family differences can be resolved through direct communication. New professional connections may also prove useful. **Watch out for:** Interfering too much in your partner's personal matters.



Tula | Libra: This week, your enthusiasm for new ideas, learning and experimentation can bring recognition among peers. Finances improve through careful spending and disciplined saving, while your words have a stronger emotional impact in close relationships. Take responsibility for your own work instead of depending on others. **Watch out for:** Irritability, sharp speech and overexertion.



Vrishchika | Scorpio: This week, energy and confidence remain high, and fresh professional ideas can receive a positive response. Your communication becomes stronger, helping you connect better with people around you. Financial decisions involving loans need caution, while family matters require sensitivity overall. **Watch out for:** Relationship arguments and neck or shoulder strain.



Dhanu | Sagittarius: This week, earlier efforts can bring recognition, and partnership-related work may produce useful gains. Your words carry influence, but finances need greater discipline and important paperwork should be checked carefully. A home or property decision may also move forward. **Watch out for:** Money pressure, family stress and neglecting health concerns.



Makara | Capricorn: This week, a career opportunity you have worked hard for may come closer, and your judgement improves through lessons from past mistakes. Your partner and friends can be supportive when pressure builds. Finances remain the weaker area, so spending needs control. **Watch out for:** Family safety issues, stress and unnecessary financial strain.



Kumbha | Aquarius: This week, a new initiative may gain support after an uncertain start. Career and partnership matters look favourable, and finances may strengthen through professional progress. Family life can bring happy developments, but personal relationships may still face small misunderstandings. **Watch out for:** Taking financial risks and letting minor arguments grow.



Meena | Pisces: This week, avoid rushing into decisions, especially when pressure or emotions are influencing your judgement. Work deadlines may create restlessness, while finances need tighter control and greater self-reliance. Relationships and family matters call for patience, and new acquaintances should be approached carefully. **Watch out for:** Hasty choices, arguments and ignoring health concerns.



Scan to Download
DAIV App

धर्मो रक्षति रक्षितः

A platform for spiritual seekers from across the globe

Download on the
App Store

GET IT ON
Google Play

“GOOD NUTRITION CREATES HEALTH IN ALL
AREAS OF OUR EXISTENCE.
ALL PARTS ARE INTERCONNECTED”
— T COLIN CAMPBELL

Ganesh Chaturthi: From Modak to Naivedya



ANIL
RAJPUT

Ganesh Chaturthi is one of Maharashtra's most awaited festivals, and food has always been central to the way it is welcomed and celebrated. The festival may be recognised by clay images of Lord Ganesha, flowers, lamps, aarti and the familiar call of “Ganpati Bappa Morya”, but food is among its most intimate forms of worship. On Monday, September 14, 2026, homes and public mandaps across India will welcome Ganesha on Bhadrapada Shukla Chaturthi, beginning a celebration that in many places continues until Anant Chaturdashi and visarjan on 25 September. Yet before the crowds, music and processions comes the work of the kitchen, where rice is ground, coconut is grated, jaggery is melted and family recipes are brought back into use.

Ganesha occupies a distinctive place in Hindu religious life as Vighnaharta, the remover of obstacles, and as a deity associated with wisdom, prosperity and auspicious beginnings. Ganesh Chaturthi marks his birth and has long been observed through household worship, fasting, offerings and community celebration. In Maharashtra, where the festival acquired extraordinary public prominence, Lokmanya Bal Gangadhar Tilak helped transform Ganeshotsav into a large community celebration in 1893, using collective worship as a space for social and cultural unity. Today, the festival remains equally important within the home and through large public celebrations. Families install Ganesha for different lengths of time, neighbourhood mandaps draw thousands of visitors, and daily naivedya is prepared for worship before being shared with family and visitors.

That idea of naivedya is essential to understanding the cuisine of Ganesh Chaturthi. Food is not prepared only because guests will arrive or because a festival demands abundance. Many dishes are first cooked as an offering, placed before Ganesha and only later shared as prasad. This changes the character of the meal. Ingredients, methods and even family habits may follow ritual preferences, with many homes preparing vegetarian food without onion or garlic. Ganesh Chaturthi arrives during the monsoon, and its cuisine draws on staples such as rice and coconut alongside seasonal gourds, leafy greens, colocasia, legumes and tart fruits. Across western and southern India, the foods prepared for the festival also reflect the produce and cooking traditions of each region.

In Maharashtra, this connection is seen most clearly in Ukadiche Modak. The outer shell is made from rice flour cooked with hot water into a soft dough called ukad. Small portions are pressed into cups, filled with freshly grated coconut cooked with jaggery and cardamom, pinched into delicate pleats and steamed until glossy. Served warm, often with a spoonful of ghee, the modak is both an offering and a test of inherited skill. The filling must remain moist without becoming runny, the shell must be thin without tearing, and the pleats are often learned by watching older family members rather than by following a written recipe. Many households traditionally prepare them in auspicious numbers, and the first batch is offered to Ganesha before being shared.

The same form changes character in Talniche Modak, where the dumpling is fried rather than steamed. A wheat or refined-flour casing gives it a crisp exterior and allows it to keep longer, while coconut, jaggery, nuts or sesame may enrich the centre. Maharashtra's festive sweet table can also include Puran Poli, whose soft wheat dough encloses a filling of cooked chana dal and jaggery perfumed with cardamom or nutmeg. Rolled carefully and cooked on a hot griddle with ghee, it brings a different texture to the meal. Chirote, another festive preparation, is made from thin layers of dough that are fried until crisp and then dusted with sugar or lightly coated in syrup.

The savoury side of the Maharashtrian table is just as important. Aluchi Patal Bhaji, made from colocasia leaves cooked with gram flour, peanuts, coconut, tamarind and jaggery, balances sourness, sweetness and earthiness while making use of monsoon produce. Careful cooking is important because colocasia must be thoroughly cooked, and the finished preparation becomes soft and well integrated with the gravy. Ovyachya Panachi Bhajji, made from aromatic Indian borage leaves, commonly known as ova or ajwain leaves, dipped in gram-flour batter and fried, adds a crisp, herbal element to the meal. Katachi Amti, made from the strained cooking liquid of the chana dal prepared for puran, is also an example of a kitchen making thoughtful use of every ingredient. Seasoned with goda masala and a tempering, it becomes a deeply flavoured accompaniment to the festive meal.

As the festival moves down the Konkan coast into Goa, where Ganesh Chaturthi is widely known as Chovoth, coconut becomes even more prominent, while seasonal monsoon produce plays an important part in the Chaturthi thali. Nevri is Goa's crescent-shaped relative of the karanji, a crisp fried pastry filled with coconut, jaggery or sugar, sesame and aromatic spices. Patoleo offer a softer, steamed contrast. Rice paste is spread across turmeric leaves, layered with coconut-jaggery filling, folded and steamed. As the leaves heat, their fragrance passes into the rice covering, giving the preparation a distinctive aroma while also reflecting the close relationship between festive cooking and locally available plants.

Goa also offers Panchkhaji, a festive assortment of sweet preparations

associated with Chaturthi, often built around fried dough, coconut and jaggery and made in different shapes. The Goan Chaturthi meal also has a substantial savoury side, including Khatkhatem, a mixed vegetable stew that may combine pumpkin, yam, raw banana, drumstick and other locally available vegetables with coconut and mild spices. Moong Gaathi, made from sprouted green gram in a coconut-rich gravy, adds body and protein, while Ambadyache Sasav turns tart hog plums into a sweet, sour and mustard-laced preparation. Together, these dishes show how closely the Goan Chaturthi meal is tied to the monsoon and the produce available during the season.

Further south, Karnataka brings its own set of traditional offerings. Modaka or sweet Kadubu may again use a rice-flour covering around coconut and jaggery, but local shaping and steaming traditions give the dumpling its own identity. Panchakajjaya is especially associated with Ganesha worship in Karnataka. Its name refers to a preparation made from five components, with versions combining roasted gram or another pulse, coconut, jaggery or sugar, sesame and ghee. Crumbly rather than syrupy, it is well suited to being offered and distributed as prasad. Karigadubu or Karjikayi brings back the crisp half-moon form, enclosing a sweet coconut filling inside fried pastry.

Karnataka's savoury festival foods provide a useful balance to the sweets. Kosambari, generally made from soaked split moong or chana dal with grated coconut, cucumber, herbs and a light tempering, is fresh and restrained beside richer offerings. Chakkuli, spirals of seasoned rice and pulse flour fried until crisp, can be prepared in batches for family members and visitors who come through the house during the days of celebration. In coastal households, Patholi reflects the turmeric-leaf steaming traditions also found in neighbouring Goa. The ingredients may be similar across the coast, but their names, proportions and methods often change from one community to another.

In Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, Vinayaka Chavithi brings another set of foods to Ganesha's naivedyam. Undrallu are among the most characteristic. Rice is coarsely ground or made into flour, cooked and shaped into small dumplings, often with soaked chana dal incorporated into the mixture before steaming. Mild and savoury, they show that offerings to Ganesha are not defined by sweetness alone. Kudumulu appears in several forms, including sweet versions filled or flavoured with jaggery and coconut, connecting the Telugu table to the wider family of steamed dumplings seen across southern India.

The sweet offering Chalimidi is made by combining rice flour with jaggery to produce a soft, dense preparation valued as a traditional naivedyam. Kajjikayalu, also called Garijalu in Telangana, are crisp fried pastries filled with combinations of coconut, sesame, peanuts, semolina or sugar. Their sealed edges hold a fragrant filling that contrasts with the crisp outer shell. Palathalikalu introduces a different texture. Rice-flour dough is shaped into small strands or pieces, cooked in milk and sweetened with jaggery or sugar, often with cardamom. Regional chutneys made with seasonal ingredients, including Tummi

Aaku Pachadi and tart Chintakaya Pachadi, can add sharper flavours to the wider Vinayaka Chavithi meal.

In Tamil Nadu, Vinayagar Chaturthi offers another regional expression of the rice-flour dumpling tradition. Pooranam Kozhukattai encloses coconut and jaggery inside a steamed rice-flour shell and is closely associated with the festival. Beside it sits Kara Pidi Kozhukattai, a savoury version in which seasoned rice flour is shaped by hand and steamed, often carrying the impression of the fingers that formed it. Navadhanya Sundal, prepared from a mixture of pulses or legumes tempered with mustard, curry leaves and coconut, provides a savoury offering that is also distributed as prasad. Steaming, rice and pulses remain central, but the form and seasoning are distinctly Tamil. Drinks served with the festival meal also vary considerably from region to region. In Goa, Sol Kadhi, prepared from kokum and coconut milk and lightly seasoned, can accompany the Chaturthi thali, its cooling tartness balancing fried sweets and coconut-rich vegetables. In Telugu homes, Panakam offers a different combination, with jaggery dissolved in water and flavoured with cardamom and black pepper, sometimes with a hint of ginger. Fresh buttermilk, where customary, may be lightly seasoned after a substantial festive meal, while fruit juices or simple milk may be taken by those observing forms of fasting.

Taken together, these dishes show how a shared ritual tradition changes from region to region. The modak of Maharashtra, kadubu of Karnataka, kudumulu of Telugu-speaking regions and kozhukattai of Tamil Nadu are not simply different names for the same preparation. Each reflects local ingredients, techniques and preferences. Rice flour may be steamed in one home, fried in another, wrapped in turmeric leaves elsewhere or shaped into savoury dumplings. Coconut and jaggery may become a filling, a crumbly prasad or part of a leaf-steamed sweet. Monsoon vegetables, pulses and sour fruits further connect the festival meal to the regions in which it is prepared.

That is why preserving the cuisine of Ganesh Chaturthi requires more than remembering a list of recipes. A family tradition survives when someone learns how the modak dough should feel under the palm, how tightly a turmeric leaf should be folded, how a grandmother balanced jaggery against tamarind, why a particular pulse is soaked before dawn, and why food is offered before anyone tastes it. Younger generations should inherit not only the finished plate but the knowledge behind it. In this sense, India's homes, kitchens and festivals can become an intergenerational classroom, where knowledge is passed naturally from one generation to the next through participation, observation and shared experience. Cuisine has a particularly important place in this process because every recipe carries something of a region's geography, season, ritual practice and family memory. Inviting younger members of the family into the kitchen, allowing them to shape imperfect modaks, grind coconut, fold leaves and listen to the stories attached to each preparation helps ensure that these practices continue beyond a single generation. When Ganpati returns each year, keeping these traditions alive means ensuring that younger generations do not simply enjoy the festive meal, but learn how and why it is prepared. In doing so, Ganesh Chaturthi can continue to pass its culinary knowledge, family memories and cultural traditions from one generation to the next.

(The writer is Secretary, Cuisine India Society)

Sweeten your Ganesh Chaturthi

TEAM AGENDA

Modaks carry a rather deep history, originally chosen by Lord Ganesha himself to symbolise pure insight. No Ganesh Chaturthi celebration feels complete without them. These days modern twists are popping up everywhere — rich dark chocolate, sweet mango, pistachio. But making them at home, hands dusted in rice flour, carries something a shop can't sell you. Chef Vividh Patil from Sofitel Mumbai BKC has provided some brilliant recipes to try out. Gathering the family to handcraft these delicacies together brings such joy, culminating in offering a little sweet piece to Ganesha. May this festival bring abundant blessings.



PISTACHIO MANGO MODAK

Ingredients:
● 250g White chocolate
● 40g Pistachio paste
● 20g Cocoa butter
Filling:
● 120g Mango purée
● 150g White chocolate
● 50ml Cream
● 15g Butter
● 5ml Lime juice

Method:
● Temper white chocolate, pistachio paste, and cocoa butter; coat moulds.
● Emulsify warmed purée, cream, white chocolate, butter, and lime.
● Cool, fill shells, seal, and garnish.

A decadent mix of smooth hazelnut praline and crispy feuilletine, encased in a rugged, stone-glazed dark chocolate shell



CHOCOLATE CRUNCH HAZELNUT MODAK

Ingredients:
● 250g Dark chocolate,
● 20g Cocoa butter
Filling:
● 150g Hazelnut praline
● 100g Milk chocolate
● 40ml Cream,
● 15g Butter

Crunch:
● 60g Feuilletine
● 80g Milk chocolate
● 40g Praline
● 30g Hazelnuts
Method:
● Coat moulds with tempered dark chocolate.
● Emulsify warmed cream, milk chocolate, praline, and butter.
● Mix crunch ingredients.
● Layer filling and crunch inside shells, seal, and apply an uneven chocolate glaze.

DARK CHOCOLATE RASPBERRY MODAK

Ingredients:
● 250g Dark chocolate
● 25g Cocoa butter
Filling:
● 100g Raspberry purée,
● 150g White chocolate,
● 50ml Cream
● 15g Butter
● 30g Fresh raspberries

Method:
● Temper chocolate with cocoa butter; coat moulds.
● Emulsify warmed purée, cream, white chocolate, butter, and berries.
● Chill, pipe into shells, seal, and garnish.

Intense dark chocolate with a naturally tart raspberry centre, offering a refined balance of richness and acidity



Tridoshic diet: Eating through Ritu Sandhi



GYANESHWAR DAYAL

September marks Ritu Sandhi in Ayurveda — the seasonal joint between monsoon and winter, when all three doshas destabilise together.

Lingering monsoon damp aggravates Kapha, the season's first dry winds stir Vata, and bursts of “Indian summer” heat spike Pitta. The goal is simple: keep Agni (digestive fire) steady with meals that are warm, light, moderately moist, and built around sweet, bitter, and astringent tastes.

Grains: Old basmati rice balances all three doshas at once. Barley dries out residual Kapha dampness and cools the body. Wheat and oats work best warm and soft — porridge or soft chapatis — to soothe Vata without adding weight.
Lentils: Mung dal is the tri-

doshic staple — cooling, light, and gas-free when spiced well. Red lentils (masoor) are equally gentle on digestion.

Vegetables: Gourds — bottle, ridge, ash — are cooling, hydrating, and easy to digest. Pumpkin and sweet potato ground Vata and Pitta. Cooked spinach or methi, finished with ghee, supply the bitter taste Pitta needs without upsetting Vata.

Fruits: Stay with sweet, ripe choices. Pomegranate balances Pitta, stewed apple with cinnamon settles Vata and Kapha, and ripe papaya

As seasons shift, Ayurveda recommends eating to steady digestion and balance the body through Ritu Sandhi



nudges sluggish digestion along. Skip sour fruit for now.

Fats & spices: Ghee is September's MVP, cooling Pitta, oiling Vata's dryness, and — in moderation — leaving Kapha undisturbed. Turmeric, cumin, coriander, fennel, and a little ginger keep digestion moving without overheating the body.

Avoid: Fried and fermented foods (stale curd, idli batter), red meat, sour and spicy foods (chillies, vinegar, tomatoes, citrus), and ice-cold drinks — all of which clog the channels (Srotas) and aggravate Pitta and Kapha.

Golden rules: Eat only freshly cooked meals; left-overs breed Ama (toxins) during seasonal shifts. Sip CCF tea — equal parts cumin, coriander, and fennel — through the day to keep digestion balanced across all three doshas.

Lord Ganesha's Mouse Wishes Only for Him

AMMA (SRI MATA AMRITANANDAMAYI DEVI)

Lord Ganesha has the whole universe in His belly. What does the big stomach symbolise? The true seeker's unappeasable hunger to know the Truth. Ganesha's big ears represent shraddha, the capacity of a sadhak to hear, that is to imbibe, the subtle spiritual principles.

An elephant can uproot a huge tree with its trunk, and it can also pick up a small needle. So Ganesha's trunk signifies the sadhak's ability to grasp both the gross and the subtle principles. Ganesha's mouse first represents desire. Just as one small mouse can destroy an entire crop, a single desire can destroy all our virtues. But a Self-realised soul has complete mastery over the mind and desires. That is why Ganesha rides on a mouse.

At other times, the mouse sits at the feet of Ganesha, gazing intently at the Lord's face, without touching the sweets that surround Him. This means that a Self-realised soul is the Lord of his own mind; his mind will only move at his command. Most of us are like the mouse who chases after every crumb of food we come across. Our minds are not focused on the Divine. How do we attain that same state of stillness where even a massive pile of laddus does not tempt us away from the Lord? What we need is full-time devotion. To pray for the fulfillment of a particular desire is part-time devotion. What we need is the love and devotion for God that leads to Supreme Love.

Full-time devotion is to be constantly aware that it is God who makes us do everything. In this way, we can discard the sense of 'I,' which is rooted in the body-mind-intellect plane, and experience ourselves as the



Ammamata Amritanandamayi Devi feeds Lakshmi, the Ashram elephant, in Amritapuri

THE LORD DOES NOT
NEED THE LIGHT OF THE
OIL LAMP
WE HAVE SPENT TEN
RUPEES TO LIGHT. GOD
HAS NOTHING TO GAIN
FROM US

all-pervading Consciousness.

This does not mean we should stay away from temples. There is a beautiful reverence in expressing our devotion to God while praying there. The money we offer symbolises our devotion; it helps us to cultivate the attitude of surrender. Furthermore, the atmosphere is purified by the pujas, prayers, and peace of others.

Our very eyesight is a gift from God. The Lord does not need the light of the oil lamp we have spent ten rupees to light. God has nothing to gain from us. When we take refuge in the Divine, we are the ones who benefit from it.

Ultimately, to progress on the spiritual path, our only wish should be to love God. That is all we truly

need. We should see God in everything. It is God who has given us the power to pray. If God's power were absent, we wouldn't even be able to lift a finger.

When we lose the 'I,' all that remains is 'Thou, God.' The insignificant identity 'I' must be discarded. True devotion is the awareness, "You are all! You make us do everything!" In this way we attain everything, after which there is nothing left to wish for.

(Sri Mata Amritanandamayi Devi, known simply as Amma, is a spiritual master and humanitarian who has given her darshan in the form of a motherly embrace to more than 4 crore people. Listening to the cries of the suffering, Amma leads the Mata Amritanandamayi Math, an NGO that reaches across more than 50 countries, working in the areas of healthcare, disaster relief, education, gender equality, and environmental restoration)



SANCTUM
POWERED BY DAIV BHAKTI

SADHGURU

Many people believe that being in rage is a solution. Rage is not really a solution. Rage is just the tool for an uninvolved person to act. When one has no sense of involvement, rage can propel action. When many aspects of life which are neglected for a long time finally spin out of control, we feel helpless and go into rage.

Whenever we face an injustice in society, we are told to become outraged, because most people are so lethargic and insensitive that they cannot act unless you set fire to them. It takes tremendous energy to be in rage.

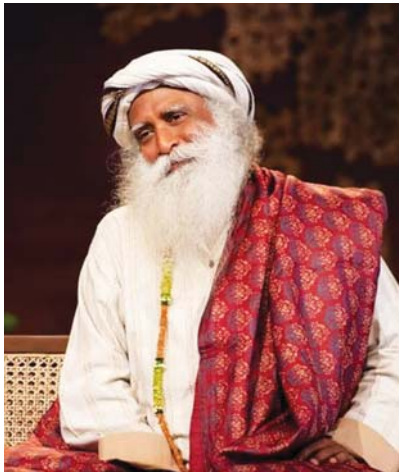
Growing up, I was simply angry with everything. Unlike today, when youth is

concerned with career and finances, revolution was the main thing for me in those days. As a youth, I also read Che Guevara, who was a revolutionary and a phenomenon in the 50s and 60s. Today many people do not know who he is, but still many young people are wearing his t-shirts — don't think they are all revolutionaries! When I asked a young man

with Che's image on his t-shirt, he thought it was Bob Marley.

Che went on to say, "If you are in rage, you are one of us." I am saying, "If you are out of rage, you are one with everything." The moment you are angry with someone or something, you go against it. It is only a matter of time and resource before you will want to destroy it.

If you act out of rage, for one injustice, you will cause another injustice. Maybe you can get some things done with this rage. Seeing your anger, suddenly the government may act out of fear that you



will burn something on the street. But anger simply means you are burning yourself. Burning a bus or whatever else, is just an expression of that.

Medically it can be proven, by seeing your blood-work and other parameters, that in just five minutes of anger, you are actually chemically poisoning yourself. And as long as negative emotions are a part of your system, you will somehow convince yourself with some reason or philosophy, to vent it upon the world. That is what is happening right now — people are doing the most horrendous things with a clear conscience, because they truly believe they are fulfilling the Divine Will.

There is a certain intense force and passion which happens when you are raging in anger. But with the same intensity, if you can sit here with a calm mind, miraculous things can be done. Look at it this way: is human intelligence the solution, or is just blind passion the solution?

The difference is just this. To be in rage, you do not have to be conscious. To see how to remain out of rage, you have to be conscious. Once you are conscious, you are inclusive. Once you are inclusive, you are a solution.

This is why in Isha Yoga, the approach

is: "I am willing to change." This is a tremendous revolution — a silent revolution. Without shouting any slogans, without slaughtering people, without throwing stones at each other — very quietly, the world will change. That is the only way wellbeing will come into society, because there is really no such thing as "society." There are just individual human beings. If you know how to be well within yourself, this wellness will grow into a society. If you are sick person, how will you make a society well? You will only spread your sickness, nothing else will happen.

Instead of addressing the individual human being, attempting to change society, will just bring more empty rules and morality. The world is already full of the highest morals, but the world has not become clean — because of morality, the world has become filthy.

Now, those who talk about India being consumed in rage, have obviously never travelled outside the country. This is one of the only places left on the planet where people can do and say what they want. In some places, if you open your mouth in protest, you may end up with a bullet!

We are 1.25 billion people. Yes, we have our share of nutcases, which every nation has. We have our share making irresponsible statements. But why are we making it out as if these statements are the discourse of the nation? Except for a few fringe elements, we have remained a peaceful country because the general ethos is peaceful.

The spiritual basis of this land always made space for acceptance and understanding. India is not a land of persecution, but of debate and dialogue. Let not the limitless possibilities that the sages of this land explored and expounded be lost in religious bigotry and senseless simplistic dogmas.

(Sadhguru is a yogi, mystic and visionary, and a prominent spiritual leader. An author, poet, and internationally-renowned speaker, Sadhguru's wit and piercing logic provoke and widen our perception of life)

Depression and Solution

Stress and depression can darken even the brightest life. But when the outer world becomes too heavy, the inner world needs a deeper anchor. A true spiritual master does more than offer comforting words; he teaches us to rise above circumstances, strengthen our faith, discipline the mind, and discover the peace within

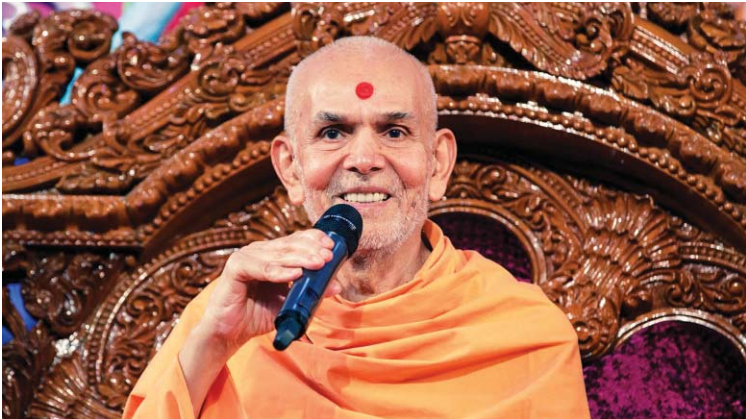
DR. SWAMI GYANANANDDAS

Persistent sadness, pessimism, and a loss of interest or pleasure in usual activities are hallmarks of depression, tension or stress. It is a frequent and significant mental health disease. It's more than just the ups and downs of life, and it can seriously impair the regular functioning of life.

It is very easy to identify a person with this disease. Feelings of worthlessness or guilt, inability to focus, suicidal ideation, and changes in eating and sleeping habits are only some of the signs of this disease. Depression affects people of all ages and all walks of life around the world. More than 264 million individuals around the world suffer from depression, according to estimates. Indeterminate genetic, biochemical, environmental, and psychological variables are thought to contribute to the development of depression. It has far-reaching consequences, impacting not only a person's mental health but also their physical health, their relationships, and their general quality of life. It can cause problems in one's personal life, as well as in one's professional and academic life.

We often believe that wealth, name and fame will free us from stress. However, in this modern era, the majority of wealthy people have the comfort and facilities and yet deep down they feel disturbed, stressed and frustrated. Of course, success sometimes brings even greater pressure when we are not vigilant. The more we achieve, the more carefully we must learn to handle its demands; otherwise, it causes imbalance in our lives.

Michael Joseph Jackson was an American singer, songwriter, dancer, and philanthropist. Known as the 'King of Pop', he is regarded as one of the most significant cultural figures of the 20th century. Michael Jackson won 13 Grammy Awards, including 8 for the album Thriller. Jackson was inducted into the Rock & Roll Hall of Fame twice: in 1997 as a member of the Jackson 5 and in 2001 for his solo career. He had millions of fans around the world. He had a magnetic charis-



ma that attracted men, women and children of all communities and classes. At a young age, he was at the top of his fame, record-selling albums, lavish living and success. But inside, he was alone, depressed and stressed. In his loneliness, that inner pain haunted him. As a result, he started to rely on drugs or surgery to kill the pain. But the depression won and the award winner lost. Michel Jackson took an overdose of drugs and killed himself. In this way, individuals' mental health has taken a hit due to the stress of keeping up with all of our achievements. In order to effectively treat and prevent depression, it is essential to understand the specific obstacles that modern life presents. We must foster a culture where true human connections, self-care, and a life well-lived are prioritized over material achievement. We can start combating the modern sickness of depression and making the world a happier and more compassionate place if we promote a culture that values emotional wellness.

Thus, the cause of depression is very clear; 'we are chasing after physical wealth, neglecting our inner wealth. Moreover, our standard of happiness is based on these material things, which are unstable and perishable. So, how can they provide us with stability?'

Mahant Swami Maharaj states: "Not only the craving for present sense pleasures, but also overthinking about the future keeps us under constant stress. We pay too much attention to things

that are beyond our control. Secondly, we think too much about other people and their opinions. All of these things can bring disaster into our lives."

Swamiji further says, "Rather than thinking that we have got this human body to get a good job and earn lots of money, we should think that we are primarily here to attain inner peace, and the source of that peace is God."

On 23 August 1988, Carlos Vega, a 62-year-old American, went to meet Pramukh Swami Maharaj in Los Angeles. On meeting Swamishri, Carlos said that you experience peace like no other. He then said that he had everything: cars, money and a beautiful home, but no inner peace. Swamishri interrupted him and said, "I have no money; I have God. When you have God, you have everything."

Nonetheless, sometimes, even when we walk on the path of God, we may face difficulties and setbacks. But remember, God has his master plan. He knows where our destination is and will take us there. When we learn to see the bigger picture, we often realize that whatever happened to us ultimately had a purpose. Even the setbacks, failures, and disappointments that once seemed painful helped us grow, strengthened our character, and prepared us to face life with greater courage and wisdom.

(Dr Swami Gyanananddas is a dedicated follower of the Swaminarayan tradition and has earned a PhD from MS University)

The Wisdom Behind The Form of Ganesha

GURUDEV SRI SRI RAVI SHANKAR

Our ancient Rishis were deeply intelligent. They chose to express Divinity through symbols rather than words. Words and their meanings can change with time, but symbols remain eternal. They carry a meaning that can be understood by people from all walks of life, across generations. The form of Lord Ganesha is one such symbol.

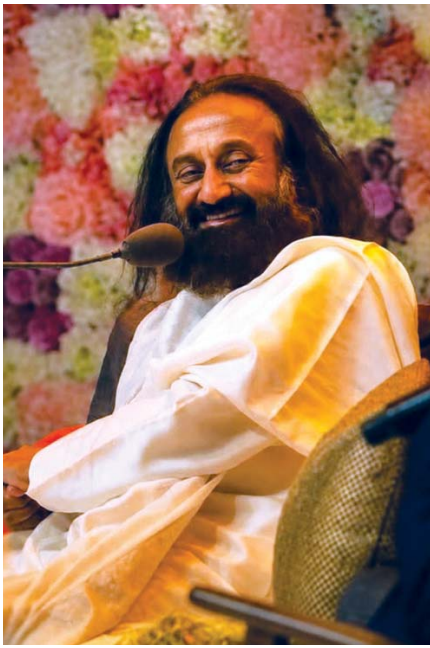
Adi Shankara has beautifully described the divine form of Ganesha. He said that Ganesha is 'Ajam Nirvikalpam Niraakaaramekam', the one who is unborn, attributeless, and formless. He is 'Achintya', 'Aykata', and 'Ananta', that is, one beyond thought, beyond expression, and eternal. None is more beautiful than Him, and He is present everywhere. Yet this formless consciousness is given a distinct form that embodies divine qualities. When we worship Lord Ganesha, the qualities that he represents get kindled within us.

The most striking part of Ganesha's form is his elephant head. It represents authority, endurance, enthusiasm, strength, and courage. There is something effortless about the way an elephant moves. It doesn't stop before an obstacle or look for a way around it. It simply removes the obstacle and keeps moving ahead. The elephant therefore also represents wisdom and effortlessness. When we keep our attention on these qualities, they become alive in us. This is the purpose of symbolism.

Ganesha energy is said to be present in the Mooladhara, the first of the chakras or energy centers, that represents the qualities of enthusiasm, courage, and strength. This is where the spiritual journey begins. When it is activated, one experiences enthusiasm in life; when dormant, one experiences dullness and inertia. When we face obstacles, feel low on energy, or lose clarity, we must turn our attention to Ganesha. By invoking the Ganesha aspect of divinity, we regain courage, confidence, and the spirit to face the obstacles. Once we get ready to face the obstacles, we win half the battle. So Lord Ganesha gives us the energy to overcome the obstacles. That's why we call him 'Vighnaharta', the remover of obstacles.

Ganesha is worshipped before all the other deities at the start of any ritual. Only after duly honouring Ganesha can we proceed with a new undertaking. It is a divine armour that helps us overcome obstacles and move forward with ease.

The elephant's enormous head also symbolizes knowledge and wisdom. It represents 'Gyaan Shakti' and 'Karma Shakti', the power of knowing and the



power of acting. Knowledge that remains only in the mind has limited value. It has to find expression in action.

True enlightenment isn't only about knowing something. It is also about putting that knowledge into action. Wisdom is meaningful when it is integrated with life.

Then there is the single tusk. Ganesha has only one tusk, 'ekadantaya'. It represents one-pointedness, one consciousness. The mind has a natural tendency to move in many directions. It gathers thoughts, doubts, desires, and fears. When the mind is scattered, it cannot see clearly. One-pointedness brings the mind back to this moment, and everything that is not necessary falls away.

Ganesha's large belly represents generosity and total acceptance. Life brings pleasant experiences as well as difficult ones. Acceptance allows us to remain centered in both these situations. But Ganesha doesn't have a large belly alone. There's a snake around his waist. This represents acceptance with awareness. This distinction is important. Acceptance doesn't mean becoming passive or careless. It must come with alertness.

Most surprising is Ganesha's vehicle, which is a tiny mouse. Naturally, a question arises in the mind: how is it that such a huge elephant rides a tiny mouse? Isn't that cruel?

The mouse represents 'logic' and 'the knowledge of the Self', and over it sits the symbol of 'supreme knowledge' that is Ganesha. Logic has its place. It helps us understand, question, and examine. But there is a

dimension of knowledge that goes beyond logic. The mouse carries Ganesha, suggesting that the smaller instrument of logic can serve the larger field of wisdom.

There is also another beautiful image associated with the mouse. It nibbles away at the ropes of ignorance that bind us. The mouse in some ways also represents the mantras. A mantra can gradually cut through layers of ignorance and free us from what keeps us bound.

Ganesha also holds the Paasha, or noose, and the Ankusha, the goad. The Ankusha represents awakening, while the Paasha represents control. Inner awakening releases tremendous energy. But energy without direction can go haywire. Awakening therefore has to be accompanied by control. It isn't enough to become more energetic or more aware. We also need the ability to guide that energy in the right direction.

The modak in Ganesha's hands represents the attainment of ultimate bliss. It points to the sweetness that comes with deeper knowledge. The raised hand represents protection that gives a message to the devotee that the devotee is taken care of. The lowered and open hand represents endless giving. It also reminds us that, ultimately, everything returns to the earth. Ganesha is also associated with the lotus, which is a symbol of sensitivity. Sensitivity isn't a weakness. It is the ability to remain aware of what is happening within and around us. Wisdom without sensitivity can become dry. Strength without sensitivity can become harsh.

The deeper purpose of this symbolism isn't to make us stop at the idol. Ganesha is the formless Divinity encapsulated in a magnificent form for the ease of our understanding. When we worship Ganesha, the qualities represented by the form are kindled within us.

We bring home Ganapati with a sense of joy and gratitude as if a loving family member had arrived. We start planning for the decorations, invitations, and making special Prasad. We offer God his favourite things; share our innermost feelings and desires; we sing and dance. At the end of the day, we are excited to go back home from work as if someone very special is waiting for us. The devotee feels the presence of Ganesha in his house and soaks in this presence. And after the celebrations, we immerse the idol by inviting the Lord back into the abode of our heart.

The ritual of immersing (visarjan) the idols after a few days of worship reinforces the understanding that God is not in the idol; He is inside us.